

Odyssey From Outremer

By

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**For the countless warriors left behind and forgotten
in the aftermath of history's endless wars.**

Author's Note

The term **Outremer** is derived from the French for *overseas*. It was used to describe the four Roman Catholic realms; the County of Edessa, the Principality of Antioch, the County of Tripoli and the Kingdom of Jerusalem; collectively referred to, by historians, as the Crusader States. Established in 1098, they existed until 1291. These Lands of Outremer consisted of the modern-day Israel, Palestine, the West Bank, the Gaza Strip, Syria, south-east Turkey and Lebanon. *Odyssey From Outremer* is the story of two men who survived the last battle in the series of conflicts that came to be known as The Crusades. Often viewed as independent events, these eight military actions to recapture Jerusalem were, in fact, part of a series of conflicts resulting from events taking place as early as the seventh century.

In 631 A. D. Egypt, Palestine, Syria, Asia Minor, North Africa, Spain, France and Italy, along with the islands of Sicily, Sardinia and Corsica were all Christian territories. They were all part of the still functional Roman Empire, whose official religion was orthodox Christianity. There were also large Christian communities outside the boundaries of the empire, including Arabia, that while not orthodox Catholic, were still considered Christian.

The beginning of Islam is dated from 610 A. D. when Muhammad received his first revelation from the Angel Gabriel. Due to the rapid growth of Islam and resulting military action, by 732 A. D., Christians had lost Egypt, Palestine, Syria, North Africa, Spain, most of Asia Minor, and southern France. Italy and the Italian islands were under threat. The Christian communities on the Arabian Peninsula were overcome around 633 A. D. and all Christians and Jews were driven from the peninsula. Within a century a full two-thirds of the formerly Christian world was in Muslim hands. Aided by the confusion resulting from the collapse of the Roman Empire, the conquest of Europe by Muslim forces appeared to be eminent.

In an attempt to protect Christian lands, a series of popes became involved in directing the defense of their territory in the late tenth and nearly eleventh century. Pope Urban II's speech at Clermont in 1095 is credited with inspiring French forces to embark on what is historically known as the First Crusade. This initial endeavor, in some ways more successful than any of the following incursions, was able to capture the city of Jerusalem, and leave it in Christian hands; however, the issue of safety for pilgrims wishing to visit the holy sights persisted.

Despite the efforts of armed groups of western pilgrims, traveling in the Holy Land remained perilous. In 1119 a group of French Knights banded together to serve as an armed force to ensure pilgrims safety.

Their original name, The Poor Fellow-Soldiers of Christ and the Temple of Jerusalem was shortened to The Poor Knighthood of the Temple and eventually **The Templars**. In the one hundred and eighty-eight years between their founding in 1119 until their suppression and dissolution in 1307, the Templars grew to become one of the richest and most powerful organizations in Medieval Europe. Even in their own time, the Templars were considered legendary figures who were not only the best equipped and most fearsome warriors on the field of battle but were also rich and influential landholders and bankers with sufficient funds to finance wars and pay kings' ransoms. They counted among their friends (and eventually enemies) kings, queens, patriarchs and popes.

Among their many innovations was the development of a network of banks that allowed pilgrims and other travelers to deposit funds at a Templar castle near their homes and cash a check for their funds at far-away castles with a Templar treasury. Though the life-span of the Templar organization was relatively short in historic terms, their legacy of ideals and innovations have lived on in the form of subsequent organizations for millennia.

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Chapter 1

May 12, 1291

Acre, Kingdom of Jerusalem

When they reached the top of the tower's spiral staircase, Charles and Gregory were gasping for breath. The humid air in the tower reeked of death. The smells of battle drifting in through the arrow slits and open doors. The odor of sweat, the sickening, sweet smell of blood and the rotting stench of gut wounds.

Charles leaned his back against the stone wall, his breath ragged, his once white surcoat striped with blood, almost the same color as the embroidered cross on his chest. His ears rang from the constant crash of catapult stones hammering the castle walls. The siege had been raging for days and yet it seemed like an eternity. A rasping breath came from behind him.

"Still alive?" Gregory smiled, his voice, hoarse but steady.

"What are you grinning about?"

"I was just thinking, these godless infidels won't get away from us this time."

"Get away?" Charles asked. "Why would they want to get away when they have outnumbered ten to one?"

"Well, after all these years, we finally get to fight them without chasing them through the desert," Gregory answered, his blue eyes sparkling.

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Charles started to speak, stopped, smiled and shook his head. He looked away. 'This is how my friend copes with anxiety,' he thought. Before battle some men quietly stare off into the distance, some shake, others vomit. Gregory copes with humor. His reason to smile, the opportunity to take as many of the Mamluk with him as possible. Looking back at Gregory he smiled and nodded.

Leaning their backs against the wall, they took off their helmets, arming caps and gloves. Charles ran his hand through his short brown hair and brushed sand from his long beard. The sweat running down Gregory's face made lines in the soot and dirt that covered him. His blond hair, caked with dust and sand was darkened to a murky brown. It stuck to his forehead. His blue eyes still held a familiar gleam.

In the stifling air each breath took effort. Their padded gambesons under their chainmail hauberks added to the ordeal. While their armor provided protection and would stop the force of most blades and arrows, it was heavy and oppressively hot.

From years of experience, they both knew that Outremer was a cruel land with seemingly endless ways of killing. Aside from battle, there was scorching heat, exotic illness, infections, poisonous snakes, spiders and scorpions. They both knew of men who had died in battle and when they were being prepared for burial, had no obvious sign of injury. Some knights had darkly joked that these men may have simply given up, losing the desire to live under those conditions.

Turning to look at his companion, Charles saw Gregory looking back at him, eyebrows raised, nodding at the helmet that Charles held against his chest. Neither spoke. The old warning still amused. Brother Benignus is watching! Charles thought of the number of times he had seen their armory instructor yelling at one of his students who had removed his helmet during training. "Are you tired of living?" Benignus would scream. "Does that lucky fool with a crossbow need yet another target? If a stray shot can kill the king of the English, it can certainly kill you!"

More often than not, the yelling was accompanied by well-timed blows to an uncovered head from Benignus' ever-present oak baton.

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As they stood catching their breath, the sounds of battle drifted in through the doorways and arrow slits; shouted orders, screams of pain, curses in several languages. There was the frequent sound of crushing explosions as the massive stones flung by Arab catapults hit the castle, sending vibrations through the stone walls. Along with the rock strikes there was the distant rhythm of hammers, picks and chisels striking stone as the Mamluk miners worked to undermine the castle walls.

In their hearts, both men knew that the siege would end this day. End in defeat. Miners had breached the walls in several places and the enemy was pouring in. The city was falling and hundreds would die. The noblemen who might be held for ransom had fled the city by sea, days ago. Some women, the young and the fit would be taken as slaves but Charles, Gregory and any remaining members of their Order would be slaughtered. The Arabs and their Mamluk, slave warriors, had a special hatred for the Order and never took them prisoner.

Both looked back to the doors they guarded. A curse in Kipchak echoed up the stairwell. More Mamluks. Gregory looked over his shoulder as they both replaced their arming caps and helmets.

“At least they’ll be coming through the doors one at a time.”

Charles turned back to the staircase, raising his sword.

“Make them pay.”

“You too.” Gregory snarled.

Charles saw the tip of a scimitar, as a Mamluk reached the top of the stairs. He waited. When he saw more of the arm holding the sword, he swung his heavy broad-sword down and to the left. The sharp blade hit the man's arm midway between the elbow and wrist. It went through the leather guard and his arm without slowing down. The scimitar rang against the staircase wall. It clanged against the stones as it bounced down the steps along with a hand and forearm still clutching it. The Mamluk screamed in pain. Falling backwards, he grasped what remained of his arm. Blood sprayed his companions and the staircase walls. A man behind him pulled him back out of the way and leapt forward hoping to enter the room, where he could swing his scimitar effectively. At the top

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step he met Charles' extended broadsword, which drove through his leather chest plate, his lung and protruded from his back. Charles placed his boot on the man's chest and kicked him back down the stairs pulling his sword free with both hands.

Stepping back, Charles heard the dull clang of metal on metal. Out of the corner of his eye saw Gregory falling toward him. A mace had caught the side of Gregory's helmet. Dropping his sword, he collapsed. Charles saw him lying unconscious, quivering. Without thinking Charles stepped over him standing with one boot on either side. Swinging his sword wildly from side to side, keeping the Mamluks at bay. They continued to rush through both doors. Charles continued to kill them. He yelled Gregory's name and screamed oaths at the attackers in Arabic and French.

Over the sound of battle, he heard the shatter of cracking stone. First the stone floor split, then it dropped and with it, Charles, Gregory and the Mamluks plunged into the abyss as the tower vanished from beneath their feet.

Chapter 2

June 1341

Hillside overlooking the Dead Sea, Mamluk Sultanate of Egypt

Charles awoke to the sound of his name. His body tensed before his mind caught up. A reflex. It was the instinct of one who had spent decades never truly sleeping. The blazing sunlight filtered through the sparse branches of the scrub bush above him, casting a jagged shadow across the rocky hillside. Disoriented, for a moment, he listened. The steady sound of water lapping against the shore. The cry of a distant bird. The faint jingling of a pack animal's harness. The voice was familiar. Turning his head, he responded, "I dreamt I lost you."

Gregory, crouched beside him, smirked. "And yet here I am."

Charles took a deep breath and sat up. His throat dry, his back aching from the hard ground. He rubbed his eyes and followed Gregory's gaze down the slope.

The road snaked along the shoreline, a well-worn path beside a lifeless sea. They had long ago decided that the name Dead Sea was fitting – nothing lived in those briny waters, no fish, no plants. Only stillness and the stench of decay.

Gregory nodded toward the road. "I've been watching those men on burros."

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Charles squinted in the bright sun light. He saw travelers plodding along in single file, heads bent avoiding the glare of the sun.

“And?”

“It’s not them that I have been watching.”

Charles followed Gregory’s line of sight. At first, he saw nothing but the jagged rocks along the water’s edge. Then, movement. The flicker of a shadow where there should be none.

Gregory nodded. “Three men. They’ve been crouched behind those boulders for some time.”

Charles’ jaw tightened. “Ambush.”

“That’s my guess.”

Charles sighed and nodded his head. “We should stop this.”

Gregory smiled. “Imagine, after all these years, saving pilgrims. Feels almost prophetic, doesn’t it?”

Charles snorted. “As I remember it, we weren’t sent to Outremer to gather firewood.”

Gregory stood, gripping his axe. “Shall we put these to better use?”

Charles eyed the woodcutting tool. “I’d rather have a sword.”

“As would I,” Gregory admitted, “but I doubt that they will wait for us to unpack our burros to get to our swords. I’m sure an axe will serve our needs.”

Charles exhaled and nodded. “Axes it is.”

They moved swiftly but carefully picking their way through the loose shale on the hillside. The sun glared off the water, forcing them to shade their eyes. The humid air was thick with the briny stink of the sea. As they neared the road, Charles suddenly stopped, grimacing he stood on one foot.

Gregory turned to look back at him. “What now?”

“Rock in my sandal.” Charles snorted, balancing on one foot trying to shake the stone loose.

Gregory shook his head and rolled his eyes. “Perhaps we can work on your wardrobe after we prevent a murder?”

Charles nodded, slipped his sandal back on and hurried after him.

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By the time they reached the road, the travelers were close. The lead rider, was an older man, dressed in a long black cone-shaped tunic with a hood and long sleeves. He noticed Charles and Gregory and reined in his burro. His companions did the same. They murmured among themselves in hushed voices. Suspicion on every face, they studied the strangers standing in their path.

Before Charles could speak, movement from the side drew his attention.

The would-be ambushers had stepped from behind their hiding place.

Three men. Young, lean and predatory. The tallest carried an ancient gladius, its blade tarnished, the edge chipped. Another gripped a small knife; the kind used for cutting fruit and dates. The third appeared younger. He was unarmed and his stance spoke of uncertainty.

The first gestured with his sword and sneered. "Back away and live, old men," he called in Arabic. "These three are ours."

Charles and Gregory said nothing. They stood back-to-back, hands at their sides, their axes hidden behind their tunics.

The one with the sword stepped forward and scowled. "Did you hear me old man? Or are you deaf as well as stupid?"

His companion with the paring knife moved around toward the travelers. The burros brayed nervously, sensing the tension.

Gregory exhaled, a faint smile on his lips.

Charles watched the man with the gladius. He could see in his eyes a false bravado, the need to prove himself.

When the young man raised his sword over his head, Charles moved. The axe came from behind his leg, arching upward and then down. The swordsman had little time to react. He lifted his battered weapon to meet the descending steel, but it was too late, the impact shattered the blade. The axe didn't stop. It sank deep into the base of his neck. A spray of red. A strangled sound.

The young man collapsed, his lifeblood soaking into the sand on the road.

Charles leaned back to pull the axe free but winced as pain flared in his lower back.

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Gregory had already turned, advancing on the other two. Wide-eyed the youngest of the three was already running. As the one with the knife ran toward the travelers, he swung his knife in front of him as if to sweep them out of his way. They moved, but as he ran past, he was able to nick the older man on the arm.

Gregory sighed, lowering his axe. "They always run."

Charles still grimacing, pressed his hand to the small of his back.

"Are you hit?" Gregory asked, glancing at him.

"No," Charles muttered, trying to stand up straight. "Pulled something."

Gregory chuckled. "Old age is our worst enemy."

Charles exhaled through his nose. "Tell that to him," he said, nudging the corpse at his feet.

The travelers, still clutching their reins had already started backing away.

"They're afraid of us," Gregory observed.

Charles took a step toward them. "Wait, we mean you no harm."

They didn't stop.

Charles tried again, this time in French. "We are not your enemies."

Still, they backed away.

Then, Charles took a breath and spoke in Latin. "*Introibo ad altare Dei.*"

The lead traveler halted, eyes widening. He hesitated, then called back, voice uncertain. "*Ad Deum qui laetificat juventutem meam.*"

Gregory smiled. "Ah a priest."

The traveler stepped forward cautiously. "You are not Arabs?" he said in Latin.

"No," Charles said, "We are Franks."

The man studied them, frowning. "What are you doing here?"

Charles exchanged glances with Gregory.

"We have been here," Charles said simply, "Along time."

The priest narrowed his eyes. "How long?"

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“We arrived in the year of our Lord 1289.”

Charles nodded.

The priest took a step toward them. “Whom do you serve?”

Gregory smiled wryly. “That, Father, is a complicated question.”

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June 1341

Shore of the Dead Sea, Mamluk Sultanate of Egypt

"We are slaves," said Gregory. The priest looked puzzled.

"How could you be slaves, who is your master?"

"The Sultan of Schobach. We cut and gather firwood for his household and castle," said Gregory, looking back at Charles.

"Where did you come from?"

"We came to Outremer as members of the *Pauvres Chevaliers du Temple*, The Poor Knights of the Temple," added Charles. "I am from Chalon. I am a Burgundian. This is Gregory of Toulouse, in the Province of Languedoc. From where do you travel?"

"I come from Suchem in the diocese of Paterborn. I am Ludolphus, rector of the parish church. My companions and I have been on pilgrimage here in the Holy Land for nearly five years."

Ludolphus stared at Charles and Gregory. He started to speak, then stopped. "You are Templars?"

Gregory nodded, "We are. Does that trouble you?"

Ludolphus raised his eyebrows. "No, but that explains your speaking Latin. There is much I want to ask you; much I would like to know."

"We will have time to talk," interrupted Charles. "For now, we should not linger here in the open, in case the two who escaped

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go for help. These people are obsessed with the need to avenge every unpleasant thing that happens to them, even when it is the result of their own stupidity.”

Gregory smiled. “Call your companions and wait here. I will go back up the hill to get our animals and wood. We’ll lead you to a safe location where we can better defend ourselves.”

Charles looked at Ludolphus. “There is blood on your arm. Are you cut?”

Pulling up his sleeve, the priest looked at his arm and shook his head.

“It is a shallow scratch. It has stopped bleeding already.”

“Be careful with it,” Gregory responded, “In this land small cuts can turn bad quickly.”

Turning to Charles he smiled. “Remain here my brother and rest your old, sore back while I get our belongings.”

Charles slowly walked to a large rock where he sat and leaned on his axe handle. Father Ludolphus walked down the road to gathered his young, traveling companions. They returned to the rock where Charles sat waiting. Ludolphus pointed to the taller of the boys, dressed in a finely-made green tunic with a braided cord at the waist.

“This is Stephan, the second son of our town's magistrate.” Turning, to the other boy who was wearing a plain cotton garment with a rope belt, he added,

“This is Nicholas, an orphan that our parish has taken in to serve as an acolyte. They are my traveling companions on this pilgrimage to the Holy Land.”

Charles nodded. Nicholas looked back, a hint of a smile, a nod, a look of acknowledgment. Stephen stared in silence, boredom, perhaps smug disdain.

Charles turned to Ludolphus. “Your companions look quite pale. Are they not feeling well?”

“I believe the sight of you slaying that man has distressed them,” the priest exclaimed. “I am sure that none of us have never seen a man killed before.”

Charles looked toward the body of the would-be robber and then to the priest's companions.

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“Violent death is always shocking. You should take solace in the fact that he did not have the opportunity to do the same to you. While you are here staring at his body, he is elsewhere, explaining to his god, how an old man, that he threatened, nearly cut him in half. I would guess that he is still surprised!” Shaking his head, he turned away, quietly adding, “It was all so unnecessary!”

Gregory approached with the burro loaded with bundles of wood.

“Are you able to walk, old man, or need I strap you to one of our pack animals?” Gregory called out.

Charles smiled as he stood up and started to walk. Ludolphus and the two boys fell in behind him, leading their burros. As they proceeded, the priest came forward to walk with the knights. His companions followed at a distance. For a moment, they walked in silence. Gregory turned to the priest.

“You said you had much to tell us?”

“I do. I hardly know where to begin. What do you know of your order?” the priest asked.

“We have heard nothing,” answered Charles. “The last we saw of any of our brothers was so many years ago.”

“Decades ago,” Gregory added, “when Acre fell.”

“Acre? Acre fell fifty years ago,” said Ludolphus.

“Yes” added Charles, “followed by Jaffa, Tyre, Sidon and Ascalon.”

“Yet you survived? We were told that all of the defenders of Acre were slain.”

“Most, but not all,” said Charles.

Turning away from the priest, he looked at Gregory, a question in his eyes. Gregory gave a subtle nod. It was alright to tell the priest of the events of that August day, a half century ago. Charles began as they walked.

Chapter 4

May 28,1291

Templar Fortress, Acre, Kingdom of Jerusalem

Acre, that Spring of 1291, was the last breath of hope for the Crusader Kingdom. It stood like a great beast at bay, battered but unbroken. Considered to be the most formidable castle in all of Outremer, it was situated along the eastern shore of the sea. We used to joke among ourselves, that Castle Acre had the deepest moat in all of Christendom. It was well-maintained with double walls, and twelve towers. The main fortress for our Templar Order was on the south-west corner. It was by far, the strongest defensive position in the city. Its entrance was protected by two imposing towers. The walls were twenty-eight feet-thick. Our Order was considered by Arabs and Christians, to be the most formidable fighting force in all of Outremer. The massive armies of Arabs and Mamluks had long dreamt of destroying Acre and driving us into the sea.

Preparations for the assaults had begun a year earlier under the leadership of Sultan Kalavun. It was continued after his death, by his successor, al-Ashraf Khalil. Their strategy was simple. Pound the walls to rubble with throwing machines, create breaches by undermining the walls and towers and then overwhelm us with superior numbers. They had two massive catapults, named The Victorious and The Furious, that had been disassembled and transported one hundred twenty-five miles from Crac des

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Chevaliers to Acre in a convoy of one hundred wagons. When their massive rocks hit the castle walls the stone beneath our feet shook. When a stone missed the walls and hit the interior it destroyed everything and everyone in its path. Our smaller catapults, answered back with speed and stubborn resolve, but from the beginning it was evident that this siege would be partly a contest of throwing machines.

The Muslim army had encircled Acre. Their tents pitched just out of catapult range looked like a black fog that carpeted the desert. We were however, able to control the sea. It allowed us to receive food and some last-minute reinforcements from Cyprus. The ships that brought us supplies were used to evacuate some of the women, children and elderly. Despite our best efforts, the battle came down to a war of attrition.

By the sixteenth day of May the outer walls had been breached in several places and had to be abandoned. On the day of the final assault, the streets ran red. The air was choked with the sickening sweet smell of blood and the rot of corpses that no one had time to bury. Looking inward from our position on the parapet of the outer wall, we could see the grim mayhem. In the streets and open courtyards there were men, women and children who had mistimed their dash from one building to another and were caught in the open during the flights of arrows and stones that the Arabs sent over the castle walls between attacks. During one bombardment a large stone missed the wall and flew over it hitting a wooden cart in the castle courtyard. The cart shattered killing the driver and the ox that had been pulling it. Wood splinters flying from the cart impaled men and women who had been standing nearby. In other parts of the courtyard people lay dead, arrows protruding from their heads and shoulders. Others lay wounded; many screaming in pain, trying to drag themselves to safety. The dead were the fortunate ones. There was no help for the wounded. They called out to us, some begging for help; others begging to be put out of their misery. We did not have the time to help them or the will to end their suffering.

Looking west, beyond this vision of Hell, we could see the tranquil, unconcerned beauty of the sea. Facing east beyond the

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castle walls, we saw the massive army coming for us. There were so many bodies in motion, it looked as if the desert sand was flowing toward us like waves of an incoming tide.

Noon of that day found the two of us on the walkway atop the castle wall with our brother knights and the Grand Master, Guillaume de Beaujeu. We struggled to catch our breath in the stifling heat. We had just successfully repelled another all-out assault on our section of the wall. We were exhaust. Some of us kept watch for the next attack. Others took silent inventory of our losses – attending to the wounded with reverent care and moving the dead into the shade. Many of the men from both groups were our close friends. All of them were our brothers. We worked in silence; knew for certain that there would be more assaults that day. Grieving would have to wait its turn.

After the wounded and dead had been attended to there was time for the squires to bring us water and dry bread. We drank to replenish the moisture lost to the scorching heat. Few of us could manage to eat. For a while it was quiet. Quiet, but the kind of silence that trembles just before a storm.

Gregory and I and the more experienced knights sensed that something was different. Usually during the time between full out assaults the air was full of rocks thrown from a distance by mangonels and trebuchets. Not this time.

I remember saying to Gregory what was on every mind,
“No stones!”

“Perhaps they have run out,” he responded, smiling.

“In this land there is one thing you will never run short of and that is rocks!” I replied. “It could mean they are coming back very soon.”

“Most likely,” answered Gregory, looking around at our fellow defenders.

Those not on watch sought any patch of shade that they could find. Most took off their helmets and arming caps to wipe the perspiration from their heads. Merciless heat made wearing the helmet and cap a miserable experience, but a necessity when arrows, bolts and lances seemed to be coming from every direction. All kept their helmets close by, remembering the wrath of our arms

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instructor, Brother Benignus who admonished anyone he caught without a helmet by smacking them on the head with his heavy, oak baton. At the time, I remember thinking that on a day like this even he might have forgiven us.

A few talked quietly. Most were silent. Master Guillaume walked the length of the wall speaking softly to the men, praising those who had fought exceptionally well and offering what solace and encouragement he could to the rest. All voices went silent when our rest was interrupted. In the distance, we heard the sound of the Saracen drums beating. Quietly at first, growing progressively louder as the drummers and troops drew near. The noise brought us to our feet, helmets back on. Approaching the wall, we carefully looked through the crenels, along the top of the wall, prepared to move behind the solid merlons, at any sign of flights of arrows coming in our direction. Large formations of Saracen troops could be seen marching toward the walls, carrying siege ladders to replace those destroyed in the last assault. As they drew closer, the drum beats filled the air, creating the anxiety in us that it was designed to instill. In the thickness of the humid air, we could feel the drum beats in our chests and stomachs. While the knights on the wall checked their equipment the sergeants and squires quickly distributed more arrows to the archers, more bolts to the crossbow men and more of the long, forked wooden poles that we used to push the ladders away from the walls.

Gregory and I were again stationed on either side of the Grand Master. We tried to maintain the appearance of calm and order, but the frustration and exhaustion was taking its toll on us as well. We knew that this attack would be like all the others. The Arabs would attempt to scale the wall and overwhelm us, while we worked to prevent them from reaching the top. We would push their siege ladders away, and drop large stones on them and shoot them with arrows and crossbow bolts. Those who managed to reach the top of the wall were confronted by heavily armored knights, covered from head to foot in heavy chainmail, wearing steel helmets, and armed with long, sharp broadswords.

While our defensive strategy most often proved successful, at this point in the long siege the advantage was being decided by

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numbers. A limited and steadily decreasing cohort of knights and sergeants was being worn down by a seemingly-endless supply of attackers. In each successive assault, we lost men that we could not replace. In addition to the rising death toll, we had an increasing number of gravely wounded knights who would normally be taken out of action to receive medical attention. Now they insisted on being allowed to remain on duty as long as they could draw breath. Their degree of bravery, dedication and self-sacrifice was lost on no one.

Our hopelessness was given a voice. It came from a young knight standing beside us. His eyes red from the blowing sand, his face smeared with sweat and dust, he turned to Gregory and cried, “We’re winning every battle, but losing the war! This is like trying to turn back the ocean’s tide with a bucket.” No one responded. We all knew he was right.

The next attack began just as the others had. Shortly before the ladders reached the base of the walls, flights of arrows, shot high in the air, rained strait down on our position. Any unprotected part of a defender’s body was vulnerable. We all felt arrows bounce off our helmets and many of us had arrows stuck harmlessly in our chainmail.

The barrage was mercifully short and as soon as the last arrow landed, dozens of ladders were placed against the walls. Swarms of Arabs and Mamluks began to climb as quickly as possible. We liked to wait until the attackers were half way up the ladder, before using the long poles to shove it out from the wall. It would fall backwards onto the sea of bodies below. Most of the time it killed those who had been climbing as well as many of those waiting below. Pushing the poles was exhausting and dangerous. It took four of us to shove one loaded ladder. All the while we were trying to avoid being hit by arrows from above or lances thrown from below. Exhausted though we were, we successfully continued to push back wave after wave.

After an hour, the inevitable happened. Even the most skilled and disciplined knights have their breaking point. As the walls on the north-east edge of the castle began to fail and crumble under the constant barrage from the throwing machines, the masses

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of Arab and Mamluk warriors came pouring in as if a dam had burst. For every Arab that we killed, three more came forward to take his place. Grand Master Beaujeu saw that the attackers had breached the outer wall and were overwhelming our forces. He ordered us to fall back and reform. As Beaujeu raised his sword to signal a counter attack, a Mamluk lance struck him under his right arm. He dropped his sword and fell backward. Blood pumped down his white tunic, running along the protruding shaft. Gregory caught the Master as he fell back. I bent over to grab his feet. We knew that it was better not to try to remove the lance, but to carry him to medical help as quickly as possible. As we struggled getting our leader down the stairs and across the courtyard to the Templar Fortress, our eyes met. There was no need to speak. We both knew that the wound was fatal. An artery had been severed and there was no way to stop the bleeding. As we burst through the door of the entry hall that now served as The Temple's emergency medical area, we were met by the surgeon. He confirmed our fears. Our Grand Master was in excruciating pain. Gregory and I stood by his side as the surgeon removed the lance. Beaujeu looked at us with a sad smile on his lips and calmly told us, "Return to the wall, they need your help there more than I do."

He was right. There was nothing more we could do for him. Choking back heart-wrenching sadness, we turned and rushed out the door to return to the wall. We had not gone halfway across the courtyard to the staircase leading up to the battlement, before we were met by the surviving members of our unit. The wall had been overrun and the only safe place to mount a defense was in The Temple. Watching on all sides, we led the survivors to the fortress and locked the massive doors behind us. In the short time it had taken us to return with the other survivors, Grand Master, Guillaume of Beaujeu had bled out. Looking around the main hallway, we saw a sea of blank faces. For many it was finally too much to bear. Several went and sat on the floor with their backs against the stone walls. Many quietly wept.

That evening the remaining knights and sergeants were called together in the Temple's main hall. It was a quiet, somber gathering. Exhausted men sat on the floor, backs against the wall.

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Some closed their eyes. Others stared ahead at nothing. Like the rest of the assembled knights, Gregory and I were exhausted. It had been a long day of fierce fighting. We were hungry, covered in dirt, stone chips and blood; profoundly saddened by the loss of our Grand Master. Guillaume de Beaujeu had been well liked and universally respected. No one in the hall commented on our situation. We all understood that finding a replacement of equal quality would be difficult under any circumstances and especially challenging given our current situation.

Among those present in the hall that evening we recognized Thibaud Gaudin, who served as both the Commander of the Land of Jerusalem and the Treasurer of The Templar Order. Standing next to him was Pierre de Sevry, the Marshal of the Order. Like all Templar officers, they were both men of impressive size and intense presence. Neither Gregory nor I had occasion to work directly with either Gaudin or Sevry, but we both had overheard others quietly questioning both men's characters and leadership abilities. We knew, in our hearts, that Gaudin might not be our best choice, but neither of us objected when the vote was taken and he was elected to be the Templar's twenty-second Grand Master. As we looked around the hall at the faces of the battered remnants of our Order, it was obvious that all were aware that our time was limited. The odds were insurmountable. Most felt that the man who led us in these final hours might not really matter."

Chapter 5

June 1341

Road south of the Dead Sea, Mamluk Sultinate of Egypt

Nicholas, who was following behind and listening to the story gasped. “That must have been terrifying!” Ludolphus, Gregory and Charles stopped and looked around. Ludolphus snarled. “This is none of your concern. Mind your manners.” Nicholas turned red in the face and lowered his eyes.

“I apologize for my acolyte’s impertinent behavior.”

Steven smiled. Gregory reached over and patted Nicholas on the shoulder. “It’s alright, don’t worry about it. We are not offended.”

The priest turned back to Charles. “What did you do then”?

They began walking again. Looking off in the distance, Charles continued.

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Templar Fortress, Acre, Kingdom of Jerusalem

“Before dawn the following day, Marshal Sevry summoned us without explanation. Along with two other brothers, we reported to his quarters. Sevry announced that he had a critical assignment for us. He led us to a stone ramp leading to a vault directly below

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the Temple's main hall. We knew of the secret, tunnel that connected the Temple to the port of Acre, 350 meters to the east. We had heard that it was occasionally used to move supplies and even horses from the port to our fortress undetected. None of the four of us had ever had occasion to go down there before. At the bottom of the ramp, we entered a large room with high stone walls. The air in the room was damp, musty, like the stale breath of secrets long held. The walls on either side of the chamber had torches resting in metal brackets bolted to the stone. The ceiling was black with soot. Against the far wall were four large chests and two tall, wooden crates. The chests were made of metal with iron straps riveted to the edges and corners. Each had a large brass lock. Both wooden crates were nailed shut.

Brother Sevry walked across the room to a wooden door framed with heavy, metal straps. He unlocked the door and swung it open, leaving it to rest against the wall.

"Use those long poles and place one through the two, metal loops on each side of the chests. One chest at a time. They are heavy. It will take one of you on each corner!" We quickly realized that he had not exaggerated. Once we lifted the chest, each of us placed the end of the pole on our shoulder. Sevry turned to the door and walked through ordering us to follow.

We found ourselves in a semicircular tunnel with a curved stone ceiling tall enough to accommodate a man on horseback. At first glance it looked very much like the underside of an archway except that this stricture went on as far as the eye could see. Every hundred paces, a torch in a metal bracket flickered like a pulse.

As we carried the chests through the cavern, I wondered why the Marshal had assigned only four men to this task. More help would have made this process easier and much faster. Looking at Gregory, I could see that he also was puzzled by the arrangement. The air in the tunnel hung with the cold breath of stone and centuries damp with the scent of secrets. We could still hear the faint explosions of stones pulverizing the outer walls, but we could no longer hear the screams and shouts of battle. After weeks of fighting, under the merciless sun, in full armor, the cool air in the tunnel was a comfortable change.

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Severy noticed the surprised look on our faces. “This tunnel extends from directly under our Temple, to the dock. With the outer walls breached, it is the only safe way to move these chests and crates to our ship.”

We dutifully nodded, and continued to carry our heavy cargo. As our group proceeded, the salty smell of the sea breeze grew stronger. Turning a last corner we saw another steel-reinforced wooden door. It was open, and guarded by four more Templars. Through the doorway, we could see the harbor, the dock and a Templar cargo ship. It was also guarded by armed knights. At dockside, Severy instructed us to leave the chest and return with the long poles to bring back the next three chests and then the two crates. As we removed the poles and started back through the cavern, we saw crewmen from the ship swung a stout, wooden lifting crane over the side of the ship to hoist the chest on board.

Quickly as we could, we made the trips back and forth through the tunnel with the remaining chests and crates. On the last trip one of the other knights wondered aloud why the Marshal had not assigned more men to this activity. Gregory suggested that it was quite likely that the fewer people who knew about this process and this tunnel, the better. We nodded in agreement, but continued to wonder.

Upon our arrival with the last crate, we were greeted, dockside, by our new Grand Master, Thibaud Gaudin. Nearby stood several groups of merchants and noblemen, accompanied by their wives and families. They had elected not to leave Acre earlier and were now imploring, begging, trying to bribe the Grand Master to take them and their loved ones away from the collapsing city. There was no doubt in anyone’s mind as to the horrors that awaited these men, women and children at the hands of the Saracens and Mamluks.

As we stood watching, the Grand Master ignored their cries of desperation. It was like the people making them were really not there. Master Gaudin turned his back on the families and announced to us that he was sailing to find reinforcements and would return as soon as possible. He added that it would be our responsibility to hold off the invaders until he returned. Without further explanation,

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he ordered the two knights who had helped us to proceed to guard one of The Temples towers. Gregory and I were ordered to secure the other one.

For a moment, we all stood in silent shock. We knew that there was no possibility of our holding any part of the fortress for any length of time. If the Grand Master were to return the next day with reinforcements it would still be too late. Listening to him, I viewed the things he said as insulting. He was clearly lying. Did he considered us to be stupid, gullible or was he just counting on our blind loyalty? I could not help wondering, but like the others, I kept my thoughts to myself. Ours was not an order that encouraged the questioning of commands.

As the Grand Master was speaking to us, we could hear the desperate groups of men, women and children still trying to get his attention. They continued begging to be taken away on this ship. We all knew that they were, in reality, begging for their lives. The men looked exhausted. The women stared through red, blood-shot eyes that rained tears down their cheeks. The ragged children crying softly, ghostlike. Every person standing on that dock knew with certainty that rape and murder or slavery awaited anyone left behind.

The four of us watched in silence, looking at each other and then back at the scene before us. We dared not comment, but there was no need. We knew each other's thoughts. Before us stood the new leader of our centuries-old organization, established to protect pilgrims in the Holy Land. He was now willing to leave fellow Christians to face a horrible end, without so much as any effort to help or even console them. In silent disgust, we turned back toward the door and started our march to oblivion.

On the way through the tunnel, Gregory mentioned the accounts we had all heard, as new arrivals in the Holy Land, concerning the slaughter that had occurred in Acre on this date exactly one hundred years ago. Older Templars called it the Massacre of Ayyadieh. They said that it took place after the Christian Armies led by Richard of England captured Acre in August of 1191. Anxious to proceed with his goal of liberating Jerusalem, Richard was unable to come to an agreement with the

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Arab leader, Saladin, concerning a ransom to be paid for the release of two thousand, six hundred Muslim prisoners. Believing that he had no other choice, Richard had them all beheaded within sight of Saladin's army. Gregory and I knew from both Christian and Arab sources that the horror of this slaughter was still fresh in the minds of all Muslims. We also knew that no better outcome for any of us could be expected after a Muslim victory. Reality hung over our heads, like an anvil on a string. We silently plodded on toward the waiting towers, mourning a cause that no longer recognized itself."

Chapter 6

June 1341

Traveling east on the Dead Sea Road

“What of Gaudin and the ship,” asked Ludolphus. “Did he ever return?”

“No but there was really no point,” said Gregory. “Acre fell later that afternoon.”

“What was in those chests?” asked Nicholas. Spinning around, Ludolphus raised his hand and reached for the boy and shouted,

“Don’t interrupt. How many times do I have to warn you?” Before he could make contact, Gregory stepped between the priest and Nicholas. It was not the first time that Gregory had seen a priest strike a child. When he was young and served as an altar boy in his home parish in Toulouse, he had seen several other boys being slapped across the face for one minor offense or another. He clearly remembered that on more than one occasion, he too had been the recipient of a priest’s anger or frustration. He had not appreciated the abuse as a child and cared for it even less as an adult.

Backing down, Ludolphus looked toward Charles and then back at Gregory. Seeing no support from either knight, he chose to change topics.

“Do you know what they contained?” he meekly asked.

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“No, we don’t. The chests were locked and we never saw what they held.” said Charles.

“Could it have been the Order’s Treasury?”

“It may have been.”

“Do you know of their destination?”

“We have no idea,” said Gregory. “They may have gone to a secure Templar castle or possibly to Cyprus, Sidon or Crete where they would be safe. It was not our place to ask and they gave us no hint of their intentions.”

Gregory looked puzzled. “Why do you ask? After fifty years, why would anyone care?”

Ludolphus looked somewhat taken aback. “Possibly because no one seems to know what happened to the Templar treasures. Legend has it that eighteen ships of the Templar Fleet disappeared the night before The Order was suppressed and the holdings of many of the Templar treasuries were ever found. It remains a mystery. Few think that the timing of those events were coincidental.”

“That is a mystery to us also,” replied Charles. Gregory nodded his head. Ludolphus studied them for a moment.

“So, after they sailed, you went to the tower?” he continued.

“Yes, and while the tower was being attacked that afternoon, it collapsed into the sea taking us and our attackers with it. Unbeknownst to us, miners had been tunneling under the walls of the tower for over a week and that day it finally collapsed. By some miracle, Charles and I were thrown free of the rubble and survived our fall only be pulled out of the water by our attackers.”

“Yet you survived,” Ludolphus mused.

Gregory looked off in the distance thinking of that day. He continued.

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Templar Fortress, Acre, Kingdom of Jerusalem

“Yes, even as I tell you of that day, fifty years ago, I find it hard to believe. So many others died. After I lay on the ground, for

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who knows how long, I began to regain consciousness. I was on my side in wet sand, surrounded by tower stones and sections of shattered beams. The last thing I could remember was standing back-to-back with Charles in the tower as Arabs and Mamluks came charging through the doors. I do recalled thinking that this was the end. When I felt something slam the side of my head, the world went black and I fell to the stone floor. I must have still been unconscious when the tower collapsed and I landed in the shallow sea water near the edge of the castle wall. I do not remember falling. The impact on the water possibly saved both of us from serious injury. Being missed by tons of falling stones and wooden beams was pure good fortune. When I opened my eyes, I noticed that my vision was blurry and my head was throbbing. I tried to move and take a deep breath, but only gaged and vomited on the sand. Looking past the puddle of sea water that I had deposited on the beach, I saw Charles lying near me. At first, he did not move. I feared the worst. I tried to reach out to him but my head was spinning. When I touched the right side of my head, I felt a large, very tender area. At first, I thought that perhaps when I had landed in the water, I had struck my head on a rock or the sandy bottom. When my head began to clear, I remembered the blow from the mace that had knocked me unconscious. I was about to call out to Charles when he suddenly took a raspy deep breath and vomited an equally impressive amount of sea water onto the beach between us.

We both stared at each other and the scene around us trying to make sense of what we were seeing. Dead and dying men lay everywhere. Some were partially covered by the large rectangular stones that had been part of the tower. Others, who were broken and twisted by the impact of the long fall and violent landing, lay still, clearly deceased. Two Arab soldiers stood over us, pointing their scimitars. Beyond them, we could see other Arabs and Mamluks walking along the beach, climbing over the rocks and rubble looking for survivors. With cool efficiency, they were dispatching the wounded.

When those soldiers finished their work among the dead and dying, they came back toward the men that had been guarding us.

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“These appear to be the only two that survived unharmed,” one Arab soldier said. “Should we kill them now”?

“Perhaps Allah has other plans for them?” suggested one of our guards, laughing.

“Perhaps Allah hates us and does not think that we have suffered enough,” I responded, in Arabic.

“You speak our language well,” offered the guard.

“We have spoken with your Sultans, often,” said Charles, forcing a smile.

The Arab, who seemed to be in charge of the group, came forward and instructed his men to remove our armor. They took our gambesons and hauberks along with our chain mail and left us wearing our once-white Templar smocks, now covered with wet sand, grime and blood, some of it ours. Our armor was placed in a pile on the sand in front of us, along with our swords and shields. The equipment stacked there reminded me of seeing those same items on the altar of my parish church, left there with me as I prayed, through the night before the morning dubbing ceremony, that would make me a knight.

Looking at Charles, I tried to smile and said,

“Other than being sore everywhere, getting out of that heavy gear has left me more comfortable than I have been in weeks!” Charles looked back and nodded.

The two Arab guards pulled us to our feet and steadied us while we waited for the world to stop spinning. When it appeared that we were able to walk, they led us off through the rubble and mayhem, our hands tied in front of us.

What we witnessed on the walk through the fallen city, was a scene from a hellish nightmare. Old and infirmed men and women were being separated from the others and summarily slaughtered. The same fate met any wounded Christian soldiers. Able-bodied men, suitable for a life of slavery, were gathered together into groups to be marched out of the city where they would be sold to slave traders. Women and younger boys were being raped where they had been found. Their cries and screams of pain and fear echoed off the buildings and remaining castle walls. As we were led past a group of women huddled together awaiting their fate, we

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saw a young woman reach out and grab a soldier's dagger from the scabbard on his belt. She placed the point between her breasts and ran forward into a stone wall. The point of the blade protruded from her back as she collapsed on the ground, her life-blood being absorbed by the sand. For her, the nightmare was over. For the others it was just beginning.

As we approached the Sultan's tent, we saw two groups of soldiers and knights kneeling on the sand, their hands bound in front of them. The first group was made up of Teutonic Knights, Knights of St. Lazarus and Knights of St. Thomas Acon, better known as Hospitallers. The second group consisted of our fellow Knights of the Temple of Solomon. We knew, only too well, that the Saracens and their slave-warriors had a special degree of hatred for all Templars. While some of the knights and noblemen in the first group might possibly be released in exchange for ransom or sold into slavery, the future for Templars was execution. The only question being when.

We were placed with the other Templars kneeling on the hot sand. Looking around the group, we met the blank stares of our brother knights. We took note of those who were bound there with us. Some appeared to be silently praying. Others seemed to be looking through us. We couldn't help thinking of the members of the order who were not there with us. There was no need to wonder about their absence. The heat of the sand and the afternoon sun continued to sap what little energy any of us might have had left. No one spoke.

Without warning, two of the Arab soldiers came from behind us and ordered Charles and me to stand and follow them. We were led to a large black tent. Once inside it took a few minutes for our eyes to adjust to the dimly lit interior, illuminated only by small brass oil lamps. The smell of incense drifted through the air that seemed much cooler than the scorching heat outside.

When we were led into the middle of the tent, we immediately recognized Melot Sapheraph, Sultan of Babylon and Sultan al-Ashraf Khalil son of Kalavun. We had been before these men several times while serving as translators for our previous

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Grand Master. Sultan al-Ashraf Khalil surprised us when he used the traditional Moslem greeting,

“Assalam Alaikum.”

“*Wa alaikum assalam*,” we responded, bowing our heads.

“My men tell me that Allah spared only the two of you when the tower collapsed this day. *Insh ’Allah*, he may have plans for you. He paused for a moment and then continued. While I am pleased to see that you have survived, it does not give me pleasure to see you here today under these circumstances. Clearly the efforts of your Grand Master were not effective.”

“Yes,” said Charles, “It gravely disappointed us and our Grand Master, who was killed yesterday, during the last attack on the wall.”

“I am most sorry to hear of this,” said the Sultan, slowly shaking his head.

“May Allah grant him peace. He was a man of great courage and wisdom.”

Both Charles and I nodded our heads.

“Master Beaujeu took the plan that you had suggested, back to the people of Acre,” said Charles.

“I remember it well. After the mayhem caused by the thousands of new troops that your Pope sent to Acre, that plan was the last hope for peace.”

“Indeed, it was,” said Charles. “The Holy Father’s purpose in sending the mercenary troops across the sea was to help stabilize the situation.”

“They did exactly the opposite,” I said. “Those mercenaries were poorly led and poorly disciplined. They spent their days and nights drinking and brawling in the taverns and houses of ill-repute. When they did venture forth, they did so to rob, plunder and murder the merchants, pilgrims and any Moslems that they found in the city streets. These killings clearly violated the long-standing truce that had been established between the Christian forces and your kingdom.”

“Could your leaders not control their men?” asked al-Ashraf Khalil.

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“Oh, where to begin?” sighed Charles. “From what we learned the Levant has been a crisis of leadership for the Franks, almost from the beginning. While the Pope’s original purpose was to wrest control of the Holy land from the forces of Islam, for many it quickly became an opportunity to gain glory and wealth. From what we had been told, during the early years, Christian progress was aided by infighting among the various Islamic kingdoms, and tribes. As time went on the factions of Christians began to compete among themselves and eventually, they became overtly hostile to each other. Eventually, the Christian forces spent as much time fighting each other as they did fighting your people. Meanwhile the Arab forces were becoming united under stronger leaders such as Saladin.”

“It is true,” I added. “There was constant infighting among the Christian armies and among the various Holy Orders, along with a general lack of discipline and strong leadership. This led to catastrophic military disasters like the overwhelming defeat at the Horns of Hattin.

“I have heard that the Franks did have some strong leaders,” said al-Ashraf Khalil

Charles nodded, “Perhaps the strongest was Richard of England, the one they called the Lion Hearted. He was able to capture the castle of Acre and march on to the walls of Jerusalem.”

“And yet you lost Acre this day one hundred years after you took it from us.”

“We thought that our meeting between you and our Grand Master, might prevent this disaster” I added. “The offer to restore the treaty if every person in Acre paid one Venetian Penny as compensation for their actions, gave us hope. As you may remember, our Grand Master was very pleased by this possibility and promised to meet with the people of Acre to present this option.”

“And he did?”

“Yes,” I said, “He called all of the people of Acre together at the Church of St. Cross, where he spoke of the derision that their constant bickering was having and the danger that it presented to the city. He added that continuing on that path could eventually

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result in a siege and defeat. He implored the people to accept your wise and generous offer and gather a Venetian penny for every person. As witnesses, the two of us were very optimistic. This seemed like a fair compensation and a way to avoid battles that could cost many lives on both sides.”

“But the people would not agree?” asked Melot Sapheraph, shaking his head.

“No,” I said. “Much to our shock and dismay, they reacted with anger and threats. The crowd shouted that the Master of the Templars had betrayed the city and should be put to death! They came forward, toward the front of the church and only stopped when they reached our drawn swords. There was no question that the crowd meant to kill us that night. The three of us backed out the side door and quickly made our way back to The Temple. We knew what this meant for the future of Acre.”

“And so, it has come to pass and we are here today,” said al-Ashraf Khalil looking past us.

“As I said before, we had great admiration for your Master. I also thought highly of the two of you. Unlike most Franks, you took the time to learn our language and understand our culture. Your efforts gave me hope. Unfortunately, there were too few Franks like you.

As our military activities continue, as they must at this point, I will have need of skilled translators that know Arabic and the various languages spoken by the Frankish forces. Are you willing to serve me in that capacity?” he asked.

Charles and I turned to look at each other. Neither of us spoke. We both knew that helping this enemy leader could, save both Christian and Moslem lives and prevent more of the type of battle aftermaths like the one we had witnessed this day. We also knew that the alternative to accepting this offer was our execution. Looking to the Sultan who awaited our answer, we both nodded our heads and simply said, “we are willing.”

Chapter 7

June 1341

Road by the Dead Sea

“You question the Holy Father’s decisions and then you agreed to serve the enemies of Our Lord?” shouted Ludolphus. He took Gregory by surprise. For a moment he was not sure what he was hearing, not sure how to respond. Charles had no such problem. His face turned red. His eyes narrowed. Looking at Ludolphus he snarled.

“The Holy Father may be infallible in matters of faith and morals, but he clearly is not in the area of military leadership. His sending poorly disciplined and poorly led troops significantly contributed to the tensions between Christians and Moslems that directly led to the fall of Acre. Even before the siege began, it got to the point where Templars and Hospitallers were fighting each other on the streets of Acre.”

Stepping forward to within inches of Ludolphus, Charles glared down at the now pail looking priest and growled,

“Do not ever question our loyalty or our courage! Our decision to assist the Sultan as translators was a sincere attempt to minimize the slaughter of men, women and children on both sides.”

The priest, wide-eyed and clearly shaken, uttered what sounded more like noises than words. He then quit trying to talk. There were no more accusations.

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Gregory found his voice. "We agreed to serve our fellow man in any way we could. We wanted to try to stop the madness that had gone on for over two hundred years. We later learned that our brother Templar knights, that had survived the fall of Acre, were taken to Cairo where they were marched through the city in a massive victory parade and then beheaded in front of a cheering crowd."

Ludolphus looked shocked. He took a deep breath as if he were about to speak, but did not. At length, he added in a humble, almost conciliatory tone,

"You must have been relieved to learn that you had been spared!"

"Yes, but with reservations," offered Gregory. "We both suspected that after the conquest of the remaining Christian castles was complete, the Sultan would behead us as well."

"So, the Sultan made use of you as translators?" asked the priest in the quiet tone of one attempting to move away from the tension of his first remarks.

"Yes, when he left Acre, he brought us along as he attacked the remaining Christian fortifications," said Gregory.

Continuing his attempt to change the subject, Ludolphus asked,

"How was it that the two of you came to speak Arabic?"

"We were both educated before we entered the order," said Charles. "Upon admission as Templars, we were directed to learn Arabic so that we might serve as translators. We had both studied Latin and Greek and had some experience with languages, other than our native tongues. As you probably know, all Templars spoke Latin.

We spent several months in the Kingdom of Sicily studying the dialects of Outremer with an Arab speaking scholar."

"Were most of the Templars educated?" asked Ludolphus

"No, very few were able to read or write," answered Gregory.

"Most came from wealthy families where most noblemen considered such skills to be 'unmanly' and left those duties to

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scribes and monks,” added Charles. “Several of our Grand Masters and even some priests were illiterate.”

“Truth be told,” said Gregory, “we were not of much use to the Sultan as translators, since there was very little negotiating to be done. The castles that elected to fight were quickly defeated and then destroyed. Others were abandoned when threatened. In either case, there was little or no conversations that required translation.”

“After the last Christian fortress was captured, we were surprised to learn that the Sultan wanted us to work as woodcutters,” added Charles. “He sent us out with pack animals and guards to gather firewood for cooking and heating his castles and kitchens.”

Ludolphus looked puzzled. “These guards, were they there to protect you from robbers while you cut wood?”

“No, we think they were more to ensure that we didn't escape with the Sultan's tools and animals.” said Gregory smiling.

“But you are alone today,” commented Ludolphus.

“Yes, that was long ago. We have not had a guard for decades. Much has transpired and the Sultan no longer fears for the safety of his livestock,” Charles said smiling.

“Or his children or grandchildren,” added Gregory laughing.

The priest again looked puzzled but felt that this was not the time to pry.

“You mentioned our order,” Charles interjected. “What news of them, father?”

Ludolphus stopped and turned to face the knights. He started to speak and then stopped. He looked at the men and then looked beyond them into the vastness of the rock-strewn desert. Charles and Gregory turned toward each other, silently thinking ‘What now?’

At length, Ludolphus faced them and with a furrowed brow said,

“They are no more!”

Charles and Gregory stared at him in silence.

“Twenty years after the fall of Acre, your order was suppressed.”

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“Suppressed?” Gregory asked.

“Yes, on Friday, the thirteenth day of October 1307, most of the Knights of the Temple were arrested in nearly all of the lands of Christendom. Their leaders were imprisoned. Their property was seized and attempts were made to confiscate their many treasuries, although most of them were never found. As I mentioned, the night before the arrest orders were served, the Templar fleet disappeared. It is thought that the largest treasuries went with them. Trials were held for those captured and the knights were subjected to torture until they confessed.”

“How could this happen?” Gregory asked. “Why did this happen?”

“To what did they confess? asked Charles.

“It started in Paris with King Lewis accusing the knights of the Temple of blasphemy, heresy, denial of Christ, spitting on the cross, worship of idols and sodomy.”

Charles and Gregory looked at each other and then back at the priest.

“That could not be true. In our years with the order, we never saw any of that,” pled Charles.

“How could King Lewis do this? The order was always under the direct protection of the Holy Father and answerable only to him!” added Gregory.

“King Lewis was able to act with the support of the pope!” Ludolphus explained. “Pope Clement V issued the Papal Bull, *Pastoralis Praeeminentiae* in 1307 ordering the arrest of all Templar Knights and the seizure of all of their lands and property.”

“I don't understand,” said Gregory. “We never saw anything like these accusations. You say that brothers of the order confessed to these acts? How many did so?”

“Under torture, most men will eventually break and say anything to stop the pain,” explained Ludolphus, “Your brothers were burned, beaten and broken on the rack. Many were old men, weak and frail, but even the young and strong had limits to what they could endure. Those, weak in character, confessed and testified against their brothers in hopes of not being tortured at all. Several who confessed under torture, later recanted their statements

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and were burned at the stake as relapsed heretics. That was the fate of the last grand master, Jacques de Moley. Moley and Geoffrey of Charney, the Preceptor of Normandy, were taken to an island, of the River Sein in Paris and burned. Some say that Jacques cursed the king and pope with his dying breath and challenged them to meet him before the final judgement of God. That may not be a true story, but it is true that within a year, both King Lewis and the Pope were dead.”

“Torture? How could Templar Knights be tortured? Who did this to them?” Charles cried.

“The Dominican order under the direction of the Holy Father.” said Ludolphus. “The Pope wrote that torture should not be regarded as a punishment, but should be thought of purely as a means of eliciting the truth. Pope Innocent IV issued another Bull, *Ad Extirpanda* in 1252, which authorized the Dominican order to use torture during questioning.”

The group stopped walking. Charles and Gregory slowly turned and walked away toward some large stones on the side of the road. Charles sat on one of the rocks with his elbows on his knees. His hands covered his face.

“Despite what we were originally told, there was apparently no salvation for any of us,” said Gregory.

“At first, we so often wondered when our Order would return to the Holy Land; later, why they never came back. We knew that they assumed we had perished with the others, but still hoped that we could see some of them again one day.”

Charles looked up, his eyes red and blank.

“At first, I wonder if God had blessed us or damned us by letting us live, when so many others did not. As the years passed, I sometimes felt that we had been forgotten by our God and our Order. Eventually, I came to wonder if any of it had been real, if either had ever really existed or were merely things that we remembered from a dream of our youth.”

Gregory walked over and sat on the rock next to Charles. He put his hand on his friend’s shoulder.

“Charles, I often thought that you had doubts about both God and the Order,” he said softly. “Many times, you seemed to

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question the motives of both. You shocked me at first, but after that battle when you refused to participate in the killing of captives and were threatened with separation from the order and later, forced to do penance, I came to wonder if you were not correct in your doubts.”

The two old knights looked at each other for a moment, then turned to see the priest who had walked up behind them and had stopped a short distance away.

“I do not want to impose,” said the priest, but I could not help but overhear what you said. When did you lose your faith, my son?

“It is a long story, father,” said Charles “For now, we need to find our way to safety before dark. We can talk about these matters later.” The knights and the Ludolphus returned to their burros and the priest’s young companions. It was time to travel while there was still light.

Chapter 8

June 1341

Fortress ruins off the Dead Sea Road

Daylight was fading as the knights and pilgrims arrived at a stone structure located on a low hill sitting back from the main road. As they approached, they noticed that it had the look of a small castle. They saw four thick, stone walls with round towers on each corner. Through the hole in the front wall where the double wooden gate once hung, they could see what remained of the interior walls. The roofs of the inner structures were gone, long ago rotted and collapsed.

What was left of the fortress stood, cold vigil to the aspirations of some long-forgotten struggle. The shattered wooden gates and the collapsed section of wall offered testimony to the fate of the last defenders. The old fortress was far enough from the road to go unnoticed by most travelers and looked to be a safe place for the party to spend the night.

As they walked through the gash in the wall, the men looked around as if expecting inhabitants. Skeletons of stone always seem to be watching for intruders. They secured their animals in the baily of the old keep and brought their personal belongings to one of the smaller rooms in the interior. Nicholas fed the animals and brought them water from the cistern near the spring. The water was clear

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and tasty, with no odor of sulfur and no rust coloring. While Nicholas worked, Steven sat off to the side and watched.

The men and boys gathered in the interior room where they would prepare a meager evening meal of tea, dates and bread. Gregory announced that he would build a small fire in the corner of the room where the missing roof would allow the smoke to escape. He asked Steven and Nicholas if they would go to the pack animals to get some kindling for the fire.

“Nicholas will do that”, announced Ludolphus, looking at the boy. Nicholas immediately left the room to fetch the wood from the baily. Steven didn’t budge. When Nicholas returned with both arms full of wood, Gregory smiled and said, “Thank you. That’s more than enough wood. We could burn a castle down with that much.”

“I am sorry,” Nicholas offered, “I didn’t know how much you needed.”

“Don’t worry,” responded Gregory, “it’s better to have too much than too little. Do you know how to build a fire?”

Nicholas shook his head. “No.”

“Would you like to learn?” asked Gregory.

Nicholas nodded.

“Alright, we’ll start with some dry leaves and dried moss from over by the water cistern.”

When Nicholas returned with a fist-full of moss and a bundle of dry leaves, Gregory smiled and said, “that again is more than we need, but if we do decide to burn the place down, we won’t have to make another trip.”

Overhearing the fire-building process, Charles smiled. ‘There is hardly anything that that man can not make entertaining.’ he thought.

Gregory continued showing Nicholas how to place the leaves and moss into a small pile and then cover them with dry twigs.

When they were finished stacking the kindling, Nicholas turned to Gregory and asked, “what do we do now?”

“This is the challenging part,” said Gregory, trying to look serious. “I am going to strike a flint stone with the dull side of my

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knife, so that hot sparks land on the dry material. As I do this you will need to blow softly to provide the fire with enough air to start burning. Do you think you can manage that?"

Nicholas nodded his head. Gregory knelt down and struck the stone with the metal knife. Glowing sparks fell on the dry leaves as Nicholas knelt next to him and very gently blew on the kindling. At first a small puff of smoke drifted upward. As Gregory and Nicholas continued watching, a flicker of flame burst out from the moss and began to spread over the dried wood. Nicholas continued gently blowing. As the fire grew, Gregory reached out and patted Nicholas on the shoulder and said, "Alright that's enough, back up before you set your hair on fire."

Nicholas looked up beaming.

"Excellent work," Gregory said smiling, "We have a fire and thanks to you we will be warm and won't go hungry tonight. In all of my years in this land," he continued, "I have never come to understand how it can go from searing heat in the day to chilling cold once the sun sets."

The others nodded as they gathered around the small fire that cut the darkness and took the edge off the evening's chill. The priest and his companions shared the loaves of bread they carried and the knights provided dried dates and tea to make a simple evening meal. As the group finished their repast, Ludolphus addressed the old men sitting across the fire from him.

"Earlier today you mentioned the Sultan's children and grandchildren. Of whom did you speak?"

Charles and Gregory looked at each other and then at the priest.

"We spoke of our wives and children, who are also the Sultan's children and grandchildren," Charles said.

Ludolphus started to speak, but then stopped. He tried again and finally said,

"You have wives and children? Did the Templar Knights not take vows of poverty and chastity?"

"All did in the beginning of the order," explained Gregory. "Originally all who took the cross, did so for life. By the time we were admitted, many things had changed. There were several,

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different reasons for joining the order and all were not lifetime vows.

“What other reason could there be besides fighting to free the Holy Land from the infidels?” asked Ludolphus.

“Truly, that was a part of the reason for all of us,” said Gregory, “but for some, like me, there was also the desire for adventure and the possibility of opportunities that being the second, third or fourth son of a major land owner did not provide. As you well know, in our lands, only the eldest sons of noblemen and kings inherit the titles and the lands, while their younger brothers serve as substitutes in the event that their older brother is unable to assume that role. My alternative to taking the cross was to live a life of perpetual inconsequence.

Looking across to Charles, Ludolphus asked,

“Was that the case for you also?”

Gregory smiled, but did not comment.

“My situation was somewhat similar,” said Charles, looking to his side at Gregory.

“I was the third of five sons.” As their eyes met, they shared the unspoken sentiment. The exact details of Charles’ decision to join the Army of God were most likely things this priest did not need to know. While looking at the flames of their small fire flicker in the darkness, making their shadows dance on the walls behind them, Gregory thought about the story that Charles had shared only with him.

Chapter 9

Spring, 1285

Chalon, Kingdom of France

As Charles told it, his father, Philippe Dubois, was a land-owning nobleman from Chalon, in the Burgundy Region of the Kingdom of France. His holdings included farmland, a large vineyard and densely-wooded tracts of forest. The lands of Burgundy were well known for their excellent soils and their exceptional wines. Lord Dubois' wife had borne him ten children. Eight of them, five sons and three daughters, had lived to adulthood.

His neighbors on each side were also lords of large manors. They too had cropland and vineyards. The neighbor to the east, Estienne Beauregard, was the father of eight; in his case all daughters. Like all men in those times, the need to have a son to carry on the family name weighed heavily upon him. The unspoken understanding was that he was willing to continue fathering offspring until he had a son, no matter how many wives it took. Like many men of this era, the dangers that his wife faced during and after childbirth never weighed heavily on his mind. It was one of this man's eight daughters that played a role in Charles becoming a Templar Knight.

It was a warm spring afternoon. Young Charles was returning from hunting rabbits in the forest and neighboring fields. Taking a shortcut across the neighbor's land, he was passing one of Beauregard's cold cellars, used for storing wine, hay and root

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vegetables, when he saw Angela, the neighbors fourth-oldest daughter. She was three years his senior. An exceptionally attractive young woman, Angela caught Charles by surprise when she called out his name. Though they had never conversed, Charles like every other young man in the region had admired her beauty. On several occasions he had overheard conversations between his older brothers and other young men concerning Angela's willingness to share her charms.

Being a shy young lad, Charles' experience with women and girls was limited. Other than once kissing a friend's younger sister, it was nonexistent. As Charles stopped and turned upon hearing his name, he saw Angela standing in the open doorway of the cold-cellar.

"You are Charles?" she asked already knowing the answer.

"Yes, I am," he answered, wanting to look at her, but not sure if he should.

"I see that you have been hunting," she added.

Charles nodded his head.

"You should come in here. I have something to show you."

Charles laid his bow, arrows and dead rabbits on the ground outside of the doorway and slowly followed Angela into the dark, cool interior of the semi-underground cellar.

"Close the door behind you," she instructed.

Angela walked to the back of the room near a large pile of loose straw that was used to insulate and protect the aging bottles of wine. Turning around to face Charles she said,

"Come here, I'm not going to bite you!"

Charles walked toward her, not wanting her to think that he was nervous, but absolutely certain that he was. As he stood in front of her, Angela smiled and reached out to take Charles' hand, which she placed on her breast. Wide-eyed, he held her for a moment, gently, as if it might explode and then pulled his hand back. He knew that he was blushing, his face felt hot. Angela was smiling when she said,

"You should join me on this straw."

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Without another word, she turned, pulled her smock over her head and spread it on the straw. Laying on her back, looking up at him she said,

“Take off that tunic and join me, I think you will enjoy this.”

Without thinking, he removed the garment and knelt down on the straw beside her. As he slowly reached out to touch her, the cellar door flew open and he heard a loud scream. Looking over his shoulder, Charles saw a woman of impressive girth and stern demeanor, bellowing the unnecessary question “What is going on here?” One of Angela’s very large matron attendants was filling the doorway.

Seeing that she had been discovered, the lord's daughter suddenly began to cry for help, claiming that she was being assaulted. After a very brief redressing, the matron marched Angela out the door, promising as she left, that the lord’s men would soon be back to arrest young Charles.

Before Charles could reach his home, true to the matron’s word, he was taken into custody and escorted to the office of the town’s constable. There he was detained. Two days later a meeting was called. Those in attendance included Charles, his father, Phillipe Dubois, Angela’s father, Estienne Beauregard, the parish priest and all six members of the town counsel.

There were few in attendance at that hearing, who were not well aware of the young Angela's adventuresome history, but the lord chose to claim that the honor of his daughter was in peril. Few dared challenge the word of a nobleman.

Lord Beauregard’s wish was that Charles be castrated and sent to live out his days in a distant monastery. Upon hearing this, Charles turned a ghostly pale. The room went silent. Finely, one of the town’s councilmen, a long-time friend of Phillipe Dubois, rose to speak in defense of young Charles. He eloquently argued that a more fitting punishment would be to force the guilty young man to take the cross and serve with the Templers defending the Holy Land. All present were aware of the number of Templers that had been killed in Outremer and to most this suggestion sounded like a form of death sentence.

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It was not a novel idea. There were other instances of men being assigned to the service of the Temple as a form of penance for a variety of transgressions. The most well-known case being the four Norman knights in the service of Henry Plantagenet who had murdered the Archbishop of Canterbury, Thomas a Becket. All four were sentenced to serve with the Templars in the Holy Land for fourteen years. It was also widely known that several of those knights were among the many Franks killed at the battle of Hattin, where the forces of Saladin slaughtered the Christian army. For those knights, taking the cross truly was a death sentence.

At first, Angela's father seemed hesitant, but he finally agreed that this would satisfy his families honor as well as his daughter's. Every man in attendance suspected that in his heart, Estienne knew of his daughter's previous adventures, but sought a way to resolve the issue without further embarrassment to the family name.

Looking back, Charles was understandably pleased and relieved. Becoming a Templar was an adventure that he gladly accepted and considered it to be a wonderful alternative to a lifetime spent in Burgundy or a monastery.

Over the years, Charles had shared this motivation for taking the cross with only Gregory and his confessor. Gregory agreed, there was no need for others to know, although he could not help teasing Charles about it. When Charles had told him that he had mentioned the event in the confessional, Gregory asked how that went.

"When you told the priest that you had almost committed a sin, did he almost absolve you and give you almost three Hail Mary's and three Our Fathers for penance?" By that time, Charles was already getting used to his fellow Templar's sense of humor.

Chapter 10

June 1341

Fortress ruins near the Dead Sea Road

Sitting across the small camp fire, Ludolphus looked up at Charles and Gregory.

“I understand now that you could enter the order for limited service, but that does not explain your wives and children.”

“Yes, that is another long story,” said Gregory.

“It will be a long evening,” suggested Ludolphus, “I believe we may have time.”

Charles stared at the fire as Gregory began.

June 1300

Desert oasis, south of the Dead Sea

“In our first years of captivity, Charles and I lived in a stall at the stable on the far side of the Sultan’s castle. Oddly enough, the horse stall that we slept in was very much like the cells that we had lived in at the various castles and monasteries over the years. It was small, but quite comfortable. From there we were sent out to gather wood in the company of one or two armed men. The soldiers that accompanied us were often Mamluks. The Mamluks and the Templars were widely considered to be the most skilled and effective warriors in Outremer and we had a long and storied history of armed conflict. Both groups’ attitudes toward the other

could accurately be described as 'loathing. 'Our guards considered us to be lowly slaves, and viewed the assignment of guarding us to be demeaning. They were also acutely aware of the Sultan's puzzling affection for us infidels. They knew, with certainty, that if harm were to come to us or we managed to escape on their watch, they would pay dearly. Their assignment was to ensure our safety, watch us work and be sure that we did not run off with the Sultan's woodcutting tools and pack animals.

Likewise, neither Charles nor I had any respect for the Mamluks. As Templars we saw ourselves as soldiers; knights who had been forced to become slaves. The Mamluks were slaves who had been forced to become soldiers. Though we never shared these sentiments with our guards, we believed that our life paths and those of their guards were significantly different.

As a result, every woodcutting excursion was pretty much the same. Charles and I walked, each carrying an axe and leading a burro. The soldiers rode horses and watched as the two of us worked. There were no cordial conversations. Though both parties spoke fluent Arabic, Charles and I chose to speak Latin or French to each other and our guards conversed in the language of their home-land; a kingdom somewhere to the north, far-east of the Levant.

About the beginning of our third year in captivity, we began to go wood-cutting with a single guard. This soldier, Abdul Kareem, was a member of the Sultan's personal guard; a young man, about the same age as we were. Unlike the many Mamluks in the Sultan's employ, Abdul was a smaller man of Arab descent. Like most Arab men, Abdul was much shorter than either of us. His eyes were a dark brown, almost black, as was his close-cut hair and trimmed beard. He was educated, intelligent and very pleasant to be with. Unlike the Mamluks, he did not view guarding former Templars as an insult or a form of punishment.

Though he never assisted us in the actual wood-cutting, he did help with camp activities when we were out gathering wood for days at a time. In the evenings, sitting around the fire, we spoke with him of our experiences as children and later as warriors. Like us, Abdul was a good soldier, skilled with the tools of war. Also, like us, he fought out of loyalty to his master and the cause he

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represented. Unlike so many others who took up the sword, none of us took pleasure in the taking of life.

Over time, we talked, laughed and joked with Abdul and became as close to being friends as a guard and his charges could be. Despite this warm interaction, Abdul still accompanied us on horseback, while Charles and I walked and led the pack animals.

It was on one of these wood-gathering ventures that we encountered the women who would eventually become their wives. It happened one evening, during the time of year when the days are short and the sun sets early. There was a nearly-full moon and yet the stars appeared so bright in the sky that they seemed close enough to touch. Normally we would have stopped earlier in the day, but we had found a bountiful supply of wood and had worked longer than usual to cut it all and load it on our pack animals. We were traveling towards an oasis we knew of, to spend the evening, when we heard what sounded like a battle in the distance - loud shouting and the clanging of metal on metal.

At first, we could not determine where the noise was coming from. In the desert, the hills and valleys often make it difficult to identify the direction of sounds. The three of us stopped and quieted our animals in hopes of hearing better. The noise of men shouting, metal clanging and then women screaming drifted towards us, but the direction was still not clear. Finally, I offered to hold the lead-ropes of the burrows and Abdul's horse, while Abdul and Charles ran to the top of the closest knoll to see if they could determine the direction of the sounds.

The skirmish was, it turned out, very close and appeared to be taking place at the oasis we wished to visit. Charles and Abdul ran back down the hill reporting that there seemed to be about ten men involved in some sort of conflict. We quickly secured the animals' halter ropes to some scrub tree branches and hurried in the direction of the oasis. Abdul unsheathed his scimitar. Charles and I took up our wood-cutting axes. As we approached the oasis I said in a whisper, "Be careful my brothers". Charles smiled and nodded. Abdul responded, "*Inshallah*", meaning 'if God is willing. 'It bothered me that evening, as it always did when I would wish an Arab well, and they would dismiss the sentiment as if it were

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meaningless. This, however, was no time to worry about verbal slights, real or imagined. We hurried on in the direction of the commotion.

Despite our urgency, it appeared, at first, that we might already be too late. When we approached the oasis, we saw six men standing in a half circle, facing a woman wearing a fine silk robe. She had positioned herself between them and the camp cooking fire. Beyond the fire, two younger women, also well dressed, hugged each other, and huddled against a large rock. A few feet off to the side, another woman with long, grey hair lay face down in the sand, blood pooled around her head and neck, soaking into her plain cotton garment. Between me, Charles and Abdul and the six men, lay the bodies of four men dressed in the uniform of the Sultan's guards. Their shields and scimitars were scattered in the sand near their twisted and bloody remains. We could see that there were eight horses hobbled in a grassy area at the edge of the oasis and another six tied to nearby bushes.

Our first thought was that the six men were, most likely, deserters from one of the many local armed groups. Whoever they were, they apparently had sufficient military skills to overpower four of the Sultan's guards. The six took no notice of us coming up silently behind them. One of them walked up to the woman near the fire and ripped open her tunic, which fell off her shoulders and hung only by the cord tied around her waist. They could see that she was a woman of exceptional beauty, tall and lean, with dark hair, dark eyes and full, round, breasts. Making no effort to cover herself, she stood looking down, her hands at her sides, seemingly resolved to her fate.

Charles, Abdul and I moved up behind the six as quickly and quietly as we could. At that point the woman looked up at her captors and saw us; two men in plain cotton smocks and a third in the uniform of the Sultan's guard. We made eye contact with her for a moment and wondered if she might betray our presence. As we approached, she looked back at her captors and reached up to cup her breasts in her hands. The six deserters stood mesmerized by her beauty and boldness. Seeing an opportunity, Charles, Abdul and I rushed the men, each of us delivering a fatal blow to the back

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of an armed man whose last thoughts were far from battle. As their companions fell dead in the sand, the remaining three turned to defend themselves. Though well-armed, the men were not as skillful with the tools of war as we were.

Charles and I made short work of our second men while it took a little longer for Abdul to deal with the his. This last deserter lunged at Abdul, who seemed to momentarily loose his footing as he stepped to avoided the thrust. He recovered nicely and dispatched his man with the next swing of his scimitar.

For a moment we stood catching our breath, checking to make sure that all of our enemies were accounted for. Charles asked me if I had been hit. I told him no, I had been bruised, but not cut. We turned to Abdul, who had put the tip of his scimitar in the sand and was leaning on its hilt. His face began to look pale even in the firelight. We asked if he was well.

"Allah was apparently not willing," he said with a crooked smile as he collapsed to his knees. Charles and I rushed to his side.

"Where were you hit?" Charles asked.

"My man got a sword tip under my breastplate," he said. "It is not deep, but the blood flows freely and I am starting to feel very cold."

Abdul dropped his scimitar and fell forward on his hands and knees. I turned him on his back and sat holding his head and shoulders in my lap. He clutched my arm.

"I am sorry to leave you my brothers," he said. "I have come to care for the two of you over the time we have spent together. Now, I am so tired and cold," he said as he closed his eyes for the last time."

Charles and I looked at Abdul and then at each other. I could not remember the number of men that we had seen die or the number of fellow Templers that we had lost in battle over the years, but none seemed as painful as this Arab man's death. We sat there holding Abdul for a while in silence and then gently laid him on the ground.

Looking to my right, I saw the woman, who by then had pulled up her tunic. She was standing near the younger women, next to the rock. When our eyes met, she stepped forward to place herself

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between us and the young women. I walked over to her and stood for a moment. Charles came to stand at my side. The woman looked into our eyes and let the torn sides of her tunic fall off her shoulders, her arms at her sides.

We stood in silence. I remember thinking that I had never seen such a beautiful woman. I doubted that Charles had either. Her dark hair hung to her shoulders in ringlets. Her skin was dark with silk-like smoothness. As we looked at her, we were both speechless and confused.

“I will not resist, if you leave my daughters alone,” she said.

We looked at each other and then back at the half-dressed woman.

“You can have your way with me. Please do not harm my daughters.”

Charles walked around behind the woman, who watched him out of the corner of her eye. He stood behind her. She tensed as he reached down to take hold of the torn corners of her tunic. He lifted the garment and gently covered her shoulders. She reached up and clasped the edges of the tunic and crossed them over her chest. Charles returned to where I stood watching.

“Take care of your daughters while we bury our friend,” Charles said. “He is Islamic and must be put in the ground soon. We will remove the others from this area and then return. You and your daughters have nothing to fear from us.”

He started to turn and then looked back and asked her to add wood to the fire while we are gone.

“Would you also bury our servant?” the woman asked. “She was also a follower of the prophet and our faithful companion for years.”

We nodded and turned away. For the next while, Charles and I spent our time dragging the dead deserters out into the desert and placing the bodies of the Sultan’s soldiers on the side of the oasis opposite the hobbled horses. We then dug two shallow graves on a small rise, for Abdul and the female servant. Though we did not perform the ritualistic cleansing of the bodies, that Islamic tradition dictates, we did lay Abdul and the woman on their right sides, facing east toward the Qibla and covered them with desert

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sand. When we were finished, we returned to the oasis and found the woman and her two daughters sitting against a large rock. Coming forward, we sat down on the opposite side of the fire and looked at them for a moment.

The two young women seemed to be close to the same age and certainly shared their mother's beauty. They stared in silence. It was their mother who spoke.

"Who are you?" she asked. "You fight like soldiers, but you do not appear to be from this country."

"We are not," I said.

"We came here many years ago with the Franks and are currently the property of the Sultan of Karak. I am Gregory and this is Charles. We cut and gather firewood for the Sultan's household and castle."

I went on to explain how we had come to Outremer as Knights of the Temple and how we had been captured at the fall of Acre. The woman looked at her daughters and then back at us as I spoke.

"We know the Sultan," she said. "We know him well. I was one of his wives and these are two of his daughters. I am Nadira, but the Sultan calls me Nahid. These are my daughters, Adiba and Jamcela."

Charles and I looked at each other, confused. We had recognized the uniforms worn by the dead soldiers as being those of the Sultan's guard; similar to the uniform worn by Abdul.

"I know the names Nadira, meaning rare and precious, Adiba, well mannered, and Jamcela, beautiful and graceful, but I have never heard the name Nahid," said Charles.

The woman looked at the ground and quietly said, "It is an old name meaning one with large breasts."

Charles nervously cleared his throat, wrinkled his brow and looked toward me. I quickly changed the subject and asked,

"Why are you here in the desert at night?"

"The guards were taking us to another kingdom. My daughters were being given as a gift of good will to one of the Sultan's allies. The servant that you just buried and I were being sent along to attend the girls."

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“You were sent as a servant?” I asked. “Did you not say that you are the Sultan's wife?”

“I was,” she said. “I am no longer.”

She saw that we were confused.

“In our world,” she explained, “men want sons. Women who give their husbands healthy sons are favored. Women who give them daughters are not. I could not give the Sultan sons. I not only gave him daughters, but twin daughters as you see here. In our culture, female children are considered a burden and bad luck. Twin girls are an especially bad omen. Many believe that twins are the result of the woman lying with more than one man and that they should be killed at birth. Many also believe that a man should abandon or kill a wife who does not give him sons. I have not been able to bear children since the birth of my girls. The Sultan was patient with me for many years, but his patience has run out. He is being merciful by giving his daughters to another ruler and allowing me to live as their servant.”

Charles and I sat listening in amazement. We knew from our time in Outremer that women were not valued, but this was also quite true in many places, including of the world of our youth. We had not been aware that in this land, a father or husband was allowed to simply kill his female family members. We were stunned. Turning back to the woman, I asked,

“Would you have us take you to your destination?”

“We cannot go now,” she cried, looking down at the ground in front of her, tears welling up in her eyes.

“Why not?” Charles asked. “I believe that we can get you there safely!”

“You may get us there alive,” she whimpered, “but not unshamed.”

“Shamed?” I asked. “You were not assaulted by those men. No one need know that they ripped your tunic.”

“That is not the issue. According to Islamic law, a woman must be accompanied by her husband, a male relative, or armed guards at all times. She can never be alone with a man under any circumstances without bringing shame on herself and her family. We will be here tonight with the two of you. Even if you do not so

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much as touch us, we are ruined. The man we are being sent to will not want us now and the Sultan will be advised to have us killed to protect the honor of his household and family. You are looking at three dead women,” she sobbed.

“What can we do?” asked Charles.

“You can flee and leave us here,” she said. “This is your chance to escape and return to your homeland. By the time the Sultan learns of what happened, you can be far away!”

“We cannot leave you here,” I answered. “You would surely die or be captured and sold into slavery.” Turning to Charles I said, “We cannot leave them.” Charles looked back at me and nodded.

Chapter 11

June 1341

Fortress ruins, Mamluk Sultanate of Egypt

For a moment no one spoke. The only sound the crackling of the small fire staring to burn down. Without being asked Nicholas got up walked over the pile of scrub brush and brought more wood for the fire. As the flames brought light back to their corner of the room, Ludolphus turned to Charles and Gregory I too am curious as to why you did not flee. It seems like a perfect chance to regain your freedom.”

“Not at the price of others’ lives,” Gregory responded. “The original purpose of our order was to protect travelers in this land. Besides we had little food or provisions and would most likely have been recaptured and killed if we did not starve to death in the desert.”

“So, what did you do?”

Gregory hesitated, looked at Charles for a moment and then continued.

June 1300

Desert Oasis, south of the Dead Sea

“I brought the burros and Kareem’s horse to the area near the oasis where the other horses were hobbled. After I took the

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saddle off the horse and removed the bundles of brush from the burros, I fed them oats and tied them securely for the night. I joined Charles and went over to the side of the fire across from the three women. They were huddled together near the large rock. Still not convinced they could trust us. We settled in for the night. As we had during our years on campaigns, we took turns sleeping, making sure that one of us was always on guard. Once, when I awoke in the night, I looked across the fire and saw that Nadira and one of her daughters were awake, watching us. I wondered if they slept at all that night.

Just before first light, I arose and walked out into the desert to relieve myself. The morning was clear and cool without a hint of breeze. The sky to the West was glowing with the sun still hidden just below the horizon. The air was full of the songs and calls of desert birds; the soft cooing of the Eurasian Doves and the loud call of Laughing Doves. In the distance I could see a flock of small Arabian Babblers busy pecking the ground looking for insects to eat and grooming themselves and each other. Once, when we had seen this behavior before, Charles had suggested that the Babblers must be very kind and nurturing birds to remove fleas and ticks from their companions. I suggested that they were possibly just helping themselves to tasty insects that happened to be crawling on the other birds in their flock.

As I watched, the bird's chatter suddenly went silent. Looking up I saw an owl slowly drifting overhead on the way to its daytime roost. The moment the owl was out of sight, the bird cacophony resumed. These peaceful few moments in the desert gave me an opportunity to think of last evenings events. It was obvious that we had some choices to make. At the same time, I sensed that there was only one right way to proceed.

When I turned to return to camp I was met by Charles. The thing on both of our minds was what to do with the Sultan's daughters, his former wife and the bodies of his four soldiers. We agreed that the women should be returned to the Sultan's palace along with the eight horses used by their party. In addition, we also had Abdul's horse and those ridden by the six deserters. We agreed that we needed to move quickly and that we could not afford to take

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the time necessary to bury the bodies of the Sultan's guards. As to the remains of the six deserters, we both felt that the desert scavengers were welcome to them.

Both of us were concerned about time. We were in the desert, a half day's ride from the Sultan's castle, with three women, fifteen horses and two burros. There was no question that the deserters that we had slain were not the only men in the desert who would kill to get their hands on these women and the horses. With this in mind, we decided to load all of the weapons and any useful armor from the eleven soldiers onto the horses and return with the woman and her daughters as quickly as possible to the Sultan's castle, Karak des Moabites. When we walked back to the campsite we explained our plan to Nadira, Jamcela and Adiba. We could see the look of concern on each of their faces. Even so, they did not object.

After quickly loading the equipment on the horses and helping the women mount, Charles and I selected two horses from the remaining twelve and rode from the camp site leading a string of riderless horses and the two burros. It was the first time we had been on horseback in years. We both agreed that it felt good to ride again. There were no discussions on the half-day ride to Karak. Several times on the ride we caught the woman and her daughters looking at us. When our eyes met, the daughters looked away. Their mother continued to study us. For good reason, we were all anxious about the fate that might await us.

As you may know, Karak is an ancient city. previously known as "Kir Moab" or "Kir-haraseth." It is mentioned in multiple verses in the Bible, having been besieged by the King of Israel. We had been told that during the Roman and Byzantine eras, the city served as an administrative center. The formidable castle, for which the city became famous, sits on a mountain top nine hundred meters above sea level. Its thick walls and steep surrounding slopes, on three sides, made assaulting the fortification extremely difficult. A deep moat on the fourth side made it impossible to draw siege towers up to the castle walls. The elevated location also afforded its inhabitants a spectacular view. On clear days when one could look

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out across the Dead Sea and beyond to the Mount of Olives bordering Jerusalem.

Construction of Karak Castle, which was initially a Crusader stronghold, began in 1142 and took nearly twenty years to complete. It was strategically located in an area of great importance and was considered to be a critical tool for controlling the Transjordan region.

One of the most notorious rulers in the nearly two-hundred-year history of the Kingdom of Jerusalem, Reynald of Chatillon, ruled Karak in the early 1170's. He was infamous among his contemporaries and despised by the Moslem peoples for breaking treaties, attacking and looting caravans of pilgrims on their way to Mecca and various other acts of barbarism. It was said that one of his favorite pastimes was throwing prisoners from the high walls of Karak Castle onto the rocks below.

In 1177, during a time of truce, negotiated between Saladin, Sultan of Egypt and Syria and Baldwin, King of Jerusalem, Reynald attacked a large caravan slaughtering the travelers and stealing their valuables. The event so enraged Saladin that he launched a massive attack on the Kingdom of Jerusalem which led to the famous Battle of Hattin where the forces of Reynald and the other Christian armies were soundly defeated. Saladin, who was known for his restraint toward his defeated enemies, spared many of the soldiers from the Christian armies, but personally beheaded Reynald of Chatillon. After this historic battle, Saladin turned his attention to Karak Castle which fell after a long siege and remained in Saracin hands from that point on.

During our time as Templars, we had never been to Karak. It was only after our capture that we came to live there and serve the Sultan.

Charles and I began our journey to Karak with the women and livestock shortly after first light. We arrived at the castle gates after midday. We were met by guards at the gate, who looked understandably confused. Charles explained to the captain of the guard that we had a large load of firewood for the Sultan's kitchens and were also returning the survivors of the Sultan's entourage that we had found in the desert. The captain instructed us to wait just

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inside the gate while he sent word to the Sultan. We secured the string of horses and helped the women dismount. The five of us walked to a bench near the castle wall and sat in the shade. No one talked.

It seemed as though we waited for a long time. When the captain finally returned, he instructed the five of us to follow him to the Sultan's court. As we approached the palace, two guards opened the immense, carved wooden doors that were as tall as two men. The interior of the building was noticeably cooler than the outside air. At the far end of a dimly-lit hall, we could see the Sultan sitting on a large, ornate cushion that rested on a raised platform. He was surrounded by a dozen of his advisors who stood on either side of the dais. We slowly walked the length of the lavishly appointed room that had beautiful tile floors and colorful tapestries on every wall. The men gathered around the Sultan interrupted their conversations and turned to look at us. By the time we reached the far end of the hall, the only noise in the room was the sound of our sandals on the tile floor. A guard with a long lance held sideways, stepped forward and stopped us ten paces from the Sultan. It was the first time that Charles and I had been in the presence of Al-Monsure Abu Bar. Years ago, we had translated during negotiations between his grandfather Qulawun-al Malik al Mansur, the Frankish kings and the masters of the Orders. As we mentioned earlier, we also translated for his father, Al-Ashraf Khalil before he began his siege of Acre.

Al-Monsure Abu Bar looked very much like his father and grandfather. He was a handsome, dark-complexioned man, perhaps a few years older than we were. He had dark hair, and a short cut beard and moustache. His intense, dark eyes might have made some feel uneasy were it not for a sense of serene, calmness about his manner. Unlike so many in positions of authority and leadership, when he asked questions, he seemed sincerely interested in the answers.

At first, we did not expect the Sultan to have any idea who we were. To our surprise, he clearly did. He addressed us in Arabic saying that he knew that we were former Knights of the Temple and that he had heard stories of our mission to his father's court during

the final days of the siege on Acre and the assaults on the remaining Christian castles. He added that when he was young, he had heard many tales of our order, and that the Templars were widely considered to be the most-worthy adversaries among the Frankish forces. Charles and I nodded and thanked him for his kind sentiment. He then asked us how we had come to be with his former wife and daughters. Charles explained how this had come to pass and told him of the loss of his soldiers, the deaths of the woman servant and our guard, Abdul Kareem. The Sultan listened and nodded his head, but did not respond. He looked worried and concerned. At length he look at us and said that apparently the passing years had not dulled our fighting skills.

When he finished speaking, one of his advisors, standing to his right, addressed the Sultan, explaining loudly enough for all to hear, that since the women had been in the company of infidels through the night, without proper supervision, they were no longer considered pure. According to Islamic law they should be killed to maintain the honor of the Sultan's house. The Sultan looked down at his hands. He sat silently, almost imperceptibly nodding his head.

Finally, he looked up and ordered all of the guards but one, and all of his advisors to leave. The advisors looked puzzled, but no one spoke and soon the room was empty, but for the five of us, one guard and the Sultan.

"You heard what it is that I should do according to our traditions," he said looking at Charles and me.

We nodded slowly, not knowing what to say.

"As a man and a father," he continued, "I have love for my children and for this woman who was once my wife. As a Moslem, I am obliged to follow Islamic Law and tradition. As infidels you may not understand this, but there is no other way. In our culture, no man of worth would have any of these women after what has transpired. They are no longer honorable."

He looked past us and softly, as if merely thinking aloud, asked,

"What man would have them now?"

Without hesitation, I answered,

"We would."

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The Sultan looked up with a question in his eyes. I glanced to my left, at Charles, who seemed even more shocked than the Sultan. There followed another long silence. I could hear my heart pounding as I considered what I had done. Had I offended al-Monsure Abu Bar? Did the Sultan consider my answer inappropriate or insolent? My mind was racing. The women and Charles remained silent. We all seemed to be holding our breath.

The Sultan looked at the floor, looked back at me for a moment and then back at the floor. He finally looked up again and spoke.

“You are unusual men,” he said. “Many, if not most men, would have fled from captivity to save themselves and taken my horses with them. My soldiers were all dead. There was no one to report your absence. The women would have perished in the desert or been captured and sold into slavery. It could have been many days, even weeks, before anyone knew of your absence and even then, it might have been assumed that you too had perished. And yet you come to the man who holds you as slaves and return all of his property to him safely. I do not always see such loyalty; not even from my own people.”

Charles and I stood in silence, not knowing what, if anything, to say. He looked at us for a moment and then beyond to the three women standing behind us. Nadira and her daughters had not said a word since their arrival. They continued to stand together with their eyes looking at the floor in front of them.

“Though you are worshipers of the cross, you served my father, his father before him and now serve me, in this difficult situation. For your loyalty, this I will offer to you. Take these women as your own and go to your quarters at the stable across the castle grounds. As you know the new stable, near the palace is almost finished. You will have the old structure to yourselves. From this day forward, you will work alone. I see no further need for a guard. I believe that you will not try to escape and you clearly have little need for protection! You may each keep a sword from the weapons that you brought back today. You will continue to provide wood for this castle and the guard posts. You may leave now,” he concluded, and said no more.

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Charles and I looked at each other expecting more, then realizing that he was finished. We backed away until we reached the women. At that point all turned and slowly walked out of the Sultan's presence. Not a word was spoken as we left the palace. We all feared that we might not have heard correctly; were not sure that the woman and her daughters had truly been spared. Could we have misunderstood or might the Sultan change his mind?

Once outside we returned to the pack animals, quickly unloaded the wood and left the weapons and armor we had captured, with the exception of the two swords that we selected.

The five of us were silent as we briskly walked toward the palace gates, half expecting to be called back. As we departed, we turned toward the stables on the far side of the castle. We walked looking straight ahead; Charles and I each leading a burro; the three women following several paces behind.

As we approached the stables Nadira came forward and walked close behind me and Charles. After a while she spoke.

"Will you sell us?" she asked.

We stopped and looked at her and then back at her twin daughters. Charles shook his head from side to side. I responded,

"No, we will not sell you".

"May Allah bless you," she said.

As we walked on, Nadira and her daughters smiled for the first time since we had found them in the desert."

"That is truly an amazing story," said Ludolphus. Looking over at his traveling companions, he could see that they had fallen asleep somewhere during the tale.

"Thank you for telling me of your adventure, it is time for me to get some rest also."

Looking at each other, Charles and Gregory nodded and wished him a sound sleep. There was no need to say any more. They both felt that what they had said was probably enough, if not perhaps, too much.

Chapter 12

June 1341

Desert Oasis, south of the Dead Sea

Though they had never directly discussed the topic, Charles and Gregory both felt that there were some details about their relationship with their wives that they did not need to share with Father Ludolphus.

June 1300

Karak, Sultanate of Egypt

After their meeting with the Sultan, Charles and Gregory led the three women to the stables where they had been living between woodcutting trips. The building was a rectangular, stone structure that had a long central hallway with horse stalls along either side. It had large wooden double doors on each end. Both ends of the building had two large rooms, one on either side of the hallway, that had been used to store tack and feed for the animals. A stall near the feed storage room was used to house the two burrows that carried fire wood. Charles and Gregory had cleaned out two of the horse stalls at the other end of the stable and had been sleeping in them. The two larger rooms at the end near the men's sleeping stalls remained empty. The Sultan's men took all of the

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animals and equipment to the new stables on the other side of the castle as soon as the new structure was completed. The new stable was closer to the palace, at least twice as big as the old one and had room for twice as many horses.

As they approached their building Gregory wondered about the reaction that the women might have when they saw their new abode. The harem quarters were known to be lavishly decorated and beautifully appointed accommodations. Gregory could not think of a more stark contrast in living conditions with the possible exception of camping out under the stars. Both wondered if the women might not reconsider their fate.

As he walked along, Charles was still in shock. He could not help but think of the old joke about the man who awakens in the morning after a night of drinking and gambling to remember that he had won a camel in a dice game the previous evening. After a moment of joy, he suddenly remembers that he knows nothing about camels and has no idea what he should do with the beast.

As members of a religious order that took vows of chastity, it could be truly stated that Gregory and Charles had very little experience with women. The last woman that either of them had conversed with, in years, were their mothers and sisters. They were acutely aware that they knew very little about women, and yet now thanks to the Sultan's mercy, they owned three. Neither had any idea of where to begin.

As the group walked along in silence, Nadira found the knight's nervousness to be entertaining. These two tall, highly trained warriors, who had survived countless battles with calm efficiency, were clearly ill at ease with her and her daughters. Smiling to herself she thought that she had seen men who had encountered a deadly sand viper handle the situation with less anxiety.

Nadira was an intelligent and pragmatic woman who had survived the perils of life in a harem and, just recently, the very real possibility of execution along with her daughters. After being spared by her former husband and informed by the knights that she and her girls would not be sold, she was elated. This was a very

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good day, something that she could not say about many of the previous days in her life.

Life in a harem, was a hyper-competitive and ruthless world of mercenary mothers, cut-throat mistresses, shelved female hostages and calculating eunuchs. All were as vicious as they were ambitious. Harem status was hierarchical with a brutal pecking order, that was often cruel and occasionally deadly. Yet there was a seemingly endless supply of women willing, even eager to be a member of a sultan's harem.

For citizens of a Moslem kingdom, having a daughter who was a member of the sultan's harem was considered a great honor. Nadira's father had presented her to the sultan as soon as she reached puberty. She had been a truly beautiful young girl and had every indication of becoming an equally beautiful woman. She was fortunate that in her sultan's harem women were given a general level of education in literacy and household management and were trained to be good companions both in and outside of the bedroom.

As was the case with members of many harems, Nadira studied music, was instructed in Islamic religious practices and taught to dance. In addition, she was admired for her storytelling skills. The most successful women of any harem had to be as intelligent and capable as possible. They also had to be attractive, fertile and successfully produce male heirs.

When the group arrived at the old stable, neither Nadira, Jamcela nor Adiba reacted. If they were shocked or even surprised by their new accommodations, they displayed no hint of it to their hosts. As it turned out, the lack of creature comforts that the former stable offered them were gladly offset by the freedom and security that life with the former knights offered. Not only did they not miss the constant tension of interacting with dozens of women competing for the sultan's attention, they reveled in the freedom of being allowed to walk through the city market places with the knights as their companions.

Nadira could not help but notice her daughters' fascination with the two tall, handsome men who had saved their lives twice in the first two days of their time together. On their walks through the city and surrounding countryside she noticed Jamcela walking and

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visiting with Charles, while Adiba doing the same with Gregory. She found herself smiling as she noticed the awkward innocence of both her daughters and the men as they became better acquainted. Clearly none of them had experience with this type of interaction. As time went on, she observed the young women sitting close to their companions, looking into their eyes and allowing their hands to gently touch. It was obvious to Nadira and anyone else paying attention that what they were witnessing was two couples in the early stages of serious infatuation. While Charles and Gregory, Adiba and Jamcela were busy falling in love, whatever was to happen next, had not been considered.

The topic did come up, many months later, when a local Arab man, Abdul-Latif came to Charles and Gregory to inquire about Nadira. The knights had met Abdul several years ago through his work with livestock. He had attended to their pack animal's hooves on several occasions.

Abdul was a handsome, former soldier. The knights knew him to be a good and honest man about the same age as Nadira. He had lost his only wife and their first child during childbirth, several years earlier. When Charles and Gregory told Nadira of Abdul's inquiry and asked her for her thoughts on the subject, she at first seemed confused, saying that she would do as she was told. She seemed puzzled that they had even asked. It was possibly, the first time in her life that anyone had asked her what she wanted to do. As Charles and Gregory came to understand, in this culture, women had few if any choices .

Abdul-Latif was invited to visit Nadira at her dwelling place so that they might share tea and figs and have an opportunity to talk. The knights made it clear that any decisions would be hers alone. What concerns they might have had were put to rest when it soon became obvious that Abdul and Nadira were quite attracted to each other. As they sat talking and sipping their tea, they looked into each-other's eyes as if there was no one else in the room.

After several more visits, Charles and Gregory asked Nadira for her thoughts, even though they were already certain of the answer. With a smile on her face, she told them,

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“With your permission, I would be most happy to marry Abdul.”

When Abdul-Latif came to ask for permission to marry Nadira, Charles and Gregory gladly gave them their blessing, fulfilling the role most commonly performed by the father of the bride. This was a duty that neither of them could have foreseen in their wildest imaginings. Yet the surprises were only beginning.

Shortly after their meeting with the prospective bride and groom, Charles and Gregory met with Nadira to explain that they knew very little about marriage in general and nothing about Islamic weddings. Nadira was happy to explain the Islamic traditions to the men. She told them that the Quran allows Muslim men to marry women who are Muslim or non-Muslim, while Muslim women can only marry Muslim men. She went on to explain that marriage in Islam consisted of the creation of a Nikah which served as a formal marriage contract. The ceremony could take place in a mosque, a home, or any other location and that any Moslem who understands the Islamic tradition could be the official for the reading of the Quran and the exchange of vows in the presence of witnesses for both parties. When she had finished with her explanation, Nadira faced the two knights and quietly asked,

“May I ask you a question on another matter?”. The knights looked at each other for a moment and then Gregory responded,

“Certainly, was is it you would like to know?”

Looking at the floor and speaking in a voice, barely more than a whisper she said,

“Please forgive me if I am being too bold, I mean no disrespect, but could I know what your plans are for my daughters.”

The men were caught off guard. It was not a topic that they had discussed. Although both had wondered where their feelings for the young women would lead. Neither of them knew where to begin. Their hesitation led to a seemingly long and uncomfortable silence. Though she feared that she might have offended the men, Nadira, looked down at the floor and quietly asked,

“Might you consider taking them as wives?”

Charles and Gregory knew that marriages in Outremer as well as the kingdoms of the continent were often not based on love.

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Many, if not most marriages were politically motivated. Husbands and wives were often strangers when the marital arrangements were made. If love was involved at all, it developed after the couple were married. Nadira, Charles and Gregory also knew that their situation was different.

Charles cleared his throat several times. Gregory finally spoke,

“As you said, it is not permitted for Moslem women to marry non-Moslem men. Christianity has similar limitations. I do not think that either religion would permit this.”

For a few minutes, no one spoke. Finally, Nadira looked up and said,

“If I may be so bold as to suggest that churches do not marry couples, people marry each other. If their union is one of love and honest concern, the approval of others may not be necessary?”

Charles and Gregory looked at each other and then at Nadira.

“I believe you may be right,” said Gregory smiling.

“As do I,” said Charles nodding in agreement, “Should we ask your daughters?”

Smiling as tears welled up in her eyes, Nadira said,

“You can, but I can tell you now, what the answer will be!” They all smiled and laughed.

Two days later there was a triple wedding, in the former stable, officiated by Ahsan, Abdul-Latif’s brother. It was the humble beginning of three unions that would last each couple until death did them part.

Chapter 13

June 1341

Fortress ruins, Dead Sea road, Mamluk Sultanate of Egypt

After a long evening of stories and longer time of reminiscence, the knights and pilgrims slept soundly. Dawn's hazy light slowly replaced the star-filled sky as the five travelers began to stir. Early morning with its gradual brightness and cool air was for many, who lived in Outremer, the most pleasant time of day. The sun would not crest the horizon for a while and the air was cool and still. Too soon the cool would be replaced by heat, the constant dry breeze and the blowing sand that was a part of almost every day. Cloudless, deep blue skies were ringed with the orange haze of blowing sand around the entire horizon.

Charles was the first to rise. It was not that he wanted to, but toward morning he ran out of comfortable positions in which to sleep. Getting up to move around was the only way to ease the pain and stiffness. Though he had slept, it had been a restless evening. The things that he and Gregory had shared with the priest, as well as those events that they had chosen to keep secret were heavy on his mind,

He stood and stretched, looking around their camp at his fellow travelers. They too were beginning to stir, but it would be a while before they awoke. Morning had always been Charles' favorite time of day. He had time to be alone with his own thoughts

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and memories-time to think. He smiled as he looked at the beauty of the desert in early morning. He realized that as he aged, he came to appreciate so many of the simple things that went unnoticed in the years of his youth. Mornings in the Order often began with a rude awakening from a sound sleep that could have lasted until mid-day if uninterrupted by a summons to prayer, breakfast and the beginning of training or work. For years, they had been a blur of activity viewed through eyes half open and a mind still yearning for sleep. The beauty of these early hours had rushed by unnoticed and unappreciated. Perhaps the peace and serenity of early morning was the tradeoff for the body aches that would not allow him to sleep longer.

But again, there were other thoughts that had stolen his sleep last night. The cool morning air felt good on his face as he walked to the edge of the camp to look for brush and small twigs for a morning cooking fire. When he had gathered enough, he stopped to look out on the desert. Charles found a large flat rock to sit on and placed the fire wood on the ground next to it. For a while, he sat in the silence.

"What troubles you, my brother," came the voice from behind him. He quickly turned to see Gregory.

"Must you sneak up on me to jolt me back from my thoughts?" Charles asked, smiling.

"Didn't mean to startle you. You did not sleep soundly last night and I came to see if all is well."

Charles shook his head and looked back out across the open land just starting to brighten.

"I can't explain this," he said. "For the first time in decades, I am saddened by what I have done. There was time yesterday, for that young man to take his sword and walk away. I wanted him to back down and live, but you saw him, he only became more belligerent. I haven't felt this way in years.

Reminds me of the first time I ever took a life. I was eight. My parents had given me a bow with arrows and a straw-filled target for Christmas. I set the target near the edge of a field and practiced with the bow constantly. I was the envy of my friends whose parents thought we were too young for such activities. One

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day as we were shooting at the target, a Peacock from an estate to the south, came wandering through our fields. It was a beautiful male with bright plumage and long, elegant tail feathers. "Shoot it" said one of the older boys. I said that I didn't think it was a good idea. The boys began to tease me, suggesting that I was unmanly.

They started to chant "shoot, shoot". I finally did. The arrow hit the large bird in the chest and he started to run. He stumbled and fell to the ground flapping his wings and crying out. The flapping slowed down and the bird was finally silent and lay still. We all walked over to look at the beautiful creature. My friends slapped me on the back and congratulated me. The older boy told me that it was a good shot and that now I was a hunter. I felt like I couldn't breathe. I kept staring at the beautiful bird and tears welled up in my eyes. The oldest boy asked if I was going to cry and the others laughed. I felt empty and numb.

I had just ended a life and there was a sense of profound finality to it. There was no way to take the act back. I know it sounds strange. I spent my adult life with you as a knight. We have been in more battles that I can remember and I, long-ago, lost track of the number of men that I have killed. We are no strangers to death, but yesterday and that day so many years ago seem different from all of the others. Perhaps I am getting old and soft. Today both killings seem sad."

"You are getting old, my brother," said Gregory, smiling, "But I understand what you are feeling. Keep in mind that yesterday you had no choice!"

"Yes, I know that what I did was necessary to protect the travelers, but it could have been so easily avoided. All the young man had to do was walk away. Now he never will! I am beginning to wonder if sadness is not the right way to feel whenever a life is taken!"

"You may be right. As Templars we never really talked about what it was that we did and when we did talk, it was in general terms and most often shrouded in dark humor. In my most secret thoughts, I have long felt that there is no solace, certainly no joy, in taking a life, even when it is absolutely necessary. You are not alone in this my brother."

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Charles silently nodded his head as he looked at Gregory.
They gathered up the kindling and turned to walk back to camp.

Chapter 14

June 1341

Fortress ruins, Mamluk Sultanate of Egypt

Walking back to the ruins, they saw Ludolphus, rolling up his sleeping cloth. Turning to Charles as they walk, Gregory quietly said, “I have been thinking that we were wise to say as little as possible to Father Ludolphus concerning our wives and children.”

“I agree, I’m really not interested in a lecture on church doctrine from our pilgrim friend.”

“Amen,” said Gregory smiling and nodding

“Good morning, did the two of you sleep well?” Ludolphus called out as they approached.

“As well as these old bones will allow,” said Gregory, smiling. Charles nodded.

“I slept well,” offered Ludolphus. “Knowing that we were safe at night made sleeping so much easier. My traveling companions will sleep until we wake them,” he said, looking at Steven and Nicholas still wrapped in their cloaks.

“Ah, the joys of youth,” said Gregory, “the sleep of the just and the sleep of the innocent.”

“Most likely a combination of both,” added Charles, smiling.

Ludolphus, sat on a rock as Charles and Gregory began to build a small fire to warm tea. He looked away for a moment,

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hesitating. Turning back, he said, "I awoke thinking of your account of meeting your future wives in the desert. That is a most interesting series of events."

"Yes," said Gregory, "but it is a long story, perhaps for another time."

Looking at Gregory and then Ludolphus, Charles nodded and added,

"For now, we need to have something to eat, get packed up and leave the area. If we hurry, we will have time to show you some of the biblical sights that you undoubtedly heard of as children."

"How should we proceed?" asked Ludolphus, rubbing his forearm.

"I suggest that we travel to Karak where you may stay with us and our wives. It is a day's journey, but there are some interesting things to see along the way," said Charles.

Turning toward Ludolphus, Gregory asked, "Is your arm bothering you where you were cut? I noticed that you have been rubbing it."

"It is a little sore," answered Ludolphus. "It stopped bleeding, but is a little swollen."

"Pull up your sleeve and let me have a look," said Charles.

The priest lifted his sleeve revealing a short cut on his forearm that was red around the edges and seemed slightly swollen.

"We should have a healer attend to that when we reach our home," said Charles. "Even simple cuts can become serious in this land."

The priest looked puzzled.

"It is true," said Gregory. "We have many times seen minor cuts turn bad and eventually kill even very strong men."

Charles nodded. "Outremer is a harsh world. As you have already seen, death is never far away. Through all of the years of holy war, far more men were killed here by heat, disease, famine, thirst, spider, scorpion, and snake bites, than were ever killed in battle."

"We have heard stories of snakes that live here that are so poisonous that if they bite a mounted horse, the rider would die also," said Nicholas.

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The group turned to look at the young man who had quietly walked up behind them. Normally shy and silent, he had suddenly become quite agitated.

“Some of those stories tend to be fanciful exaggerations.” said Charles. “Years ago, we also heard that the foul smell of the Dead Sea could kill both men and beasts.”

“That is not true,” said Gregory smiling, “but there are days when the odor is enough to make one long for death. For now, we should proceed to the castle and seek the service of a healer that we know there.”

“Is he a Christian doctor?” asked Ludolphus.

“No, he is not,” said Charles. “Over the years we have found that if you wish to get well, you should seek out an Arab healer.”

The priest look at him with a question in his eyes.

“It is true,” said Gregory. “We have seen situations in which Frankish doctors have made matters worse for those with illness or injuries.”

“They are not skillful as healers?” asked Ludolphus.

“Judge for yourself,” said Gregory. “Once, many years ago, we were at Moinestre, about half a day’s ride east of Jubail. There we heard the account of a knight who had an abscess on his leg. They didn’t say what caused the swelling, but it was red and growing larger. The knight, was a brave man, who had tried to ignore the problem, hoping that it would go away. It apparently got worse with time. Also in this town was a Frankish woman who was suffering with consumption. Both the knight and the woman went to an Arab healer who agreed to treat them. The Arab had applied a poultice on the knight’s leg and after a day, the abscess had opened and had begun to drain and heal. For the woman he prescribed a cleansing and refreshing diet to counteract the Frankish foods that were making her ill. This treatment was also beginning to have a positive effect and she began to feel better.

Soon afterwards, a Frankish doctor arrived in Moinestre. When he heard of the knight and woman, he went to visit them. He examined the man first and told the knight that the Arab healer had no idea how to cure people. He asked the knight if he would prefer to live with one leg or to die with two. The knight was

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understandably fearful and responded that he would prefer to live. The Frankish doctor immediately sent for two strong men and a sharp axe. When they arrived, the doctor and one man held the afflicted leg on a wooden block and instructed the other man, with the axe, to strike a mighty blow!

The man struck the leg with one blow and then another for the first did not cut cleanly. Blood and marrow spurted out of the leg as the knight screamed aloud, making a frightful sound. Within moments, he was dead. The doctor, who seemed completely unconcerned, then left to visit the sick woman.

Upon examining her, he declared that she had a devil in her head that was in love with her and that they should cut off all of her hair. This was done and the woman returned to her home, where she went back to eating the Frankish foods that made her ill. When her condition became worse, she returned to the Frankish doctor, who examined her again. This time he declared that the devil had gone into her brain and must be removed. He had two strong men hold her down while he proceeded to cut across her head and remove her brain so that the inside of the skull was laid bare. This area he ribbed with salt. Obviously, the woman also died immediately! The Arab healer, who had been successfully treating both patients before the arrival of the Frankish doctor, had no choice, but to observe in shock. “

“That story is hard to believe,” said Ludolphus, who looked quite pale.

“We also found I hard to believe. Yet it is possibly true.” said Charles. “Countless times after battles we saw the priests and Frankish doctors going quietly among the seriously wounded, encouraging them to die quickly and hurry to their heavenly reward. Those that scoffed at their counsel, were told that their treatment could take too long and that they would become an unnecessary burden for the Army of Christ.”

Ludolphus and his traveling companions had listened silently. At length Nicholas turned to the priest and said softly, “Father, I would recommend an Arab doctor.” Ludolphus nodded in agreement.

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“A wise choice,” said Gregory, smiling. “Your condition may not be that serious.”

“Especially if you avoid a Frankish doctor,” added Charles.

Chapter 15

June 1341

Fortress ruins, Mamluk Sultanate of Egypt

After their tea and dates the men gathered their belongings and began their journey. The sun had still not crested the distant mountains, though it was growing noticeably warmer. There was no breeze. The sky was a brilliant blue and the distant horizon was fringed with the ever-present orange haze.

Charles and Gregory walked in front leading their pack animals loaded with firewood. Ludolphus walked between them also leading his burro.

“What will we see of interest today? he asked.

“Over the crest of that next hill, we will see a pillar that is said to be the remains of Lot's wife, Frit,” said Gregory.

“The wife who God turned into a pillar of salt when she looked back at Sodom and Gomorrah?”

“The very same,” said Charles.

Ludolphus turned around to tell Stephen and Nicholas, who were following at a distance. Both seemed eager to see this Biblical site. For a while the group walked on in silence, surrounded by expansive vistas, endless blue skies. The only sound, that of sandals and small hooves on gravel and sand.

As they reached the crest of a low hill, Gregory pointed to a tall pillar of rock on the top of a larger hill. It was close to the side

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of a well-worn trail. The pillar looked to be at least 60 feet tall. It was the same color and texture as the surrounding rock. The priest and his companions looked puzzled.

“Is that it?” asked Ludolphus.

“Yes!” replied Charles.

“It looks like so many other rock formations that we have seen,” said Stephan. “It looks more like rock than salt. How do you know that it’s Lot’s wife?”

Charles and Gregory turned around. It was the first time that they had heard Stephen say anything.

Ludolphus agreed with Stephen. “Yes, we have all seen several similar rock formations.”

“We know it is Lott’s wife, because the Empress Helena, told us so,” said Charles smiling.

“Do you mean St. Helena, the mother of the Emperor, Constantine?” asked Ludolphus.

“The very same,” responded Gregory.

“How did she know that this was Lott’s wife,” asked Nicholas.

“Probably the same way she knew where the site of the Nativity, the Ascension and the Burning Bush were located. When you are the mother of a Roman Emperor, few dare question your ideas,” said Charles.

“I am certain that you have heard the stories,” said Gregory. “How the Emperor Constantine gave his mother, Helena, the title *Agusta Imperatrix*, granted her unlimited access to the imperial treasury and sent her to the Holy Land, three hundred years after the death of Christ. Her goal was to find relics of Christianity, the Roman Empires’ new religion.”

“Of course, we all know of these events,” said Ludolphus. “Through the miracle of curing a woman who was near death, she was able to identify the true cross.”

Stephan and Nicholas looked puzzled.

“Were you not taught of this in your parish?” asked Ludolphus. “When St. Helena first came to Jerusalem, the city was still in the process of rebuilding after its destruction by the Romans. The Emperor, Hadrian, had renamed the city *Aelia Capitolina* and

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built a temple, that I believe was dedicated to either Venus or Jupiter, on the site of the tomb of Jesus, near the hill called Calvary.

According to the traditional stories, Helena ordered the temple to be destroyed and chose a site nearby to begin excavating. The digging led to the discovery of three wooden crosses. Believing that they might be the crosses used during the crucifixion of Christ, the Empress sought to determine their validity through the working of a miracle. Helena had a woman who was ill and near death brought to the digging site. The woman was allowed to touch the first of the three crosses. Nothing happened. The same was true when she was told to touch the second cross. However, upon touching the third cross, she suddenly recovered her health. St. Helena declared the cross, that had cured the woman, to be the True Cross. It was on this site that her son, Constantine, built the Church of the Holy Sepulcher. Later St. Helena was said to have also located the original nails of the crucifixion.”

“That is the way the story goes,” said Charles nodding. “The cross that she found was the same one that the Franks carried into battle and lost to the Saracens when they were defeated at the Horns of Hattin.”

“It is no wonder that the Church declared her a saint,” said Nicholas. “I always wondered why her son who made Christianity the official religion of his empire was not also declared a saint!”

“Possibly because he was not a Christian until the last moments of his life,” said Charles.

“How could that be?” asked Stephan.

“It is true,” said Gregory. “Constantine was a follower of Saul Invictus, the sun god. The story goes that he converted the empire to Christianity to help control the unruly population as the empire continued to weaken and decline. He only converted to Christianity at the very end as he lay dying.”

“Perhaps he was not as pious as his mother, Helena,” suggested Nicholas.

“That's an interesting story also,” said Gregory. Some who wrote about the times in which Constantine and Helena ruled, suggested that Helena was involved in the murders of both

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Constantine's eldest son, Crispus and of Constantine's wife, the Empress Fausta. Hardly saint-like behavior.”

“True,” said Charles. “I cannot think of any other saints that were suspected of murder.”

Ludolphus, abruptly stopped walking and turned toward the two knights.

“Has your time in the Holy Land caused you to completely lose your faith?” he asked. “What you say is close to blasphemy!”

The knights stopped and looked first at each other and then at the priest.

Gregory spoke first.

“It is a long and complicated process!” he said. “When we were children, we were told so many amazing stories that were almost beyond belief. If we questioned them, we were chastised and admonished to accept them on faith. We were told that accepting the mysteries of faith was a part of being a good Christian.”

“And we did!” added Charles. “But in coming to the Holy Land and seeing these places for ourselves, and hearing the same stories from another perspective made us at least question the accounts we had been given.”

Ludolphus and his traveling companions looked puzzled.

“It is true,” said Gregory. “One of the first was the story of Thomas of Aquinas and his meeting with the famous Arab leader, Saladin. As young monks, we were told many times of the piety of Saint Thomas. We often heard of his life of poverty, prayer and sanctity; of how he was loved by the birds and animals. As we prepared to come to Outremer, we heard the story of his famous meeting with the great Saladin and how impressed the Arab warrior was with this simple monk.”

“That was but one side of the story,” added Charles. “Since we both speak Arabic, we were able to easily converse with the people here and were able to share stories and experiences with them. The Arab and Christian accounts of the meeting between Saint Thomas and Saladin are somewhat similar, but they are very different in essence. Like the Christian accounts, the Arab version indicates that Saladin and his court were most impressed by the visit of Saint Thomas. As we had long known from our childhood

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instruction, Thomas was a man of great piety who rejected many of the worldly trappings including bathing. According to the stories, Thomas never washed his clothes, bathed his body nor cut or combed his hair. As one might imagine, he had a rather strong odor about him.”

“As we came to learn, Arab people, unlike those of our homeland, are very concerned with cleanliness and bathe often. Many do so daily,” added Gregory. “In the hot climate of this land, the smell of Saint Thomas was overwhelming. Rather than being struck by his piety, as the Christian tales suggest, the Arabs, according to their own accounts, were convinced that this representative of the Christian armies was completely mad and therefore should not be harmed.”

“Yes,” said Charles. “Like many cultures, the Arabs have a kind of reverence for those who have lost their minds and are careful not to harm them. Sending Thomas safely back to the Christian army was an act of mercy! This tale is like so many other accounts shared by two or more cultures. They come with at least two ways of understanding them.”

“It is not so much a matter of losing or keeping faith as much as being able to see the same events through the eyes of different peoples,” said Gregory. “Have you never questioned your own beliefs?” he added, looking at the priest.

“Of course, I have had moments of doubt,” said Ludolphus. “Everyone does at some time, but when they occur, I pray for guidance and stronger faith.”

“For years, we did that also,” said Charles.

“But as time went on, we began to see the wisdom in the views of others and we began to pray for enlightenment instead,” responded, Gregory.

“Were your prayers answered?” asked Ludolphus.

“Your presence might indicate that they were,” said Gregory, smiling.

Ludolphus smiled and slowly nodded. The men turned back to the road and continued their journey.

Chapter 16

July 1341

Al Karak Castle, Mamluk Sultanate of Egypt

It was dark when Charles, Gregory, Ludolphus, Steven and Nicholas arrived at the home shared by the knights and their wives. The tall building was one of the larger stone structures in Al Karak Castle. Many of the other buildings were constructed of mud bricks. The knights and their wives had done a creative job of converting the barnlike structure into spacious living quarters, with the large hay storage area serving as a combination kitchen, dining and common area. The former horse stalls, after a thorough cleaning and the addition of straw-filled sleeping mats, made comfortable bedrooms.

Upon entering the building, the knights introduced Ludolphus, Steven and Nicholas to their wives. Ludolphus smiled and nodded toward Jamcela and Adiba. Turning toward Charles and Gregory he smiled and said,

“Tell your wives that it is a pleasure to meet them and that we appreciate your hospitality.”

“You just did,” said Gregory.

Ludolphus looked at the men, not sure that he had heard them correctly.

“It is true,” said Charles. “Our wives speak Latin and our native tongue as well as we do.”

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Ludolphus looked surprised.

“You are most welcome in our home,” said Jamcela, smiling.

Ludolphus nodded. Turning toward Stephen and Nicholas, he introduced them to the ladies. Nicholas smiled and nodded, understanding what was happening despite his command of Latin being limited. Stephen simply smirked and looked bored.

Charles led the group onto the common room where they sat on cushions, placed against the walls, as was the custom in this land. Jamcela and Adiba went into the cooking area and prepared hot tea and dates for their guests. When they returned and served the travelers, they looked to their husbands to determine if they should leave the room. Gregory told them that they should join the guests and hear of the surprising news that Adolphus had shared with them earlier in the day. Charles agreed.

Anxious to hear what the priest had to say, Jamcela and Adiba sat against the wall next to their husbands. The women had known for decades that Charles and Gregory had come to Outremer as members of the Knights of the Temple, but they too were surprised to hear of the fate of the Order. As was the custom in these times, they listened in silence waiting until later to ask questions of their husbands.

As they spoke, Ludolphus noticed that his traveling companions were struggling to stay awake after a day of much adventure, followed by a long journey to their destination. He asked if they might retire for the evening before Steven and Nicholas fell asleep where they sat. Charles nodded in agreement and offered to take them to rooms where they could rest in comfort.

When Charles returned, he sat with Gregory, Jamcela and Adiba. For a moment, no one seemed to know where to begin. Some were bursting with questions, the others struggling for answers. Finally, Jamcela asked,

“What does this mean for us?”

“Probably very little,” said Charles. “For years we wondered when the next Frankish army, and our brothers of the Order, would return to reclaim the Holy Land. Now we know. Never. The order that we served with pride is simply no more.”

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Gregory slowly nodded his head. "We wondered for years, why it was taking so long and now we know. While it still does not seem possible, I believe that it is true," Gregory added.

"It is hard to understand what this all means," said Charles. He looked at Gregory who was smiling brightly and asked,

"What do you find amusing about any of this?"

"One thing it means, for certain, is that we have great deal less to explain," said Gregory. "For years I have thought about how, upon the Orders return, we would explain the fact that in their absence we had acquired wives and now have grown children."

"That would be an interesting discussion," said Charles smiling at his wife.

"Are you sad to learn that the Franks will never return to reclaim their holdings," Jamcela asked.

"I was at first," said Charles, "but I am coming to believe that their absence might possibly be a good thing. So many thousands of people lost their lives in those wars and in the end, nothing changed."

"Could it be," said Gregory, "they final realized that in the end, patience was a more powerful weapon than masses of invading armies. Like the man who pulls his hand out of a bucket of water the impression that he leaves disappears as soon as his hand is gone. When an invading army leaves the country it assaulted, conditions almost immediately start going back to the way they were. Perhaps the great powers of the world have finally learned this lesson."

"Time will tell," added Charles. Looking at Jamcela and Adiba, he asked,

"How does this news sit with the two of you?"

There was a moment of silence. Finally, Adiba said, "It makes little difference to us."

"As long as we are with you, we are happy," added Jamcela. "I think we have loved you forever."

"Even from that first night when we met you," suggested Adiba.

"After we realized that we were safe and that you would not harm us we sat with our mother and I mentioned that we both thought that the two of you were so handsome," added Jamcela.

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“I remember that our mother gave us such a stern look, but then smiled and gave us a hug.”

“Yes,” said Adiba. “Our mother loved you also. That day you saved us again by offering to take us from our father so that he did not need to have us killed to save his honor, we were confused. Our mother told us that we should feel joy and that we would never, ever meet better men than the two of you!”

Gregory and Charles looked at each other, smiled and Gregory said, “Your mother was a wise woman; it is no wonder that we loved her as we came to love her daughters.”

For a time, the two couples sat in silence, smiling. Finally, Jamcela asked, “How long will our guests be with us?”

“I believe that they will be going out again tomorrow,” said Gregory. “They mentioned that there were several biblical locations that they wanted to see. We will be leaving for a day also. We found a supply of good firewood that we need to cut and deliver before some else gets to it.”

The next morning Gregory gave the pilgrims directions to the sights they wanted to visit and then left with Charles and the pack animals to secure the wood that they had found several days before. When Ludolphus mentioned that he and his companions were still shaken by the previous day’s events, Charles assured them that they were in a much more populated area and that the odds of running into more robbers was very slim. They were relieved and told the knights that they would be back in two days if all went well.

Charles told them that he and Gregory would only be gone for the day and should be back home by sunset. The travelers and woodcutters left the town in opposite directions

Chapter 17

July 1341

Al Karak Castle, Mamluk Sultanate of Egypt

Midmorning, two days later, Ludolphus, Steven and Nicholas returned to the home of Gregory and Charles. They were tired from their travels, partly due to the uncomfortable nights rest they had experienced. The inn where they stayed the second night was located close to a popular ale house where some sort of loud and enthusiastic celebration continued long into the evening. The lack of sleep and the stifling heat of the following day had taken its toll on them.

As they approached the door to the knight's dwelling, Ludolphus called out a greeting. There was no answer. He called again and heard the sound of someone inside approaching the door. As it opened, he saw Jamcela who looked quite pale and Adiba who had bloodshot eyes and tears running down her cheeks.

"What has happened?" asked Ludolphus. "What is wrong?"

Adiba started to speak, but her voice was choked with tears. Jamcela moved forward and said,

"The Sultan's men came early this morning and took our husbands. They have been accused of killing a young Arab and the boy's father is demanding revenge."

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Clearing her throat, Adiba said, "This day, they are before the Sultan who will pass judgement on them. How could this be happening?" she cried.

"We know what this is about," said Ludolphus. "Three men tried to rob and kill us and your husband, Charles, slew one of them when he tried to attack us. If it were not for his intervention, we would be rotting in the desert. Can you take us to the Sultan's palace? We must try to help if we can."

"Follow us," Adiba said. "The palace is on the other side of the castle. Let us hurry."

After a brisk walk across the castle grounds, the five of them arrived at the palace where Adiba translated for Ludolphus when he asked to enter the palace and have an audience with the Sultan. The captain of the guards told him that the Sultan was busy hearing evidence of an incident in which two old Franks had murdered a young Arab man.

"This man was a witness to that event," said Adiba. "He and his companions can testify as to what took place that day."

The captain told them to wait there at the gate while he entered the palace. It seemed as if they were waiting for a long time, but he finally returned.

"Come with me," he commanded, "The Sultan will see you now." Turning to Adiba and Jamcela he added, "These women must remain here."

The captain, led the three pilgrims into the throne room. A single guard followed them. They entered a large room with stone walls, a high wooden ceiling and no windows. The room was dimly lit by small oil lamps. The air was scented with the sweet smell of burning incense. At the far side of the hall, they saw the Sultan sitting on a large cushion that rested on raised platform. An armed guard stood on either side of him. Next to the guard, on the right side, stood an unarmed man holding a kamish-reed pen and a tablet.

The Sultan was a thin, middle-aged man, handsome, with dark hair and a dark beard and mustache. The hair of his temples and beard were highlighted with subtle traces of silver. Facing him, stood Charles and Gregory chained at the wrists and ankles. Two

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guards were stationed on either side of them. The knights looked straight ahead and did not turn as the travelers entered.

To the left of the Sultan stood an older Arab man, a woman and the two young men who were with the robber that Charles had slain. The older of the boys appeared nervous, shifting his weight from one sandaled foot to the other. The younger boy looked terrified. His eyes were locked in a wide stare at the floor in front of him.

The older Arab man was explaining, loudly, that he was the father of three boys. His two surviving sons had witnessed the taller of the two Franks murder his child for no reason.

“My eldest son was a good man,” he shouted. “He was a man of honor, a devout follower of the Profit and would never violate any of the principles of the Koran.”

The Sultan held up his hand to stop the father’s testimony and turned to Ludolphus and his fellow travelers.

“I have been told that you were witness to the events we consider this afternoon,” he said in Arabic.

Ludolphus shook his head, indicating that he did not understand. Seeing the problem, the Sultan ordered his translator to repeat the question in Latin.

“Yes, we were.” responded Ludolphus. “All three of us witnessed these events.”

“And why were you in the area of the Dead Sea that day,” asked the Sultan.

“We are on a pilgrimage to the Holy Land and wanted to see the pillar of salt that was once Lot’s wife.”

“Yes, I have heard that story,” the Sultan responded. “From your clothing I suspect you might be a Christian priest?”

“Yes, I am the rector of the parish church in Suchem.”

“Tell us, what did you see that day.”

Ludolphus took a deep breath and began.

“We were riding our burros on the west shore road by the sea when three men came out from behind some large rocks. The oldest of the three was shouting in a language that we did not understand, but he had a sword and it was apparent that he meant to rob us. These two older men you see before you, came forward

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and stood between us and the young men and began to try to reason with him in Arabic. After the taller of the two old men spoke to them in a quiet tone, the tallest of the Arab men raised a sword over his head and lunged toward him. Before he could do him any harm, the old man defended himself with an axe and the young man died immediately.”

As soon as he had finished the man with the pen and tablets translated his comments into Arabic. The translation was no sooner finished than the mother of the boys started to wail loudly while the father screamed,

“Lies, all of it lies, my son was a good boy who never threatened or hurt anyone.”

“That is not true,” spoke a soft, high-pitched voice coming from behind the father. “Ever since he found that old Roman sword, he threatened me and my other brother and robbed everyone, he could find on the remote desert roads. He planned to rob and kill these men also!”

Everyone in the hall turned to look at the youngest boy who had no sooner finished speaking than he found himself lying on the floor with a growing bruise on his cheek. His father had struck him with a closed fist.

“You blaspheme and dishonor your family, the father shouted. You are dead to us. You may never return home or I will kill you to restore the family honor.”

“There will be no honor killing here today,” said the Sultan, in a calm voice. Turning to Charles and Gregory he said,

“I know of you men. You have served me for many years and my father and his father before him. They told me of your service, translating for them during the wars with the Franks, so many years ago. I also understand that you are married to two of my father’s daughters. Is the priest’s account of events accurate?

“Yes, it is,” said Gregory, “your understanding is correct and so is the priest’s description.”

“I suspected that it might be,” replied the Sultan, looking away from them to the distant wall. For a moment he was silent and finally looked back at the knights. “You are free to go.”

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Charles and Gregory looked at each other, each wondering if they had heard correctly.

“May I speak?” asked Ludolphus.

The Sultan met his eyes and nodded.

“As I understand it, these two men, former Knights of the Temple, have been in your grandfather’s service, your fathers service and now your service for nearly fifty years; ever since the fall of Acre. They have served all of you well, cutting fire wood, not to mention saving the lives of your father’s former wife and daughters. Days ago, they saved my life and those of my companions. Is it possibly not time for them to be set free to return to their homeland and the relatives that remain there?”

The Sultan looked at Ludolphus as his scribe translated the priest’s words. He was silent again, for a moment. Everyone in the room was silent, including the parents of the deceased robber. At length he said. “I believe that you may be right. It may well be time for these men to return home. They may leave for their homelands with you, when you return.”

Turning to his guards, he added, “Take these pilgrims and my former wood cutters to the palace gates. Remove their chains.

Turning to face the family of the robber he added, “I will deal with these others now.”

Charles, Gregory, Ludolphus and his companions walked out of the great hall to the palace door where Adiba and Jamcela awaited. When Adiba saw that Gregory and Charles were no longer in chains she cried out and ran forward to put her arms around Gregory.

“You are free?”, she asked.

“Yes, we are,” said Gregory, “free to return to our home here in the fortress and free to return home to Toulouse and Burgundia.”

Leaning toward Charles he whispered,

“We should hurry just in case the Sultan changes his mind.”

“I don’t think he will,” said Charles. “He seems to be a man of honor, as were his father and grandfather.”

Gregory nodded, but neither man slowed his walking pace. Their wives and the pilgrims hurried to keep up. As they walked

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down the street leading back to their home, they heard the sound of footfalls behind them. Turning, they saw the youngest of the would-be robbers.

“Let me go with you,” the boy cried. “I will serve you faithfully. I have nowhere to go! If I return to our village, my father will kill me and no one will lift a hand to stop him. If you leave me here, I will soon be as dead as my criminal brother.”

He stood looking at the group, tears running down his swollen face.

“What is your name?” Gregory asked.

“I am called Khalil,” he answered, “but you may call me whatever you want.”

“Khalil will do,” said Charles shaking his head, “follow us.”

Charles and Gregory led the group, walking with Adiba and Jamcela by their sides. It was clear that the women had many questions, but when Charles and Gregory looked to their wives, they only nodded and smiled. Both women understood that the answers would wait until they had arrived home. Their most important question and concern had already been addressed. Their husbands were no longer in chains and were free to leave with them. As is often the case with those who have lived and loved for many years, much was understood while few words were spoken.

Ludolphus, Steven and Nicholas followed closely behind the two couples. Khalil followed the group twenty paces back. During the brisk walk, no one talked. It was as though all feared that they might have misunderstood what had just happened and that talking about it might change the result.

Chapter 18

July 1341

Al Karak Castle, Mamluk Sultanate of Egypt

When the party arrived at the knights' living quarters they were still in shock over the day's events. They gathered in the largest room, lit by four small oil lamps. A large woolen carpet covered the floor. Pillows lay against the edges of all four walls.

Gregory turned to Ludolphus and the three young men.

"Would you mind waiting in the other room while Charles and I explain what happened today to our wives?"

"Of course," said Ludolphus, "we will be down the hall."

The moment they were alone both women rushed to their husbands, hugging and sobbing at the same time.

"We were sure that we would never see you again," said Adiba.

"Watching you being taken away in chains broke our hearts," added Jamcela.

"For a while, we were not so sure either," said Gregory. "There was no one there to testify to the truthfulness of our account and at the end of the day, we are still infidels in the eyes of most Moslems."

"It is true," said Charles, "If you had not brought Father Ludolphus to the palace and Khalil had not added his account, today may have turned out very differently."

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"You could be dead!" sobbed Jamcela, shaking as she hugged Charles. She would not let go.

"Worry not," said Gregory smiling, "As it is said, only the good die young."

"We are decades past young!" added Charles, shaking his head at Gregory's ability to find humor in even this situation. "You are stuck with us for at least a while longer."

Jamcela and Adiba managed to laugh through their tears.

"Can we ask the others to join us?" asked Gregory. The two women nodded and wiped the tears from their faces.

When Ludolphus, Nicholas, Steven and Khalil came back into the room they took places sitting around the edge of the floor against the walls. For a while all sat waiting for someone to begin. Finally, Gregory spoke, "What a day! I woke up this morning happy to be home for a while, only to leave our home in chains on my way to face an accusation of murder." He looked across the room at Ludolphus. "Just as things were looking most grim, you came to our rescue and not only helped to justify our actions the previous day, but to also end our half century of slavery. Even as I just now say those words, I am scarcely able to believe them."

"As am I!" added Charles. "While I am most pleased to have the Sultans permission to be free and return to our native countries, at the same time I know that there is no way that we could do that. The land route is long and treacherous and much too strenuous for men and women of our years. A sea voyage would be better, but we have no means to pay for such a passage. I fear the best we can do is enjoy our newfound freedom and live out our lives here in Outremer."

Adiba and Jamcela smiled and nodded, uneasily, trying to make the most of the days good fortune.

"There may be a way." said a voice from across the room. All turned to look at Ludolphus.

"The three of us are scheduled to return to Pater born by sea. If we hope to sail this year we must be in Jaffa, by the beginning of August. That is the best month for making a return voyage from east to west. Sea captains prefer to sail west in August when the seas are smooth. Later in the year, especially November, December,

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and January there is no sailing west due to storms and cooler weather.

But I digress. We are to meet an old family friend in Jaffa. His name is Wolfgang de Suchem and he is the captain of a Genoese merchant ship that carries cotton from Alexandra and dates from the Levant to the Frankish countries. I can inquire as to his willingness to take some extra passengers on this homeward voyage.”

“Would your captain be willing to take others beside the three of you?” asked Charles,

“I believe that he would,” said Ludolphus. “He is a most devout Christian and unlike some in his profession, he is a man who can be trusted. I also suspect that he would be pleased to meet two Knights of the Temple. Growing up as children in Suchem, we heard countless stories of the Templars exploits, but even then, they were only considered to be legends since it was believed that there were no Templars left.”

“That would be wonderful,” said Gregory, “but we have no money to even pay for provisions for the journey. How could we manage a journey of that distance without funds?”

“I have coin enough for that,” said Ludolphus. “The bishop of my diocese gave me money to purchase holy relics to bring back to the parish church. I have no doubt that he would be pleased to have me return with two warriors of the church that could attest to the last days of the battles to free the holy land.”

“Then we must decide,” said Gregory. “Do we all want to travel to Jaffa and sail west?”

“I do,” said a quiet voice from a dark corner of the room. Everyone turned to look at Khalil.

Charles began to speak and stopped. No one spoke.

Finally, Jamcela said, “It may not be proper for me to speak to this issue, but we should not forget that it was this boy’s testimony that verified Father Ludolphus’ account of the events that took place that day. It has cost him dearly to bear witness to the truth, and leaving him here would surely result in his death.”

Ludolphus glared at Jamcela, clearly not pleased with her observations. Before he could comment, Adiba cried out, “He is

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only a child. The bruise on his face is probably only the beginning of what lies in store for him if he is left alone here.”

Looking around the room, Gregory announced,

“I say we take him, what’s one more mouth to feed? He is so small he probably does not eat much anyway.”

Khalil, with tears in his eyes, bolted across the room and knelt down next to Gregory.

“Thank you, my lord, I swear to always serve you well!” he sobbed.

“Stand up.” Gregory commanded. “I am not your lord, but you will be expected to carry your share of the work that goes into this journey.”

“I will never fail you,” Khalil said looking around the room. “All of you,” he added.

Ludolphus wore the look of a man trying to make the best of a bad situation. Not sure that he was clearly understanding what was taking place, he turned to Charles and Gregory and asked,

“Do you really wish to take these women and this Arab boy as well?”

Charles looked shocked at the question and turning to Ludolphus and said,

“Where we go, our wives go!”

“We follow our husbands,” echoed Jamcela.

“Very well, I can ask!” said Ludolphus, shaking his head. Tomorrow, we should start gathering provisions for our journey to Jaffa. We will retire for the evening now.”

Standing up, he abruptly left the room. He was followed by Steven, Nicholas. Khalil remained seated, not knowing what to do at this point.

Seeing his confusion, Gregory indicated that Khalil should follow him and led the boy to a converted horse stall at the end of the hallway where he could spend the night.

“Thank you for everything,” Khalil said as Gregory turned to leave.

Gregory smiled and said, “Sleep well.”

When Gregory returned to the room, he looked at Charles and quietly asked,

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“Did our priest honestly expect that we would leave our wives here in Outremer?”

“I don’t know,” said Charles. “It seemed that way at first. Turning to Adiba and Jamcela he asked, “How do the two of you feel about leaving our home and our children.”

“Our children are grown and married, with families of their own,” said Adiba. “I know that they will be sad to see us leave, but they will understand.”

“If we go, we will probably never see them again,” said Jamcela, her eyes again welling up with tears. “They will never be able to travel so far and we will likely never return to the Levant.”

“If it is too painful, we could talk about staying,” said Charles. He too knew how hard it would be to never see his children or grandchildren again, but returning to his homeland was something that he and Gregory had wished for, since the time they were captured. There was much in that world that he would like to resolve.

“We know that our children will understand,” said Adiba. “It will be a hard thing to do, but I believe that it is the right thing.”

Jamcela nodded, wiping the tears from her face. “They are all happy here and have good lives with good husbands. I suspect that they would feel most out of place in your home country. Let us all go together and tell them of our plans, hug them and say our goodbyes.”

The four of them silently agreed trying to smile through their tears.

Chapter 19

July 1341

Ar Rabba, Mamluk Sultanate of Egypt

As planned, Charles, Gregory, Adiba and Jamcela traveled, the next day, to visit the homes of their daughters. All four lived, with their families, in the nearby village of Ar Rabba, located on a steep hill, a several-hour walk north from Karak. Charles and Jamcela's daughters Nora and Sara each had a daughter of their own. Nora's daughter, Amira and Sara's daughter, Yara were both five years old. Oddly enough, so were their cousins. Gregory and Adiba's daughters, Abla and Nadia also each had one daughter. Abla's daughter, Samara and Nadia's daughter were also five. All of the four grandchildren had been born in the same year. Adiba and Jamcela had traveled to Ar Rabba to help with their daughter's deliveries.

The family gathering was held at the home of Sara and her husband Kareem. Like all of the houses in the village, theirs was a modest structure made of bricks formed using local mud mixed with straw. The tile roof kept the house dry and secure during what little rain the region experienced. The floors in the house were made of packed soil that was so firmly in place that it could be swept.

As the grandfathers sat in the main room where the family met, they could see that in addition to sharing the same birth year, the four granddaughters also shared physical characteristics.

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Leaning to his side, Charles nudged Gregory who was sitting next to him. "These four grand-daughters are all going to be tall like their mothers."

"Yes, I always thought it was amusing that our daughters were all taller than their husbands

Were it not for their hair color, they might even pass for twins like their grandmothers."

Gregory thought for a moment. "My granddaughters share the light-brown hair color that, they inherited from me."

Charles nodded. "Yes, and all four of them are a little more lightly complected than their fathers."

Gregory smiled and chuckled. "Undoubtedly due to having a light complected grandfather in their family tree."

"Probably" Charles agreed. "Did you ever find it ironic that we both had daughters and that our grandchildren are all girls?"

"I did. It's interesting that two men who formerly belonged to a large organization made up entirely of men should now sit in the middle of an extended family made up mostly of women and girls. The only explanation that I can offer is that, Allah simply willed it!"

"Probably," Charles agreed. "He also blessed our granddaughters, as well as our daughters and wives with a striking resemblance to their family matriarch, Nadira. Gregory smiled and nodded.

When everyone had arrived for the day's visit, Adiba and Jamcela gathered them together and told the families of the recent developments. Charles and Gregory sat by silently as their wives explained the previous day's events.

Jamcela began the discussion. "Your fathers are no longer slaves of the Soldan. They were freed and granted permission to return to their home countries."

"The Christian priest that testified at their hearing has also offered to help finance the return trip," added Adiba.

"Were you to go," cried Sara, "We would never be able to see you again."

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“Sadly, that is true,” responded Jamcela. “Your fathers discussed this with us and considered our feelings about leaving this part of the world.”

Adiba continued. “Of course. we would be most saddened to leave all of you, but your fathers have been slaves here for nearly fifty years. They have always dreamt of returning to their home countries. Sad as it will be, we can not deny them this opportunity.”

There was no response. Everyone except the four young granddaughters understood and appreciated this unexpected series of events. At the same time, the adults could not help but lament the separation that would be a sad part of the process.

After sitting down for a last meal together the knights and their wives hugged and kissed their daughters, their sons-in-law and their grandchildren. Amid conflicting feelings of joy and sadness, they returned to their dwelling place, in Karak, to make final arrangements for the long journey.

The next morning, Charles and Gregory went to meet with the Sultan’s Captain of the Guard, Abdallah Ayad; a man of imposing size and charming disposition. He was taller and appeared much stronger than most men in this part of the world and yet he had a gentile kindness about him that one would not expect from a professional soldier. Upon seeing Charles and Gregory he smiled broadly and greeted them with the traditional “*Assalam ‘alaikum.*”

Smiling, Gregory responded, “*Wa-Alaikum-assalam.* We are here to tell you of our plans to leave Karak and want to return the burros and tools before we go.”

“I am sorry to hear of your departure,” Abdallah said, “The Sultan sent word that you would no longer be in his service, but I did not expect that you would leave so soon.”

“Either did we,” added Charles.

“We have an opportunity to return to our homeland by ship if we can get to Jaffa within the month, so we must prepare quickly.”

Abdalla shook his head slowly and said,

“I have known you for so long, since I was a young soldier, long before I became the Captain of the Guard. I am happy to hear

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of your release from slavery, but at the same time I will miss seeing you.”

“It has been nice knowing you also,” said Charles. “You have always treated us with respect. We assumed that you would want your burros, the woodcutting axes and the swords that we carry?”

“I have lost track of the number of burros you have worn out over all these years,” Abdalla said with a smile. “These two are old. I would have you keep them for your journey and sell them when you reach the coast. I will take the axes and issue them to the next wood cutters we find. As for the swords, keep them with my hope that you never need to use them!”

“Thank you for your kindness,” said Gregory. “Like us, our wives are no longer young and the burros will make their journey to the coast much safer and more enjoyable.”

“May I also suggest that for safety, on this long journey, you consider traveling with a caravan?” said Abdallah. “In two days, there is one leaving Karak for Jerusalem carrying silk and spices for the marketplace there. I know the caravan master well and I am sure that he would be willing to have you travel with him, if I were to ask.”

“That would be most kind,” said Charles. “Jerusalem is a long walk with any number of dangers along the way.”

“Excellent,” responded Abdallah. “The Khabar, the caravan master, is just outside the city walls and I will take you to him now if you would like.”

Abdallah led Charles and Gregory down the street and out through the main fortress gates. There, they found the caravan camped as they prepared to depart for Jerusalem. Abdallah walked up to a short, stout Arab man who he greeted with a smile. After talking for a few moments, he turned back toward Charles and Gregory and announced,

“This is my friend, Arsalan. His name means ‘fearless’ in Arabic. He says that he would be willing to have your small group travel along with them on the journey.”

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“It is so,” said Arsalan, looking at the two knights. My friend Abdalla, tells me that the two of you were Knights of the Temple, some years ago.

Charles and Gregory nodded and smiled.

“As you know, the purpose of travelling in a caravan is to provide safety from robbers and it never hurts to have along a couple more men with fighting experience,” said Arsalan.

“That is true,” said Gregory. “It has been a while since we were soldiers, but we still remember how to use a sword when necessary.”

“Very good,” said Arsalan, smiling. “Meet us here, at the castle gates tomorrow evening and we will begin our journey.”

As they led their burros back toward the former stable that served as their home, Gregory asked Charles, “Does it seem odd to feel a sense of loss about leaving?”

“Yes and no. Despite being held captive for so long, we have had a very good life. In many ways, much better than others have experienced.”

“I agree,” said Gregory. “Perhaps it is just that change always brings with it uncertainty.”

“That it does,” said Charles, nodding his head.

Chapter 20

1341

Al Karak Castle, Mamluk Sultanate of Egypt

While their husbands were visiting the Captain of the Guard, Adiba and Jamcela planned on going to the central marketplace to purchase bread, dates and watered wine for the journey. Father Ludonphus gave her funds to purchase provisions, but when Adiba asked if they should all go shopping together, he declined stating that he would go with Steven and Nicholas. She was surprised by his response, and suggested to her sister that her confusion was possibly a matter of their not being used to being in the company of Christian priests. Jamcela agreed, suggesting that since they had only interacted with Imams as they were growing up, they should expect priests to act differently. The two groups left for the marketplace separately.

After hearing the sister's conversation, Khalil offered to accompany them and carry the supplies as they were purchased. While he was happy to help in any way that he could, he was still quiet and clearly shy in their presence. In the short time that he had been with the knights and their ladies, Khalil had developed a strong sense of loyalty and belonging. He thought to himself that this was the kind of family bond that he had always wanted.

Upon returning home, the women, with Khalil's help, finished packing the few possessions they owned and prepared for

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their walk to the coast. When their husbands returned with the burros, Adiba and Jamcela were delighted to learn that they would be able to ride for much of the journey and travel in the company of the caravan.

That evening, Father Ludolphus, Steven and Nicholas returned to the stables with the supplies that they had gathered and at dinner the group made plans to depart for the coast the following evening. Ludolphus said that he was relieved when he learned that they would be traveling with a caravan

The next afternoon, just before sunset, the eight travelers met the caravan at the castle gates to begin their journey to Jaffa. On the first night, they would be traveling from al Karak toward Jerusalem on a road called the Kings Highway. As was the custom in this land, this caravan would travel by night and rest in what shade they could find during the hottest part of the day. In the scorching heat of this desert land, progress was made from one water source to the next. In many stretches of the route, an oasis contained the only green vegetation to be found. Some had date palm trees which provided a little shade. Due to the number of women, children and heavily loaded camels, progress of this caravan would be slowed to a walking pace. The caravan would average eighteen to twenty miles per night and hoped to arrive at the outskirts of Jerusalem by the end of the week.

At the request of Charles and Gregory, the Khabir, Arsalan, allowed their group to travel near the front of the caravan. From years of experience the knights knew of the perils of traveling at the rear of a long procession. After a long day's march, those toward the rear found themselves covered in dust and sand to the point that they were barely recognizable, not to mention the odor of being downwind of dozens of horses, burros and camels.

Within a caravan, the travelers tended to form into conversational groups. At the beginning of the journey Ludolphus and his young companions walked and rode together. Ludolphus spoke, mostly with Steven, leaving Nicholas out of the conversations. Charles and Jamcela, Gregory and Adiba traveled

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together and conversed along the way. Khalil followed the group, walking alone.

After a few days Nicholas fell back and began to walk with Khalil. At first, they walked in silence, Khalil knowing only a few words of French and Latin, that he had picked up listening to conversations and Nicholas having done the same with the Arabic that he had overheard during his time in Outremer. As is so often the case with young people living in multicultural, multi lingual environments, they quickly developed a conversational ability using a combination of French, Latin and Arabic words and phrases. As they began to converse, they discovered that they had a number of life experiences in common.

“You know that I am an orphan,” Nicholas told Khalil.

“Yes, I do. Charles mentioned that to me. As of a short while ago, it appears that I am also.”

Nicholas looked puzzled. “But your parents still live?”

“They do, but because of my testimony against my eldest brother, they have declared me dead to them.”

“Can they do that? I heard your father yelling at you in Arabic during the meeting with the Sultan, but I could not tell what he said.”

“Oh yes, it happens more often than one might think. That is why it was so important for me to be taken in by the knights. Alone I would have been killed by my father’s relatives, sold into slavery or left to starved to death on my own.”

“I am so glad that none of that happened,” said Nicholas.

Khalil smiled at his new friend. “So am I, and what of you? The priest said that you were an appellate. What is that?”

Laughing, Nicholas responded, “I’m an acolyte, in some countries referred to as an altar server. It’s a fancy name for a church servant. I do whatever I am told, without complaint in exchange for meager food and uncomfortable lodging. Like you, I had few, if any other choices. Both my parents were dead and no relatives were willing to take me in.”

“That sounds a lot like a kind of slavery,” said Khalil.

“Yes, in a way, except that I am free to leave and go out on my own to starve, any time I would like. It could be much worse. I

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know of other acolytes whose priests have them do sex things with them. They were the real slaves.”

“And what of Steven?” asked Khalil. “I noticed that when Adiba and Jamcela ask us to go out to find firewood for the evening meal, Steven never joins us.”

“No, Steven believes that he is superior to us because his father is wealthy. He comes from people that think that labor is only for the poor. Be careful with Steven! Anything that you say around him will be reported to Father Ludolphus.”

Nicholas paused for a moment. He turned to look at Khalil. “There is something about this whole trip that has me concerned. As I came up to the priest and Steven the other day, they were talking about Gregory and Charles. The minute they noticed me, they stopped talking and Ludolphus told me to leave them for a while.”

“What were they talking about?” asked Khalil.

“I don’t know, replied Nicholas, “but whatever it was, they did not want me to hear it!”

“Steven and Father Ludolphus seem to be very close,” said Khalil.

“Yes, that is true,” said Nicholas, “Several times when they thought that I was not around, I saw them being much closer than a priest and a young boy should ever be.”

Khalil, nodding his head. “Yes, that happens in my culture also.” Changing the subject, he added, “what of Adiba and Jamcela, have they been kind to you?”

“Oh yes, in the brief time that I have known them, they have treated me as one of their own. They are both kinder and more loving than what I remember of my own mother. And they are both so beautiful,” he whispered.

“I noticed that also,” Khalil replied, smiling. “They have been most kind to me also and are most wonderful to behold.”

Chapter 21

July 1341

Road From Karak to Jerusalem

To the travelers, the journey seemed long and uneventful. The weather was typical of this time of year. Scorching hot days and cool nights. On moonlit nights the desert can look beautiful. The stars can be so bright it seemed as if one could reach up and touch them. At first, going to sleep in the oppressive heat of the day was difficult for the travelers, but after a few days they adjusted to the seemingly backward schedule.

For the first six days, the caravan was fortunate. There were no serious dust or wind storms and no signs of robbers. Several times groups of men were seen watching them from a distance. Charles and Gregory were aware of them, thinking that they could be other travelers or possibly robbers who were sizing up their caravan to determine if it was too well armed to attack.

On the morning of the seventh day, while returning from his morning walk out into the desert, Gregory encountered the Khabir, who was looking out toward the horizon. He looked worried.

“Do you see signs of others following us?” Gregory asked.

“No, not this morning,” answered Arsalan, pointing to the west. “I am watching what might be the beginning of a Haboob over there on the horizon.”

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“Yes, I see what you are looking at. That rising yellow dust on the horizon does look like a sand storm may be developing. Do you think it will be coming this way?”

Arsalan nodded. “Yes, whatever weather we get today will be coming from the west. Will you help me spread the word that it is time to secure our tents, cover our belongings and protect our pack animal’s eyes?”

“I will!” said Gregory. “Let’s hope it is a small storm and passes by quickly. I have seen Haboobs that have lasted several days!”

As Gregory and Arsalan moved through the caravan warning the travelers of the approaching storm, the wind continued to pick up. The wall of orange dust grew higher in the sky and the first bits of sand and dust reached their camp site. Everyone had seen and experienced Haboobs. They were not uncommon in this land. No one had to be warned twice. The entire caravan immediately began to make preparations. Within what seemed like a matter of minutes, the force of the growing wind began to carry off anything that was not securely tied down. It drove stinging sand into unprotected eyes and every crevice of equipment and clothing.

As he progressed through the caravan warning others of the storm, Gregory came upon Charles and then others securing their belongings.

“I will come back as soon as I finish warning the rest of the caravan,” said Gregory, “it looks like our group is ready.”

“As ready as we can be,” answered Charles. Gregory hurried off.

When Gregory reached the far end of the caravan, he turned and started back toward Charles and the others. By this time the wind was blowing hard and the sand was stinging every bit of exposed skin. Gregory had pulled his tunic up over his face and was walking back into the wind squinting to keep his eyes clear while trying to see where he was going. When he stopped for a moment to adjust his covering, he felt something bump into his leg. At first, he thought it might be part of a tent or a bundle of cotton that had not been adequately secured. When it grasped onto his leg, he knew it was not.

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Looking down Gregory saw a small girl hugging his leg, her face against his hip. Even with her face pressed to his leg and despite the noise of the howling wind, he could hear the girl's cries for her mother. Gregory bent over, picked up the little girl and pushed her face into his cloak.

"Don't worry, we will find your mother soon," he said, patting her head.

"I want her now," the girl cried, still clutching Gregory as hard as she could.

"We'll find her as soon as this stops," he said, leaning into the wind on his way back to where he thought he had left Charles and the others. In only a few steps, Gregory realized that they were in the center of the full force of the storm and that he was turned around, not sure of his direction. Years of experience had taught him that in a situation like this, it was best to find a place to hunker down and hope that the storm passes by, or at least abates. He remembered well situations in which grown men had panicked during Haboobs and tried to outrun the storm only to be lost far out in the desert. Some were never seen again.

Looking down-wind Gregory could make out the shape of a large boulder. Holding the little girl's face close to his chest he hurried to the stone and crouched down, against the downwind side. Gregory and the girl huddled together with Gregory's cloak over their heads and faces.

They were quickly covered with sand and dust. The young girl finally stopped sobbing and seemed to understand that she was safe. Gregory briefly considered asking if she was comfortable, but realized that in the howling wind of the storm any conversation would require shouting. He elected to wait until the storm passed over them or at least began to dissipate.

Despite its impressive intensity, the storm was mercifully short. In less than an hour the center of the Haboob had gone over their location and the winds were quickly subsiding. When Gregory realized that the storm had passed, he stood up and shook off as much sand and dust as he could. The little girls once jet-black hair was now a shade of crusty orange.

"Can we find my mama now?" she asked.

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"Of course, we can!" said Gregory, smiling at her and trying not to laugh at her heavy coating of dust. Picking her up, he proceeded to walk toward the center of the caravan. In the distance they could see a frantic woman running toward them, looking from side to side, crying out, "Has anyone seen a little girl?"

"I have," said Gregory.

The woman stopped and looked at him. For a moment he thought that possibly the girl, that he held was not her daughter. Perhaps he had found a different missing child. The woman stopped, stood and stared. She suddenly realized that this mass of tangled orange hair and liberal coating of dust was indeed hers and burst into tears of joy and relief.

"May Allah bless you," she cried, taking the girl from Gregory's arms. "Where did you find her?" she asked.

"We ran into each other as the storm began. She was headed out into the desert." Gregory responded. "I feared that she would be lost and covered with sand."

"You saved my daughter's life," the woman sobbed, tears running down her cheeks, leaving streaks in the dust that covered her face.

"I am happy that I could help," said Gregory, smiling. "I must go now to see if the rest of my party fared as well."

Turning he walked back toward the front of the caravan where he found Charles, Adiba, Jamcela, Nicholas, Khalil, Steven and Father Ludolphus standing in a circle trying to brush off the sand and dust that caked their hair and clothes.

"Have you people seen my family and friends?" Gregory called out.

"Bold talk for a man with a mound of dust over each eyebrow!" answered Charles, grinning at his friend's appearance.

"Are you all survivors?" asked Gregory. "I have sand absolutely everywhere," cried Nicholas.

"We all do!" added Jamcela. "I would give anything for a bath or even a stream to sit in."

"We could all use some dusting off!" offered Charles.

Turning to look at Ludolphus, who was also covered with dust, Gregory asked, "Are you also well, Father?"

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“I survived,” he answered. “As the storm began, I prayed for our safety and clearly my prayers were answered.”

“That is good,” said Gregory, turning to look at Charles. Neither of them saying anything more.

“What should we do now?” asked Khalil.

“It would be good for us to get as much rest as we can before the evenings journey,” said Charles. “Gregory and I will go to speak with the Khabir, to see if there is anything else that we need to do.”

As they started to walk to find the caravan leader, Gregory turned to Charles and asked,

“Does he really think that his prayers made all the difference?”

“I sometimes wonder about that also. Does it seem to you that the closer we get to Rome, the more pious our priest becomes?”

“Lord only knows,” said Gregory, smiling.

Chapter 22

July 1341

Road from Jerusalem to Jaffa

Two days later, the caravan arrived at a field outside of Jerusalem. Charles and Gregory stood together staring at the massive stone walls, each lost in his own thoughts. This was the city that they had come so far to recapture. The city so significant to their order. The founding knights of the Templars were participants in the 1099 conquest of this ancient city that the Arabs called Al-Quds. It had a history dating back to the fourth millennium BCE, making it one of the oldest cities in the world. It remained in western hands for eighty-eight years and was the capital of what the Frankish forces referred to as the Kingdom of Jerusalem. Saladin recaptured Jerusalem in 1187 and permitted the faithful from all religions to worship there.

Thirty years before Charles and Gregory arrived in Outremer, the Mamluks had conquered all of Palestine, including Jerusalem, adding it to what came to be known as the Mamluk Sultanate. While most pilgrims were allowed to visit their faith's holy places, The Knights of the Temple were not on that guest list. Templars would never be welcome in Mamluk-ruled lands.

After the caravan had settled outside the city walls the Khabir, Arsalan, came to Charles and Gregory to tell them that Jerusalem was the end of his journey, but that he knew of another

caravan led by a friend that was leaving for Jaffa the following evening. He said that he had already asked his colleague if Charles' and Gregory's party might join his caravan and was told that it would be acceptable. Both Charles and Gregory were surprised by Arsalan's kind help with the second leg of their journey. They had rarely had the opportunity to speak with him on the trip from Karak. Even so, he wished them well and told them when and where to meet the new caravan master, a man named Omar.

This second Khabir was very much like his colleague Arsalan. Caravan masters, like their seagoing counterparts, tended to be a serious lot who had absolute authority over their enterprise. Like a seagoing vessel, the caravan carried large amounts of valuable cargo through areas that presented a variety of dangerous, sometimes deadly hazards. When dealing with robbers, sand storms or dry wells, sound judgement and strong leadership was always the critical factor in the success or failure of a journey.

Like the first caravan, Omar's was one of moderate size, consisting of eight men called camel pullers, each leading a string of eighteen camels. Caravans could consist of as many as five hundred camels and although they were often referred to as the ships of the desert, it would take a caravan of one thousand camels to carry the same amount of cargo as the average sailing ship.

Travel between Jerusalem and Jaffa was along a well-worn familiar and more densely populated route with many opportunities to purchase additional provisions. At various locations along the way there were roadside stations called *caravanserais* where travelers could find water for man and beast. In some places water for washing and ablutions. When Abdula and Jamcela heard of this possibility they smiled in hopeful anticipation.

In a little over twenty-four hours after their arrival at the walls of Jerusalem, Charles, Gregory and their entourage began the final leg of the journey to Jaffa. Once again, due to the kindness of the new Khabir, they were allowed to travel near the front of the caravan, where conditions were much more comfortable.

On the third night of their journey, about three hours into their nighttime travels, the caravan stopped to rest the animals after climbing a long, steep section of the road. Once the entire caravan

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was on the large rocky, brush-covered plateau, the Khabir ordered the drivers and travelers to stop, rest, water their animals and take care of any necessary trips out into the desert to relieve themselves. It was a clear moonlit night and the view from the crest of the hill was breathtaking. Bathed in soft moonlight the brush and rock of the land that looked so desolate in bright sunlight took on a softer, much more tranquil appearance under the stars.

A group of boys and young men walked a short way out into the desert and were conversing, laughing and joking as they took care of their needs. One of the younger boys, a shy lad, had walked away from the raucous group to urinate alone against a stone outcropping. When he had finished and was turning to rejoin the group, he spotted a shiny object, reflecting moonlight, near a small rock wall. He bent down to examine the coin-sized item. As his fingers touched the object, he felt something strike the side of his neck. At first, he thought that a rock had come loose from the formation and hit him. He reached up to feel the side of his neck. When he looked at his hand, he saw a small amount of blood on his fingertips. Immediately the side of his neck began to burn. He suddenly felt dizzy. His head throbbed. He fell to his knees and then landed face first on the sand and rocks. His body twitched for a moment. Then he lay still.

Some of the other boys, seeing him fall, came rushing to his side. The first to arrive reached out to shake him and ask if he was alright. He did not respond. As the friend looked up, he saw a snake with a diamond shaped head, rust-colored flanks, dull white diamond-shaped markings with a solid red line running through them along the top of its back. The boy quickly stood up and jumped back from the rock wall. The serpent remained coiled and did not move.

“Painted carpet-viper,” was all the boy said. One of the other boys ran back to the caravan and found some men including the injured boy’s father. While trying to catch his breath, he asked them to come and help. By the time the men arrived at the scene, the snake was gone and the boy that it had been bitten was growing cold. One of the men returned to the caravan to inform the Khabir, Omar.

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Omar found the young boy's mother and walked with her out to where her son lay. When he heard the account of what had happened, he nodded his head.

"I am truly saddened to see this," Omar said to the boy's parents. "The carpet-viper is responsible for more fatal snake bites than all of the other poisonous snakes in this land combined. It can be a very painful death! Allah was merciful in that your son did not suffer."

The parents knelt in the sand next to the body of their child. The wife cried softly. The boy's father stared silently.

"It is always a tragedy to lose a son," said Omar, "but we cannot stay here. I can give you a little time to bury him, but we must move on quickly." Without another word he turned and returned to his duties.

With the help of several men, the father dug a shallow grave where he and his wife left their son. News of the child's death spread through the caravan. Parents quickly checked on their children, quietly feeling guilty about the relief they felt that the victim was not one of theirs. All knew that though the Levant was considered by some to be god's Promised Land, it was an unforgiving place. For many, life there could be harsh and brief. For all, death was never far away. The caravan moved on.

When they arrived in Jaffa, Ludolphus announced that he was going to the waterfront in search of his childhood friend, the sea captain, Wolfgang von Suchem. There he would inquire about passage on the captain's merchant ship. Charles and Gregory remained at the well, on the outskirts of the city, with Adiba, Jamcela, Steven, Nicholas and Khalil.

Shortly after mid-day, Ludolphus returned smiling.

"I have very good news. The captain has room for all of us and will not charge us extra since we are returning two members of the Knights of the Temple. We will have to gather our own food for the first part of the journey as the ship carries only provisions for the captain and crew. We will be making several stops at ports along the way and will be able to buy more food as we go. We may be expected to man the oars along with the crew if we become

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becalmed, but there is no way to tell until we discover what winds the sea have in store for us.”

He spoke to a group wearing smiles on every face, with the exception of Khalil, who had tears of joy in his eyes and Steven who displayed his usual blank stare, as if he expected nothing less than good news.

Chapter 23

August 1, 1341

Port of Jaffa

Despite being tired from their evening's journey, the travelers were anxious to proceed to the Jaffa dock. Charles told the others to go with Ludolphus while he went to find a buyer for their burrows. The proceeds would be used buy food and provisions for the voyage. He said that he would meet them at the dock when he was finished.

Led by Ludolphus, the group found the ship captained by his childhood friend. It had been over fifty years since Charles and Gregory had arrived in Outremer, on a vessel very much like the one before them. Ludolphus, Steven and Nicholas had come to the Levant on this very boat, just five years earlier. Jamcela, Adiba and Khalil had seen ships like this passing by the coast at various times, but had never been this close to one. They stared, wide-eyed and silent.

Captain Wolfgang's ship was typical of the gallies used in the Mediterranean by merchants, travelers and armies. Often referred to as merchantman gallies, these vessels were primarily designed to carry large quantities of cargo. Though they came equipped with one, two or three masts, their primary source of propulsion was the banks of oars along both the port and starboard sides. Reliance on oars required the presence of a large number of

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sailors to man them. While this arrangement limited the amount of cargo that could be moved, the extra manpower was necessary on windless days and came in handy in the event of pirate attacks, which were not uncommon on the Mediterranean.

As was the case with all wooden seagoing vessels, this ship had the distinct odor of the tar and pitch used to seal the wooden beans and planks and protect them from the ravages of sun, weather, salt water and wood-eating insects. Even when at rest, tied to a dock, the ship sang a subtle song; a rhythm of creaking wood, gentle lapping water and the soft whistling of breeze through the rigging.

The three masts on Captain Wolfgang's ship were equipped with cross spars that supported large square sails that could only be used only in following winds. There was no way to tack into the wind. Maneuvering was accomplished by the use of a steering oar, usually mounted on the right side near the stern, as it was on this ship.

To those not familiar with sailing ships, they can look like a confusing mass of ropes and pullies. For those viewing them from a dock, the sides of a boat can seem imposing.

Seeing the confusion on their faces, Gregory turned to the women and boys and quipped,

"Fear not my friends, it will not bite you."

Adiba turned to Gregory with a look of feigned displeasure,

"We know that, we are just surprised that it is so big. So long."

"It seems big now," said Gregory, "but after a week on board, out to sea, she will seem to shrink a little each day. By the end of our voyage, you will be delighted to once again stand on solid ground. If you get as sea sick as Charles and I did on our voyage here, you will be longing for dry land in much less than a week's time."

"If we are fortunate, she will be sea-worthy also," said Charles coming up behind them.

"That was quick," said Gregory turning around to see his friend approaching. "Were you able to sell the burros so fast?"

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“Yes, I did not even make it to the market before I ran into a merchant with too much cargo and not enough pack animals. I was surprised at how much he offered me for them and gladly took his payment.”

“May the rest of our voyage go that smoothly,” said Gregory.

As the party stood on the dock next to the large galley, Ludolphus called out to the ship to see if the captain was on board.

“I am and to address your concern, my ship is both sound and sea-worthy,” answered a booming voice from above. Looking up they saw a stout, barrel-chested man with a full beard and long grey hair. He was smiling down at them. Pointing to the boarding ramp he said,

“Come aboard and I will show you my ship, the Santa Christina.”

Once on board, Ludolphus took a moment to introduce the knights to the captain. Almost as an after-thought he gestured toward their wives and the three young men and said that they would be coming along also. Wolfgang warmly greeted each of his passengers. Facing Gregory and Charles he said, “I considered it an honor to have members of the Knights of the Temple on board. Many decades ago, when I was a very young sailor, I served on several ships that transported Templars to various ports in the Mediterranean. In those days, we were all impressed by the amount of equipment and personnel it took to support a single knight.”

Gregory smiled, “Yes, a great deal of equipment and much support was required to keep a knight ready for battle.”

“As I remember it, for each knight, there were two sergeants and one squire. In addition, there were chests of equipment, three of the war horses you referred to as Destriers, two or more horses for each sergeant and a horse and pack mule for the squire. We used to say that three knights with their entourage, horses and equipment took up the space on a ship that could be used to transport twenty ordinary men at arms.”

“Yes, we remember hearing that,” said Charles shaking his head and smiling, “We liked to joke that every mounted knight was worth more than twenty, foot soldiers on the battle field.”

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“That may have well been true,” said Wolfgang, smiling. “Now that I captain my own ship, I am pleased to be able to transport two Knights of the Temple back to their homelands with a very different entourage.”

Turning to Steven, Nicholas and Khalil he added, “And it never hurts to have more stout, young lads available to man the oars in case we became becalmed.”

Nicholas and Khalil beamed with pride at being refer to as stout. Steven sulked.

Turning back to Gregory and Charles, Wolfgang said, “This is the best time of year to be sailing west since the seas will be much calmer than they will be in another month. It will be a longer voyage than your initial trip to the Levant since sailing from west to east is much easier and takes less time due to the west-to-east prevailing winds. While your trip, those many years ago, was relatively fast, sailing with the wind, our return trip can take much longer.”

“Yes,” said Charles, “we have heard that the seas are relatively calm in late summer and that this is the best time for gallies to be at sea.”

“That is true, but as you probably remember there is always the danger of strong currents, unexpected winds near mountainous shorelines and the ever-present danger of pirates.”

“We remember the pirates well,” said Gregory smiling. “On our voyage to the Holy Land we were on the lead ship which was far ahead of the main fleet. A ship of pirates came out from the coast and attacked us assuming that we were a merchant vessel. It was not until they were within bow range that they realized that they were attacking a ship full of Templar Knights and sergeants. After we loosed the first flight of arrows and cross-bow bolts, they turned and rowed as fast as they could back to their home port. When the rest of our fleet arrived, our Grand Master sent two ships in to follow the retreating pirates to their base. Once there, our brothers burned every ship in their harbor and killed every man, woman and child in the town.”

“From what we heard, once the other pirate crews came to recognize our Templar ships, with the Red Cross on their mainsails, they never attacked another one.” said Charles.

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“Let us hope that we do not see any bad weather or pirates on this voyage,” said Wolfgang, “but enough talk, let us get this voyage underway. We will have plenty of time to share tales as we go.”

Turning to his crew Wolfgang gave the order to cast off lines and row the ship to the harbor entrance. Without another word, the crewmembers moved to their stations and the ship was faced out to sea. It was clear that they had done this many times before and worked well together. The captain stood silently watching the process and did not say another word until they had left the harbor. Once clear of the entrance he shouted, “Make ready to make sail.”

Some crewmembers untied the ropes holding the folded sails to the booms while others stood by with rope-lines attached to the bottom corner of each sail. When the captain shouted “make sail” they pulled on the ropes and the sails that had been folded up against the spars, fell free and came down to almost deck level. The ship shuddered slightly as the wind filled her three sheets. The lines were secured and the voyage was underway.

Captain Wolfgang gave the rigging a quick inspection and then turned to walk over to where Charles and Gregory were standing near the gunnel.

“Smoothly done,” said Gregory. “Your men seem very well trained.”

“I tolerate none that are not,” said Wolfgang still watching the crew work, “Seamen are an interesting lot. Many of these crew members had to make a choice to either work as honest sailors or take their chances as pirates. I always treat them with respect, but I also never let them forget that if they do not respond in kind, I will not hesitate to feed them to the fishes. It has been my experience that when given no other choice, most men will almost always do the right thing.”

“We would agree,” said Charles, “but the responsibility to maintain that order lies with the commander and that degree of leadership is not always evident.”

“Worry not my friends, it is present here, in abundance.”

“I can see that,” said Gregory. “Where do we sail to first?”

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“First we sail north along the coast past Haifa, Tyre, Beirut and Tripoli. From there, we will sail west across open water to Famagusta on the island of Cyprus. We then sail along the coast of Cyprus to Limassol and from there to Kandia on the island of Rhodes. Our next port will be Itonas on Crete. We will then proceed along the northern shore of Crete to Kydonia and from there across the open water to Kytheria. That will bring us to our greatest stretch of open water from Kytheria to Rhegion. Depending on the weather we will either make the voyage between those two ports or sail along the coast of the Greek Isles to cross at Lecce. When we reach Rhegion we will hire a pilot to guide us through the straits of Messina. I’ll explain why when we get there.”

“It sounds like you have done this voyage a few times before,” said Gregory.

“Too many times to count. I have never lost a ship, crew or cargo to winds, storms or pirates and I don’t intend to ruin that record on this voyage.”

“We’ll do what we can to help you keep your perfect record,” said Charles.

“I know that you will,” said Wolfgang, patting the two knights on the shoulders.

“As you can see, we have a full cargo both on deck and in the hold. Feel free to make yourselves comfortable and find a sleeping area among the cotton bales. Now I have to attend to my crew, please excuse me.”

When Charles and Gregory turned to relay this information to their wives, they noticed that in the strong sea breeze, both women were holding their hijabs on their heads with both hands.

“This could be a long voyage if you always need both hands to keep your heads covered!” said Gregory

“Indeed, Charles added, “How would you feel if we asked the captain if it would be permissible for you to uncover your heads?”

“We would feel delighted!” said Adiba. We have never really enjoyed wearing the hijab and would be happy to take them off!” Jamcela nodded in agreement.

Gregory looked at Charles who was also nodding.

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"It's unanimous," said Gregory, "I will take this up with the captain, and come back with his decision!"

As Gregory walked away, Charles turned to the women and said, "Let us find a place among the cargo bales where we can sleep out of the wind and not be in the way of the crew. Looking at Khalil, he said, "You should find a place near-by so we can find you quickly, should there be an emergency".

Once they had found places to sleep between the bales of cotton and large bags of silk cloth, the women and Khalil went to stand at the port railing to watch the harbor slowly shrink and fade from view. Standing next to them Khalil looked at Adiba and Jamcela with a curious expression on his face. When Adiba saw him staring at her she asked, "is there something wrong?"

"Your faces," said Khalil. "You seem to be turning green!"

Adiba turned to look at her sister and asked, "are you feeling well? You are a little off-color."

"So are you," said Jamcela, "I am dizzy and feel like I am about to be sick! You too look a little green."

"I feel like I did when I was first with child and could not keep food down," answered Adiba.

As both of the women held onto the ship's rail and leaned over. Khalil said,

"I will go and summon your husbands!" Without waiting for a response, he hurried off toward the stern of the ship. It was a while before the men came back with Khalil. They arrived to see both women still leaning over the rail.

"I see you are feeding the fishes," said Gregory, laughing.

"It is not funny," said Adiba, "we both feel terrible, like we are again with child!"

"At our ages, that is highly unlikely," said Charles.

"It is much more likely that you are just sea sick," said Gregory, "On our first voyage to the Holy Land, it seemed like every Templar on board was leaning over the rail".

"The sailors on that voyage laughed at us and told us that we were 'shouting at the sea'."

"That is not funny," said Jamcela, "How long were you like this?"

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“Most of us were over it in a few days,” said Charles.

“And the others?” asked Adiba.

“They just finally gave up and jumped overboard,” said Gregory.

Adiba looked angry and was about to say something when she suddenly turned around and leaned over the rail, quickly followed by Jamcela.

“Perhaps we should let them recover by themselves,” said Gregory turning to walk away. Charles nodded and quickly followed him. Khalil was close behind.

After a day and a night at sea, both of the women began to feel much better and were able to eat without constantly looking for a clear path to the ship’s rail. As time went on, they were not only much more comfortable, but started to develop an appreciation for the rhythm and beauty of the sea. They delighted at the sighting of dolphins who frequently kept pace with the bow of the ship and the never-ending array of noisy and colorful sea birds circling overhead. It would be fair to say that in time they came to understand what drew men to a life at sea and brought them to be more at ease on the waves than they ever were on dry land.

Chapter 24

August 1341

Sailing past Acre on the Santa Christina

Those first days at sea, cruising north, along the coast of Outremer, gave the travelers an opportunity to see cities and countryside from a different perspective. Never having been on a boat of any kind, Adiba and Jamcela were fascinated by the rugged, rocky shoreline, the crystal clear water and the abundance of sealife. The nearly constant offshore breeze cooled the heat of the day. They were happy to spend hours at the shore-side railing looking for the next city, and asking where they were at that point. Unlike traveling by caravan, which was a night-time activity, travel by boat was an around-the-clock event.

Turning to her sister, Jamcela asked, “How are you feeling? Do you think we may be over the sea-sickness?” “*Insha’Allah*,” Adiba responded, “I truly hope to never go through that again. Our husbands were right, it only lasted for a few days.” Tuning to look at her sister, she asked quietly, “Did I hear Charles call out in his sleep last night?”

“Yes, you might have, every once in a while, he has a nightmare, something to do with a bad experience he had during a battle. I know that it embarrasses him and he does not want to talk about it, so I don’t mention it to him.”

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“That is probably best. Have you thought about the fact that we are leaving our homeland, our children and everything that we have ever known?” Adiba continued, “We will probably never see any of those people or places again.”

“I have several times,” responded Jamcela, looking out at the water, “but I also remind myself that I am leaving behind many things that were unpleasant in our former lives. When all of this change worries me, I remind myself that we have had a life so much better, so much richer than the one we had before us, when we were a part of the Sultan’s harem.”

“That is true,” said Adiba. “Instead of being one of a dozen wives or concubines competing for our master’s attention and approval, we have both had wonderful husbands of our own.”

“Yes,” said Jamcela, smiling, “and we have had them all to ourselves. Neither one of them wanted more wives.”

“Yes, and they were delighted with the daughters that we gave them. Neither of them seemed disappointed that they did not have sons.”

“When we were growing up, I did not know that there were any men like that anywhere,” said Jamcela, laughing. “I think, deep down inside, I feel the same way that you do. Aside from the fact that these two men have saved our lives several times, they have given us long and wonderful lives that we would have never had if we had not met them.”

“Do you know where our wonderful husbands are now?” asked Adiba, laughing.

“Yes, they are behind you, at the starboard rail.”

Turning the women saw Charles and Gregory standing together. Gregory was pointing toward a very large structure along the shoreline. As they came closer, they could see a massive stonewall. Where it reached the sea, at the entrance to what looked like a harbor, there was an enormous pile of large, scattered building stones. Some lay in the sand on the shore, others were half submerged and covered with mussels and barnacles.

Adiba turned and started to walk toward the men when Jamcela reached out to hold her arm.

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“Perhaps we should leave them alone,” she offered. “They seem to be upset about something.”

“Very possibly.” said a voice from behind them. Turning the women saw Captain Wolfgang. He seemed serious, even sad.

“That is the ruins of Acre. Father Ludolphus told me that is where your husbands were captured. After that battle, the Sultan had the fortress destroyed and the city has been uninhabited ever since.”

“Yes, that was the work of our great grandfather,” said Jamcela. “We, of course, never knew him, but as we grew up, we heard stories of how he defeated the Christian Franks and drove them from his lands.”

“We are just so happy that he did not also kill the men who would one day be our husbands,” added Adiba.

“I am sure that you are,” said Wolfgang, smiling “Perhaps we should give them some time alone to experience the sadness that they must be feeling.”

“We do not know for certain, but we suspect, from what they have told us, that they have a sense of guilt for having survived when all of the other members of their order were executed,” said Adiba.

“I am not surprised,” said Wolfgang. “The survivors of traumatic experiences are often haunted by a sense of guilt, asking themselves, ‘why not me’?”

As the captain and the women looked at the two knights gazing at the ghost-like remnants of the once mighty citadel, they saw Charles reach up and wipe his eyes with the hem of his tunic.

“Must have something in his eye,” suggested Adiba.

“Hardly the first tears shed for that tragedy,” said Wolfgang, smiling as he turned to return to his duties.

“We can talk to them later,” suggested Jamcela. “Perhaps we should leave them alone for now?” Adiba nodded. “Considering what happened to all of their brother knights, that place must be full of ghosts. It’s little wonder that they have nightmares about it.”

At the rail, Gregory turned to look at Charles.

“It looks so different now, does it not?” he asked.

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“Yes and no.”

“Our surviving that tower collapse was truly a miracle, look at that pile of rubble,” added Gregory.

“There were times, I thought of it as more of a curse,” said Charles. “Today I see it as a blessing.”

“As do I.”

Charles softly replied, “And yet, while those ruins have remained deserted by the living, I suspect that they are alive with the spirits of the thousands whose lives ended violently there.”

Nodding his head, Gregory sighed, “May we all find peace there some day.”

Standing in silence, they watched as what was left of Acre faded into the distance.

Turning to Charles, Gregory said,

“It’s may seem funny, but for the first time, as we sail away from Outremer, I feel truly free.”

Chapter 25

August 1341

Aboard the galley Santa Christina off the Greek Isles

An hour before first light, the ship moved at a slow, steady pace, pushed along by a gentle breeze. The sea lapping against the hull and the constant creaking of the rigging, the only sounds other than the snoring of the crew and passengers. Captain Wolfgang was on the upper, aft-deck with the helmsman. Listening to the song of the ship, they knew that all was well.

Among themselves, the crew joked that the captain rarely slept, but when he did it was ‘with one eye open’. The other persons always awake at this hour were the helmsman at the rudder and the top watchman stationed on the small platform high in the ships rigging. This night the watch was a man named Enzo, who came from the beautiful coastal area called Cinque Terra. He had been on duty all night and was happy to see his replacement climbing the rigging to relieve him. The sailor taking over the next watch was Vito who the captain had awakened from a dream of his hometown of San Gimignano, south of Florence. Though Vito missed his home and extended family, who had lived in the hill country for generations, he loved the sea and his life as a sailor. After getting a quick drink of watered wine he started his climb the rigging. When he reached the platform, he greeted the man on duty. “Quiet night?”

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“Quiet as the grave,” said Enzo. “Some dolphins swam along with us for a short while, but other than that, nothing to report.”

“That’s the way we like it,” patting Enzo’s shoulder he began his descent to the deck. As he did at the beginning of every watch, Vito scanned the sea in all directions. He paid special attention to the starboard side as they were sailing north along the coast of the Greek Isles. Most nights one could see light coming from buildings, campfires or cooking fires along the shore. This morning there were no lights. It was still dark enough that he could barely make out the coastline. There were also no lights on the ship. The main concern in this stretch of coast was pirates and there was no need to alert those watching from shore that a slow-moving, heavily laden merchant ship was making its way north. Along with sudden storms, freak winds and hidden rocks, pirates presented the greatest danger to ships at sea. It was never wise to alert them to one’s presence.

At the first hint of morning light, Vito began to concentrate his attention on the coastline. He quickly scanned the sea off the port, bow and then slowly examined the starboard sea. That shoreline was just beginning to be evident. As he watched, Vito thought about the number of times he had executed this duty during his twelve years at sea. He did not need to remind himself that no matter how many times a sailor did this well it only took one moment of carelessness to end a perfect record and possibly his life. His captain’s words haunted him, ‘life at sea can be a classic adventure, but it can also be short and brutal for those who do not remain vigilant!’

Vito looked to his right, toward the stern and slowly moved his gaze to the left, carefully examining the areas that they would soon pass. Suddenly he looked back to the right. Movement caught his eye. Something along the darkly-outlined distant beach. At first, he could not make it out. Whatever was moving had no discernable shape, a dark form moving across a drab, rocky shoreline. As he had learned to do, he looked away and then looked back, hoping that the image would clear. Gradually it appeared to move away from the shore. It was a ship. Approximately the same size as theirs.

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It carried no sail. It was moving under a full complement of oars. Vito could see the flash of the early morning light off of the oars as they went forward for another stroke, dripping water as they moved. It was clear that all oars were being used and the ship was moving at a rapid pace. It wasn't coming straight out from shore, but rather moving to his left, on an intercept course. Without hesitation Vito leaned over the side of the platform and called out, "ship off the starboard bow, closing fast."

Without looking up at Vito or to the starboard shore, Wolfgang shouted, "men to oars." Not another word was needed as the crew jumped to their feet from a sound sleep, pulling the oars from their storage racks. They fed the oars through the oar locks spaced along both rails.

"Man every other oar. The rest to arms," Wolfgang shouted.

Running up to the captain, the suddenly awakened Nicholas and Khalil shouted, "can we help?"

"Yes, we need all the speed we can muster. "said Wolfgang, "Ask the oarsmen what you can do."

"Can we help also?" asked Charles.

Looking over his shoulder at the man who towered over him Wolfgang said, "I may have another duty for you."

While they watched the approaching ship, Gregory came up behind them.

"Hope I haven't missed anything," he said with a grin on his face.

"Not yet," said Wolfgang keeping his eyes on the approaching ship, only looking away for a moment to see if preparations were going as planned. Half the crew was at the oars moving the ship as fast as a heavily laden merchant vessel could hope to go. The rest of the crew had returned from below decks armed with short bows, long pikes and boat hooks as well as a few swords.

Charles and Gregory looked at the crew, then at each other. No need to speak. It was obvious that these men were willing. The way they handled their weapons made it clear that they were not trained men at arms.

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Only the rhythm of the moving oars and the sound of water slapping the ship's hull broke the silence as the approaching ship pulled up to within hailing distance and kept pace with the slowly moving merchant ship. Carrying only its crew, the second ship had no difficulty keeping up with the heavily laden vessel.

"We demand you surrender," shouted one of the two men standing on the aft deck.

"Surrender without a fight we will take only your cargo and let your ship and crew go unharmed."

As this man yelled his message, a taller, better dressed man, stood to his left, hands on his hips. Wolfgang turned and said, "Just as I thought. Pirates. They will take the ship and its cargo, capture the women and boys to sell into slavery and kill the rest of us."

"Can your crew fight back?" asked Charles.

"It's our only choice," replied Wolfgang. "They have more men, but we still stand a chance. Half the crew will keep us moving. They can use the oars to keep the pirate ship at a distance. The others will be ready to repel boarders. As you can see, we have bows, clubs, pikes and a few swords."

"We both have scimitars," said Gregory, "and we have some experience in these matters."

"I am sure you do." replied the captain, but I have another idea. I have an excellent crossbow and some bolts that I won in a dice game at our last port. I have never used it and I am confident that none of my crew has any experience with this type of weapon either."

"I would suggest that you send someone to get the crossbow quickly," said Charles.

Wolfgang ordered his first-mate to go to the captain's cabin and bring the bow and bolts back on deck as quickly as possible. He then shouted the order for the oarsmen to keep rowing at a steady pace. As they waited for the crossbow the three of them kept an eye on the pirate ship. Turning to Wolfgang, Charles said, "I was never a great shot with the crossbow."

"That is true, said Gregory. "I am not sure that Brother Charles could shoot himself in the foot with a crossbow."

Charles turned to Gregory, frowning.

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“Why would you say that?” asked the captain, keeping an eye on the pirate ship.

“Years ago, when we were sieging a Saracen castle our forces were camped safely out of bow and catapult range of the fortress, however a group of Saracen archers would stand on the castle walls and when the wind was blowing in the right direction, shoot fire arrows high into the sky in the direction of our encampment. The wind would carry the arrows toward us, where they would land on our tents and set them on fire.

Charles and I, along with four other knights were sent with crossbows to get close to the city walls and do what we could to discourage the archers. Five of us stood behind large boulders with our crossbows cocked, while the sixth man watched for archers to appear on the walls. When he gave the signal, we were to step out from behind the rock, raise our weapons and shoot at the unsuspecting bowmen. When the signal was given, we did as planned; except that Brother Charles bumped the trigger on his crossbow as he started to bring it up to his shoulder and it went off shooting the bolt into the sand a short distance from his feet. The rest of us were laughing so hard that only one of our shots hit a man on the wall. That was enough. After watching their comrade fall forward off the high castle wall, the Saracens learned their lesson and never again tried to set our camp on fire. The story of Charles shooting and missing his feet of course has lived on forever!”

The captain smiled. Turning to Charles he said, “I am sorry to laugh, but that is a funny story.” Charles shook his head and look back toward the other ship.

“So, you will be doing the shooting?” Wolfgang said looking at Gregory.

“Yes,” Gregory said placing the short, heavy steel-tipped arrow-bolt into the groove on the cocked crossbolt.

The ships were gently rolling on the mild seas as the oarsmen on both continue to pull the vessels forward. Gregory braced himself against the ships rail and took careful aim. Charles moved closer and softly asked,

“Will you shoot before the pirates come aboard our ship?” Gregory smiled at Charles. Just as the spokesman for the pirates

began to shout another demand, Gregory shot. The captain, crew, and passengers, all looking at the shouting pirate and saw that he had suddenly stopped shouting. He turned his head to look at the man standing next to him. who had dropped his hands to his sides. The feathered end of a crossbow bolt protruding from his forehead. The man stood still for a moment. He then crumbled straight down like a puppet whose strings had been cut.

A chorus of cheers went up from the merchant crew followed by vulgar oaths in their various native languages, accompanied by a variety of hand gestures. Captain Wolfgang smiled while patting Gregory on the back: "I see that the legends of your order are true! That is the best shot I have ever seen! Two ships on a rolling sea and you put the bolt square in the pirate captain's head. "

Wolfgang's crew continued to cheer, shout foul oaths and make ribald suggestions as to what the pirate crew might do with their own mothers. All crude possibilities were accompanied with a variety of obscene gestures.

Adiba, Jamcela, Ludolphus and Steven, carefully looked out from the space between the bales of cargo where they had been cowering.

Charles turned to look at his grinning companion who quietly said, "I must beg to differ with our captain. That might just be the worst shot he's ever seen! I was aiming at the loud man standing next to him."

"I don't think the pirates see it that way; they seem to be turning away to get out of range, "said Charles.

"That will be enough!" shouted Wolfgang. His men went silent immediately. "We have distance to put between ourselves and those barbarians."

Turning to Charles, Gregory and Ludolphus, who had just emerged from his hiding place, he said, "I must apologize for the conduct of my men, using such language in the company of a priest and your ladies."

"There is no need for apology," said Charles. "Our wives do not understand the meaning of the oaths in languages they do not speak and I am certain that they were not offended, but are most

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grateful to you and your crew. As to the hand gestures, there were several that were new even for two old warriors like us.”

“Yes, the people of my land are famous for speaking with their hands. There is an old joke that the best way to silence a person from Genoa is to tie their hands behind their backs. Now back to sailing.”

Turning to the crew, Wolfgang gave the order to stow the oars and reset the sails, and run with the stronger breeze that was coming up. Keeping an eye on the retreating pirate ship, he added, “We will sail further off shore for the rest of the day. That will make more work for any others who wish to attack us.”

Patting Charles and Gregory on the back he turned to attend to his duties. As he walked toward the aft deck, he encountered Nicholas and Khalil. He patted each of them on the head and said,

“You make fine deck hands. You worked the oars today like you meant it! If you ever seek a life at sea, come and find me first. Good men are always in demand.” The two boys stood tall and beamed with pride as the captain walked on.

Gregory and Charles turned and walked aft, to where the cargo was secured and their wives had been hiding along with Ludolphus and Steven. The women emerged from their hiding place and met their husbands. There were tears in both of their eyes. Without a word they reached out to hug the knights.

“Do not cry,” said Charles smiling, “I believe we are safe at least from those pirates.”

Adiba started to speak, but her words were choked with tears. Jancela cleared her throat, smiled through her tears and quietly said,

“Yet again the two of you save us.” She started to speak again but lost her voice and buried her face in Charles’ chest and sobbed with relief and joy.

“You have no idea how many times the two of you have saved us,” said Gregory, holding Adiba and gently stroking her hair. The two couples walked to the ships rail and looked out at the quiet sea. No more words were needed.

Chapter 26

September 1341

Santa Christina, Ionian Sea

On the days following the pirate attack the seas were calm, the winds favorable and the sailing enjoyable. In the early morning light, before sunrise, Charles and Gregory stood along the rail watching the coastline slip by in the distance. Yet another of the ship's crewmembers stopped on his way by to thank and congratulate Gregory for saving them from the pirates. Once again Gregory smiled, nodded and told the sailor, "It was my pleasure to be helpful". Once again Charles smiled, shook his head and looked away.

"What would they be saying if you had missed?" asked Charles, after the sailor had walked on.

"Something less charitable?" suggested Gregory.

"Whatever they might say, it would be quietly mumbled with a mouth full of sea water as we all headed for the bottom." He paused a moment. "I have to say your lucky shot came close to restoring my faith in the divine. There is no doubt that God cares for children and idiots and that you share that affection."

"I have often thought that might be the case," said Gregory, grinning. "Several times in battle when a spear would whistle past my helmet or a Saracen arrow meant for me would wind up stuck

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in a Mamluk coming up behind me, I thought I felt the presence of a protecting hand.”

“Well, as we have heard at least a hundred times, there is nothing quite as satisfying as being shot at and missed!” added Charles.

Coming up behind them, Captain Wolfgang, greeted them. “Good morning gentlemen, beautiful day is it not?”

“Truly,” responded Charles.

“Are you ready for our next challenge?” Wolfgang asked.

“Do you expect more pirates?” asked Gregory.

“No, our next adventure is courtesy of Mother Nature. By midday we will be near the Stretto di Messina, the narrow strait between the eastern tip of Sicily and the western tip of Calabria. It connects the Ionian Sea, where we currently sail, to the Tyrrhenian Sea to our north.”

“Does that present a problem?” asked Charles.

“Possibly,” said Wolfgang. “At its narrowest point between Torre Faro and Villa San Giovanni, the strait is less than two miles wide and has shifting tidal currents and strong winds that create a large natural whirlpool. Some think was the inspiration for the Greek legend of Scylla, the six-headed sea monster and Charybdis, the ship swallowing whirlpool.”

“Yes, we both studied Greek and Latin and read about that In Homer’s Odyssey,” said Gregory.

“Well tomorrow morning, you will have a chance to see it first-hand. The land you see on the horizon, off our bow, is the isle of Sicily. The smoke you see rising over the land is from the island’s famous Mountain of Fire, which, from time to time, belches smoke, noxious fumes and occasionally liquid fire that runs down the side of the mountain into the sea. Some of the local residents claim that the mountain is one of the portals of Hell.”

“As if sea monsters and deadly whirlpools were not enough,” laughed Gregory.

“Truly,” said Wolfgang, smiling.

“We will make port at Messina this afternoon where I will hire a pilot who knows these waters well and we will pay him to guide us safely through the strait tomorrow morning.”

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“Is the passage that difficult?” asked Gregory.

“Not that difficult for those who sail it daily.” said Wolfgang. “The challenge is to stay far enough away from shore on the port side to avoid shallow reefs and rocks, while at the same time not going close enough to be sucked into the whirlpool on the starboard side. In a large, heavily burdened merchant ship, such as ours, it requires precise navigating, since quick maneuvering in a fully loaded vessel is not possible. I will contact a pilot that I have worked with many times. I assure you he will make the passage look easy and safe.”

Within the hour the ship arrived in the port of Messina, with its beautiful sickle shaped harbor. When the crew had the vessel securely docked, the captain went ashore to seek his pilot and the passengers went into the port with Anthony, a young crewman from the ship, to buy provisions for the next leg of the voyage. Ludolphus and Steven were asked if they would like to join the group, but said that they would stay on board. Both of them had seemed quiet and reclusive ever since the pirate attack.

As the group walked up the street leading to the market place, Gregory noticed that Adiba and Jamcela seemed unsteady on their feet.

“Have you not found your land legs?” He said to Jamcela.

“I feel like I am unsteady on my feet. The ground is moving like the deck of the ship,” she answered.

“That happens all of the time,” said Charles. “Once you are back on board the ship, it will stop.”

“Now you know what it is to be a sailor,” said Anthony. “When we go ashore, people often laugh at us assuming that we have had too much to drink.”

The group turned to look at the tall, dark haired young man who was leading them to the market. It wasn’t that they took umbrage with his comment. Like most of the other sailors in Wolfgang’s crew, he had never before spoken to the passengers.

“Did I offend you?” Anthony asked seeing the surprised look on their faces. “If so, I am sorry.”

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“No, not at all,” said Jamcela, “it is just that we have never heard you speak before. With the exception of seeing some of the crew visiting with Nicholas and Khalil, we have not had many of the crew members talk with us.”

“Oh, that is probably due to the warning we had from our captain. Before you came on board, he gathered the crew together and told us to watch our language and behavior, especially around you ladies, or he would feed us to the fishes. We love our captain and would like to think he was only kidding, but we are never sure.” he said with a sheepish grin.

Smiling, Jamcela looked at Anthony and said, “Thank you, we appreciate you and your captain’s respect for us and we also appreciate your helping us while shopping for provisions. So often, in the other ports we have visited, we have had the feeling that the merchants may have been talking advantage of us, being strangers in their land.”

“They will not do so today,” Anthony responded, smiling and looking away to hide the blush on his cheeks.

As the group walked on, Charles leaned in to whisper to Jamcela, I fear that your womanly beauty has made our shy shopping guide blush.

“At my age, I think not!” she replied.

“I disagree,” said Charles softly. “Like your wonderful mother, your classical beauty is timeless!”

Jamcela smiled softly as they walked and gently leaned her shoulder against Charles.

Coming down the waterfront street from the opposite direction the group saw Wolfgang striding toward them. On land as well as at sea the captain had the air of one in complete control. He smiled broadly and greeted the party. “Is Anthony taking good care of you?” he asked.

“He is doing a great job,” answered Gregory.

“Very good,” said Wolfgang, nodding sternly at Anthony. “I have found our pilot and he will safely guide us between Scylla and Charybdis first thing tomorrow morning while the tide is high and the winds are calm. When you have finished your shopping, I

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will see you back on board.” With a nod and a smile at Charles and Gregory he proceeded on his way back to the Santa Christina.

True to his word, Anthony helped the shoppers find fresh fruit and bread, dried fruit, dried meats and Messina’s famous salami, along with a cask of watered wine, all at reasonable prices. Loaded with their bounty, the party returned to their ship in good spirits.

As Anthony helped the group with the last of their provisions, they heard the voice of the captain informing the crew that they were to remain on board for the evening.

“We will be departing at first light as soon as our pilot comes on board,” announced Wolfgang. “I will need you on the oars ready to pull us safely through the strait. Strong backs and clear heads are essential for this task, so you will be staying on board this evening. Get a good night’s rest and be ready for action, first thing tomorrow.”

As the captain turned and walked to the aft deck it was obvious to the passengers that the crew was disappointed.

“That is the wise thing for a leader to do,” said Charles. “I am sure that the crew would much rather be on their way to visit the local ale houses.”

“True,” said Gregory, “but this assures the captain that all will be present and clear-headed when he needs them for the passage tomorrow morning.”

Later in the evening, as the passengers and crew settled in, a group of sailors gathered on the aft main deck to sing together. With the captain’s admonition, concerning the crew’s language in mind, the songs were carefully selected. Many of the sailors had truly beautiful singing voices and the passengers thoroughly enjoyed the music, even those songs sung in a language they did not understand.

Chapter 27

September 1341

The Straits of Messina

Before first light, Captain Wolfgang moved about the ship waking his men and preparing for the coming voyage through the Straits of Messina. The only sound other than the quiet footfalls of the crew, was the gentle lapping of the water against the hull, the breeze whispering through the rigging and the ever-present creaking of ropes and lines. The sailors worked in silence out of respect for the passenger's rest, but there was little need for conversation. Every man knew his role when preparing to venture into uncertain seas.

As Wolfgang walked by the area near the cargo bundles, where the passengers slept, he saw Charles rising from his sleeping mat.

"I did not mean to disturb your sleep," said Wolfgang. "Some preparations must be made before the pilot arrives. I ordered the men to work as quietly as possible."

"We appreciate your consideration. I have been a light sleeper forever. The last sound night's sleep that I remember was during the years of my youth."

Looking toward Gregory, who was still asleep, the captain added, "It seems the noise does not bother your fellow Templar."

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“No, it never seems to. I have often thought that Brother Gregory could sleep through the Second Coming or the end of the world, no matter how much noise was made.”

Looking past Charles, Wolfgang raised his hand and called out, “Bon journo, Salvatore!”

Charles turned to see a heavy-set man with a dark brown beard, that was just starting to show hints of grey. He had the ruddy complexion of those who spend years in bright sun and salt spray. Climbing the loading plank in long strides he called out, “Greetings my captain, are you ready to face Scylla and Charybdis?”

“With you on board, I have little fear from either,” Wolfgang said, laughing.

Salvatore quickly strode across the deck and embraced the captain.

“Salvatore, this is Charles, one of the two Knights of the Temple that I mentioned to you.”

“Truly an honor to meet you,” said Salvatore looking up at the older man.

“It is a pleasure to meet you,” said Charles. “I know that your name means savior and who better to lead us through the dangerous waters ahead, than a man with such a name.”

“Ah, you need not worry, I too dislike the idea of sailing into a whirlpool, so you can rest assured that I will not put us in harm’s way. If the conditions are not as they should be for a safe passage, we’ll return to port and wait.”

“I am confident that you and our captain are more than adequately prepared for any danger that we might encounter,” said Charles.

“Certainly, for ones that we can foresee,” said Salvatore. “It is not only the tides and pirates that make the sea we call Mare Nostrum dangerous. It is also the winds. Winds can always be dangerous, and then there are the winds that the sailors call ‘gulph’.”

“That is so,” said Wolfgang. “Just earlier this year the gulph, which comes out to sea from the hollows of the mountains, caught a ship at daybreak as it was sailing toward the Sulatian mountains. Their captain, an old friend of mine, said that they were

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running with full sail before an East wind that had carried them all evening as if they were flying. In the morning as they proceeded, with most of the crew still asleep, they were assailed by a cross-wind that hit the ship with such force that it came close to capsizing. The wind was so strong that it moved the ship sideways heeled over so far that the gunnel was within a hands distance of the water. Were it not for the sailors who awoke and quickly cut the ropes to free the sails, along with the skillful helmsman who managed to turn the ship down-wind, the vessel would surely have capsized with all on board. As it was, only the crewman, who was on watch in the rigging, was flung out to sea by the sudden force of the wind. Though they searched for him, he was never found.”

“I have heard similar tales too many times,” said Salvatore.

“Yes, the sea can be a harsh mistress,” added Wolfgang. “But enough sea tales, let us move out while the conditions are right.”

Salvatore nodded in agreement and Wolfgang turned to give the order to cast off lines and man the oars. As the ship was pushed away from the dock and slowly started to move toward the harbor entrance, the rest of the passengers began to stir.

Salvatore took his position at the front rail of the aft deck. From that vantage point he had a clear view of both the sea and crew, and was close enough to shout orders to the helmsman. He stood with his hands on his hips scanning the sea to both sides and monitoring the rower’s cadence.

Gregory, who was now awake and standing by the port railing, saw Salvatore on the upper deck and smiled. He thought to himself, that must be the captain’s pose; head up, chin out and hands on the hips. Salvatore stood just like Wolfgang did as he commanded his crew and the pirate captain had as he waited for the crossbow bolt meant for his loud spokesman.

“Will we be all right this day?” asked a voice behind him. Gregory turned to see Kahlil.

“Do you grow taller every day?” Gregory asked. “Every time I see you and it looks like you have grown.”

“I don’t know,” replied Kahlil. “It is good to grow taller, but I also want to grow older and see tomorrow,” he said. Looking at

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the deck he softly said to Gregory, "I am worried, I do not know how to swim."

"Don't worry so much," Gregory said, as he reached out to rub his hand on Kahlil's head. "On our way to Outremer, our captain told those of us who were not good swimmers that if we were to ever find ourselves in the sea, especially when dressed in full armor, that we should go straight to the bottom and run like hell for shore."

"So, what did you do?" asked Khalil.

"Simple," said Gregory, "I made sure that I never fell overboard."

Realizing that he was being teased, Khalil smiled. "When I was a little boy, my grandmother told us that Christians did not have to worry about drowning since their god had taught them all to walk on water. Is that true?"

Laughing out loud, Gregory responded, "No your grandmother exaggerated. Only the Son of God could walk on water. All of his followers had to learn to swim. What else did your grandmother have to say about us?"

"She also told us that the Knights of the Temple, were all born clothed in full armor and wearing long beards. She said that if we were not good children, they would come in the night and carry us away."

"Truly?" asked Gregory, raising his eyebrows, "Were any of your friends carried off?"

"No, not that I know of," said Kahlil with a sheepish smile.

"Then they were lucky," said Gregory, smiling as he turned to walk away. "Every once in a long while we would miss one."

The crew was uncharacteristically quiet as the ship was turned to port and left the harbor entrance heading north into the strait. There was no bantering among the crew members, no singing among those working at the oars, just the sound of creaking oar locks and water dripping from the blades. The passengers and the rest of the crew stood by the rails in silence, looking out to sea to catch a glimpse of the narrow passage and its legendary perils.

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From his vantage point on the upper, aft-deck, Salvatore scanned the sea ahead. From time to time, he looked over his shoulder and shouted course corrections to the helmsman. Salvatore had placed Wolfgang and some of his men in the bow of the ship to watch the water ahead for shallow sand bars and hidden rocks. As Salvatore scanned the horizon watching for currents and moving water, he occasionally turned his gaze to the captain, in the bow, to check for any signal of danger.

The Strait of Messina became narrower as they ship traveled north and the tension on board became more evident. Crew members not manning the oars joined the captain and pilot scanning the water for signs of submerged rocks, shoals and sand bars on their left side while those on the right rails searched the water surface for signs of moving currents that might indicate the edges of a whirlpool. The waters of the strait were clear and calm. As the sun began to rise it was possible to see the sea floor in the shallow water. Years of experience allowed Wolfgang and the men with him in the bow to determine if the rocks and shoals that they spotted might constitute a danger to the ship. Though some sharp rocks and sandbars passed by just beyond the blades of the portside oars, it was determined that none of them were a danger to the ship's hull.

Through the whole process Nicholas, Ludolphus, Steven, Adiba, Jamcela, Gregory and Charles stood together on the aft section of the main deck. Adiba turned to Charles and Gregory.

"Is there something we can do to help?"

"You could keep an eye out for Scylla or any other sea monsters," suggested Gregory.

"That is not funny," said Jamcela. "We are all nervous. This is no time to make jokes!"

Ludolphus and Steven nodded in agreement.

"Let us remain calm," said Charles. "I believe that the best thing we can do is to stay out of the crew's way. Seamen face this kind of danger on a daily basis and have no more desire to visit the bottom of the sea than we do. Everything will work out well."

As Charles looked at his fellow travelers, he wondered if his comments made them feel any better. They no longer voiced their

concerns, but continued to watch the process in wide-eyed awe. As usual Gregory seemed unphased.

When the ship began to enter the narrowest part of the strait, between Torre Faro and Villa San Giovanni, where it is less than two miles wide, Salvatore noted that they had arrived, as he had planned, at the slack water point of the high tide. To their right he could see the shifting currents of the whirlpool Homer had called Charybdis. He knew that since he had kept the ship as close to shore as possible there would be less chance of the current pulling them to the right, where the whirlpool awaited. At the first indication of the waters moving them to the right, Salvatore shouted the order, to the men on the oars, to increase their speed, while the helmsman turned the rudder to move the ship toward the port-side shore, away from the whirlpool.

It seemed as if everyone on board was holding their breath as the ship moved through the narrows and entered the wider bay beyond. Once it was obvious that the danger had passed, passengers and crew alike breathed a collective sigh of relief. There were smiles on every face with the exception of Stephen, who managed to maintain his usual sulking expression.

"Relax my friends," came a booming voice from the aft deck. "Yet another ship has avoided the perils of Scylla and Charybdis."

The passengers and crew turned to see Salvatore smiling at them with his burly arms held out above his head. All on board let out a cheer and Salvatore nodded his head in recognition. Wolfgang strode back across the main deck and climbed the steps to the aft deck where his friend stood grinning.

"Once again, my friend, you have bested Ulysses!"

"I suspect that we have a better captain and crew than that legendary Greek did," answered Salvatore. "Let us continue up the coast to Faro Point, near Punta del Faro, where you can drop me off. One of my men will come out in a small boat to take me ashore. I will wait there to meet another ship needing to make the journey southward and you can be on your way."

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As the two old friends stood looking out from the aft deck, the breeze came up as it tends to do when the sun begins to warm the surface of the water.

“As always, your timing was perfect, my friend,” said Wolfgang. “The sea was as smooth as a tabletop as we passed through the strait.”

“Yes, I believe that in sailing and in life, timing and good fortune make all the difference.”

Just as Salvatore had promised, the watchman on duty in the rigging sighted a small row boat approaching them from the shoreline. As it neared the merchant ship Wolfgang gave the order to stop rowing and ship the left side oars.

The captain and pilot gave each other a hearty bear hug and said their goodbyes. As Salvatore settled into the seat at the rear of the launch, he waved to the crew and passengers who were now all smiles and good cheer. His small boat turned toward shore and the crew resumed rowing until they were safely clear of the shallow water.

Since the winds were now becoming favorable, Wolfgang ordered the crew to stow the oars and set the sails. Charles and Gregory stood silently watching the crew from the upper deck. Charles turned to speak to Gregory and in the distance, on the front, lower deck saw Father Ludolphus looking at them. Gregory saw the look of wonder on Charles’ face and turned to look over his shoulder in time to see Ludolphus turn his back and look away as if he had been caught in an indiscretion.

“What was that about?” asked Charles. “Has Ludolphus seemed a little odd to you lately?”

“To be honest, he has seemed a little odd to me from the moment we met him. The way he’s acting now is something new, though.”

Charles nodded, “I have had very few conversations with him ever since we began this journey and even those were mostly ‘good day and how are you doing.’”

“It’s been the same for me,” said Gregory. “When we first met, he was nothing but questions and information. Perhaps we told him all he needed to know?”

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“Possibly,” said Charles. “What about you?”

“During this voyage, the only conversation of any duration that I have had with the priest, was in the evening of the day of the pirate attack. Ludolphus came up to me as I stood at the deck railing watching the sun set and asked me if I wanted him to hear my confession.”

“Truly?” asked Charles. “What prompted that?”

“He mentioned that he had personally seen me kill a man and had heard of others. He thought that I should seek absolution. When I hesitated to answer, he asked me if I was aware that taking a life is always a sin, as is having sex. The first he insisted is less of a sin if the killing is done to protect others or in the service of the church, just as sex for the purpose of conceiving a child is considered a lesser sin. But, he insisted, they are both sins requiring absolution.”

Charles stood looking at Gregory. His mouth was open as if to speak but no voice issued forth. His eyes were wide open and his brow furrowed. He finally responded, “I don’t know what to say!”

“Either did I! I was not sure if I had heard him correctly. After a far-too-long silence, he repeated his comments in almost exactly the same words and then stood there looking at me as if I may not have understood him.”

“Did you ever respond?”

“Yes, at first, I was concerned about the possibility of offending him or seeming impertinent, but I finally explained that I disagreed with him on both points. I probably shouldn’t have, but I went on to explain that if we needed absolution for every man that we had killed since entering the order we would have a Herculean task ahead of us. I told him that in the first place I doubted that either of us could specifically remember all the men that we had killed and that even if we could, we would lose our voices saying all of the Hail Mary’s, Our Fathers and Acts of Contrition necessary to gain absolution. I went on to tell him that I believed that every man that I had killed in the service of our church and Templar Order represented a justifiable act. I added that the issue of sex between me and my wife was our business and no one else’s.”

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The look on Charles face turned from puzzlement to amusement.

Smiling broadly, he asked, "How did he respond?"

"He didn't. He turned on his heel, walked away and has not said a word to me since. Was I too offensive or irreverent brother?"

"Not for me," said Charles. "You stated my feelings exactly."

Both men smiled and turned to look out to sea.

Chapter 28

October 1341

Tyrrhenian Sea

With the anxiety of navigating the Straits of Messina behind them, the days that followed seemed anticlimactic for passengers and crew. The seas were calm, the winds favorable and according to the captain they were making very good time.

For Charles the idea of going home after fifty years in Outremer began to dominate his thoughts. In many ways the idea of returning to his homeland was both comforting and confusing. He thought about the fact that he and Gregory were twenty when Acre fell and they had now seen seventy years. Though their current voyage home reminded him of their first voyage so many years ago, he was acutely aware that he was not the same person that had set out on an adventure to recapture the Holy Land for his church and his God. Not only was he fifty years older, but the world that they left had apparently gone through many changes. The information that Ludolphus had shared with him and Gregory was still a shock. How could the Templar Order simply cease to exist? Being a Templar was central to his life and his identity even though he had not seen or heard from his brothers for decades. He and Gregory had survived when all of their fellow Templars had been executed. The memory of being forced to watch their brother knights being beheaded still filled him with both horror and confusion. He knew

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why they had been spared, but that knowledge held little solace and a great deal of guilt. The joy, of being freed from service to the Soldan and the prospect of returning to their homeland was tempered by great uncertainty.

Where would they go? What would they do? Would any of their family or friends still be alive? If they were, would they remember him or Gregory? At the age of seventy, he knew that he was long past the average life expectancy. It was a certainty that his parents had passed away and most likely his older siblings were also gone. Would they find anyone they had known?

Ludolphus had mentioned earlier that he would take them to report to the Holy Father. That seemed to make sense to Charles, since the Templar Order, to the dismay of kings and regional noblemen, had historically answered only to the Pope. What that audience would entail was a mystery. Depending upon the pontiff's age, it was conceivable that the Order of the Temple had been disbanded when the current Pope was very young or possibly even before he was born. Charles tried to imagine the conversation that they might have, but found himself at a loss for possibilities. As he wondered, he looked out to sea. The breeze and salt air were refreshing. The sound of creaking rigging and passing waters produced a rhythm that was both comforting and relaxing.

"We are making good time," came a voice from behind him.

Turning Charles saw Ludolphus coming up next to him at the ships rail.

"We are father," he replied. "The captain has told me that we could reach Genoa in a few days depending on this following breeze."

"Are you excited to return to your homelands?" Ludolphus asked.

"Yes, excited and confused. I am not sure what to expect. You mentioned once that you would have us report to the Holy Father."

"Yes, your order answered to His Holiness and he should be made aware of your long service and your return to Christendom after all of these years. He can also release you from your vows and give you direction for your new lives."

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“So, we will be going to Rome after making land at Genoa?”

“No,” said Ludolphus. “We will be going to Avignon where the pope now resides.”

“Not Rome?” asked Charles. “I do not understand.”

“There have been many changes in the years when you and Gregory were gone. The Pope today is Benedict XII a French Cistercian. He is the 197th Pope and the third to reside in Avignon.”

Ludolphus could see that Charles was confused.

“Some of this may be hard for you to understand, but there have been many conflicts within the church in the past years. The Pope at the time of the fall of Acre was Nicholas IV. He passed away the next year in 1292 and there was great conflict in the process of electing the next pontiff. The time following his death is called the Interregnum, a two-year period without the election of a valid pope.”

“But you say there is a pope today and he resides in Avignon?” asked Charles.

“Yes, Pope Benedict XII lives in a grand, fortified palace, called the Palais des Papes, that he had built in Avignon on the Rhone River, in the Kingdom of Aries. He is now the third pope to reside in Avignon rather than Rome.”

“So, we go to Avignon?” asked Charles.

“Yes, we will make land in Genoa and then sail on west to Marseille, where Captain Wolfgang will put us ashore. From there we journey north to Salon-de-Provence and then Avignon. It should be a pleasant journey. We will be able to find shelter and provisions along the way.”

“And in Avignon we will have an audience with the Holy Father?”

“Yes, I am confident that he would like to meet you and hear of your time in Outremer.”

“Have you met this Pope before?” asked Charles.

“No, I have heard him speak to a large congregation several times, but I have not had an audience alone with him.”

“I am sure that it would be interesting to meet his holiness,” said Charles, “I look forward to it.”

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“There is one thing that concerns me about this meeting,” said Ludolphus.

“What is that?” asked Charles.

“Your brother knight, Gregory. I have talked with him recently about his activities and offered to hear his confession and grant him absolution for the killing of the pirate captain. It was an event that I witnessed. He did not seem to accept that this killing, in the eyes of the Lord, is a sin that requires contrition and absolution. There are other events in your lives that the pontiff may question and I am concerned about Gregory’s responses.”

Charles looked puzzled, but did not respond. There was something about Ludolphus that made him hesitate. As he looked at the priest, he decided to remain silent.

“One of these issues is the matter of your wives and children. Years ago, you both took vows of poverty and chastity. I do not know how the Holy Father will respond to your current situation.”

For a moment Charles stood in silent disbelief. Mind racing. None of these issues were recent discoveries, he thought. This priest has been aware of these things for some time and yet now they have become matters of concern? Charles thought of what he might say to respond, but something in the back of his mind suggested discretion.

“I will talk with Gregory about the significance of these concerns,” said Charles. “Thank you for making me aware of this.”

“Very well,” said Ludolphus. “I knew that I could count on your wisdom in these matters. We will visit again before meeting the pontiff. If you will excuse me now,” he said and turned and walked off toward the stern of the ship.

Charles nodded and turned toward the rail and looked out to sea. Taking the measure of a man was something he had thought he had always done well. Yet he feared that he had missed something about this priest. From the beginning, he had an uncomfortable feeling. It had started with their first encounter, but it was nothing that he could put his finger on. Thinking back, he remembered that on several occasions he had wondered at the priest’s attitude and observations, but thought, at the time, that it could be merely the

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fact that he had not had a conversation with a priest in nearly a half a century. In his youth he had met several priests that were overly impressed with their stations in life and seemed much more concerned about the sins of others, than they were of their own. Charles was also acutely aware that Ludolphus had played a key role in he and Gregory being released from slavery. For that he was most grateful. Yet Charles had wondered at the time and still wondered this day why this priest would take such a chance in the Sultan's court. Sultans have the power of life and death over their subjects as well as those who visited them. If Ludolphus' words had been viewed as impertinent, the results could have been very different.

At various times since meeting Ludolphus, Charles had thought that some of their conversations seemed odd, but then again, so much of what he and Gregory had learned since the day they saved the pilgrims from the robbers had been confusing. Of late he was beginning to think that he may have been right to be concerned. While Charles smiled and nodded to Ludolphus, he resolved to find time to have a conversation alone with Gregory. What could this audience with the Pope mean?

A voice from behind him said, "Hello Brother Charles. "Turning Charles saw Nicholas standing next to him. He appeared nervous, hurried, anxious.

"Nicholas, where have you been? I haven't seen much of you for days," said Charles smiling. "I feared you might have fallen overboard!"

"No, I'm still here," His voice soft, barely more than a whisper. Father Ludolphus ordered me to stay away from the crew members, Kahlil, you, Brother Gregory, and your wives. He said that both he and Steven were concerned about the bad influence that some of you were having on me."

"I see," said Charles. "I am sorry if any of us were leading you astray."

"You were not; not any of you. I think that Stephen was upset that Khalil and I were having fun with the crew; rowing with them and listening to sea stories."

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“From what I could see, it was harmless,” said Charles. “I was quite impressed by how the crew watched their language around you and our wives. I could see that they enjoyed having you row with them especially during the pirate attack. Was Stephen not asked to join with you?”

“Oh, he was invited alright. When a crew member asked if he would like to learn to row, Steven turned and walked away like he had been slapped across the face. Steven thinks of himself as a young nobleman and finds any sort of labor to be beneath his station in life. I also think that he resents it when anyone is enjoying themselves. I suspect that he believes that “joy” is the eighth deadly sin.”

“Some people are like that,” said Charles, laughing. “They are always miserable and resent anyone else who is not. You have probably noticed that my fellow knight is the exact opposite. Brother Gregory responds as if everything is fun.”

“I noticed that during the pirate attack. I was rowing with Khalil and from where we sat, I could see you and Brother Gregory at the ships rail. You looked very serious and Brother Gregory was smiling as if the other ship came bearing gifts. Is he always like that?”

“Almost always,” said Charles. “Gregory can find the light in even the darkest hour.”

“That is the way, I would like to be,” said Nicholas, looking over his shoulder. “I must go now before Father Ludolphus or Stephen sees me with you. It is so good to talk with you again.”

“For me also,” said Charles smiling as he turned to look out to sea. He thought to himself, “what is going on?”

Chapter 29

October 1341

Golfo di Genova, Ligurian Sea

During the next few days Charles could not find an opportunity to talk privately with Gregory. Though it was a large ship, given the cargo, the number of crew members and the eight passengers there was little space for privacy. Charles did not want his discussion with Gregory to be overheard. It might have to wait until they were ashore and could get away from prying ears.

Shortly after the watchman in the rigging called out ‘land-ho’, Captain Wolfgang came forward to the main deck and walked up to Charles and Gregory who were standing at the railing.

“Good morning my friends, we are within sight of land and we will soon be docking in Genoa. Much of our cargo will be unloaded there before we sail on to Marseille, where we will deliver the rest of it and you will depart to continue north on your journey to Avignon. We will be in port there for no more than two to three hours and will be on our way shortly after noon. It is best that you remain on board or near the ship to insure that no one is left behind for the next leg of our journey.”

“How long will it take to sail to Marseille?” asked Gregory.

“It usually takes about half a day, assuming that there are no difficulties,” said Wolfgang. “We should be there in time for the evening meal.”

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“We will stay close by,” said Charles. “Is there anything that we can do to help?”

“No, but thank you for asking,” answered Wolfgang. “My lads will make short work of the process and we will be on our way.”

As promised the cargo was deposited safely on the Genoa dock and the ship was rowed back out of the harbor to continue on its way west. The skies were clear, there was a gentle east-to-west breeze. As soon as they were clear of the Genoa harbor Wolfgang ordered the three, square sails raised and the ship moved smoothly westward.

The captain was especially fond of this part of the Mediterranean and took pleasure in showing it to his passengers.

“This sea is known for its striking natural beauty and the shoreline between Genoa and Marseille is no exception. These turquoise waters of the Golfo di Genova are dotted with sheltered bays and coves and inlets that resemble small fjords.”

For the benefit of his guests, Wolfgang had his crew sail in closer to shore than they normally would so that they might enjoy the beautiful scenery. In many places there are long stretches of sand beaches while in others the steep mountain sides come down to the waterline. Some of the seaside villages appear to be clinging to the mountains near the water’s edge. The five-hour sail along the coast went by quickly for the passengers and as the sun began to sink towards the western horizon the sailor on watch near the top of the center mast shouted ‘Marseille.’

Captain Wolfgang came forward to the main deck and walked up to Charles and Gregory. “Before we make port, I want to take a moment to tell you both how much I have enjoyed having you along on this voyage. It has been an honor to meet two of the knights that were a part of the order that was so revered by me and my friends in the days of our youth. The two of you are a credit to the memory of your Order and your assistance during the pirate attack has, among my crew, already become the stuff of legend.”

“It has been a pleasure for us also,” said Gregory. “You have been a most gracious host and your crew has done much to make us feel welcome.”

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“Yes, that is true,” said Charles, “and we are acutely aware that we would have had no way to make this journey without your generosity. You have been so kind to us and our families and we will never forget you.”

“Oh, you are most welcome, my friends,” said Wolfgang, “but I must warn you that my admiration of your Holy Order is not universally shared. There are some that believed the lies that the French King spread about the Templars and some who were most pleased to see the mighty fall. Many princes of the church, kings and noblemen alike, resented the Templars; especially their power, their wealth and the fact that they answered only to the Holy Father. Among these powerful men there is also the continuing frustration of having brought down the order, but never having been able to lay their hands on the legendary Templar treasures. I have heard tales about eighteen ships of the Templar fleet that reportedly disappeared the night before the Order was suppressed. Some believe that this event explains why none of the holdings of the large Templar treasuries were ever found. It is a mystery that has never been solved.”

“I see,” said Charles, nodding his head. “That is good to know.”

“Yes,” said Wolfgang, “be careful who you let know of your past. This is not the same world you left, those many years ago. In many parts of Christendom there is a rising tide of concern among those who love God, but find fault with how some men run His church. May the Lord be with you and with your loved ones,” he said, and hugged each of the men.

“Now I am needed on the aft deck,” he said smiling as he turned and strode toward the stern of the ship. Charles and Gregory looked at each other but did not speak. There was no need, they knew the other’s thoughts. They were both concerned.

As the ship approached the mouth of the harbor, Kahlil, Adiba and Jamcela walked toward the stern of the ship and climbed the steps to the aft deck. There they walked up to Wolfgang who was busy giving orders to his men. The captain turned to face them with a broad smile on his face.

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"I see that we are about to say goodbye to you and your husbands after this exciting voyage."

"Yes, we wanted to say goodbye and thank you for your generosity and kindness. We are so grateful that we are able to return with our husbands to their homeland."

"Yes, I understand," said Wolfgang. "Many men who travel to the Levant have women while they are there and sometimes even children. Unfortunately, it is not uncommon for some of these men to abandon the women and children when they return home. You are indeed fortunate that this is not the case for you."

"We know that well," said Adiba. "Our husbands have saved our lives more times than you could know."

"It is true," said Jamcela. "We also want to thank you and your crew for making us feel so welcome and safe on your ship."

Wolfgang smiled broadly as he listened. "You may not know this, but sailors are an unschooled and superstitious lot. To the man, they traditionally believe that it is very bad luck to ever have a woman on board their ship."

"We would have never suspected that," said Adiba. "Your crew was very polite and respectful to us at all times."

Still smiling, Wolfgang nodded and said, "Yes, I believe that they were. Before you boarded in Jaffa, I had a talk with the assembled crew and warned them about my expectations concerning their behavior. I ended the meeting with an offer to throw overboard any man who did not comply."

"Oh, I cannot believe that you would ever throw a man overboard," said Jamcela. As she spoke, she noticed a young sailor who was coiling a rope while standing near the deck rail behind the captain. He was clearly listening to the conversation and Jamcela saw him nodding his head in agreement as the captain spoke.

Wolfgang turned to see who was behind him and the sailor immediately looked at the deck and his rope, while turning his back to the group.

"The only important thing is that my men believe that I would," said Wolfgang, softly with a smile on his face and a wink in his eye. "Now, I must get back to my duties."

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As the women and Khalil turned to walk away, he called out “Don’t forget my offer Khalil, there is always a place for you and your friend Nicholas on my crew, if you ever decide to go to sea.” The young man nodded, beaming with pride and turned back to follow the women.

When the ship was docked and the ramp was lowered, Charles, Gregory, Adiba, Jamcela, Khalil, Nicholas, Steven, and Ludolphus left with their few possessions and stood together on the wharf. All of them looked to Ludolphus who appeared nervous. While the rest of the group was clearly happy to have arrived safely after a long voyage, something seemed to be concerning the priest.

No one spoke, but there was a question on every face. Ludolphus turned to the group and while seeming to look beyond them said, “I must go ahead by carriage, to make arrangements for lodging in Avignon and schedule your audience with the Holy Father. I will take Steven with me. Nicholas will travel with you. You should be there in two and a half to three days and I will meet with you to tell you of the arrangements. When you reach Avignon, Nicholas will take you to the rectory and the parish priest will direct you to your lodging place. Here are coins for the purchase of food along the way,” he said handing a small leather pouch to Charles. Before Charles could respond, Ludolphus turned and began to walk away with Steven following closely behind. Nicholas did not seem as surprised as the rest of the group. He looked at the ground and was silent.

“What just happened?” asked Jamcela.

“I am not sure,” answered Gregory. Charles shook his head. He also looked puzzled. They all looked at Nicholas who continued to stare at the ground in front of him.

“Do we know the way to Avignon?” asked Khalil.

“That should not be a problem,” said Charles. “There is only one main road north along the coast and if we become confused, we can ask for directions.”

Turning to face the group Charles continued. “Perhaps Father Ludolphus is nervous about our visit to meet the Holy Father. I remember him at one point saying that he had seen the pope speak to a large group of churchmen several times, but had

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never spoken with him directly. Possibly that makes him uncomfortable.”

“Perhaps,” said Gregory. “The priest seems to have become progressively more anxious ever since our journey began.”

“Well, we will know more when we meet him in Avignon,” said Charles. “For now, we should buy some provisions and be on our way.”

After a visit to the town marketplace to buy bread and dried fruit, the group started their long walk north, toward Salon-de-Provence and then on to Avignon. As is so often the case, it took a few days for the travelers to stop feeling the moving ship’s deck as they walked. The weather was warm and sunny without being hot and a cool breeze made the walking enjoyable. Charles and Gregory, who had spent their whole lives actively working and walking had no problem with the overland progress from the port of Marseille. Nicholas and Khalil, who were more than a half-century younger than the knights could have run the whole distance with no trouble at all. For Adiba and Jamcela it was a different story. Neither woman had mentioned any of the difficulties that they had during either of the caravan segments of the journey. Saddle sores and other aches and pains were suffered in silence. Never a word of complaint, or even concern was heard from either of them during that entire journey. It wasn’t until late in the afternoon of the second day of walking north that Charles and Gregory noticed that both women were limping

When they stopped for the day and talked with the women after the evening meal, they noticed that both ladies had swollen ankles and feet covered with very red blisters.

“Why didn’t you say something?” asked Gregory. “Your feet are swollen and raw with blisters. That must be very painful!”

“We don’t want to be a problem at every stage of our journey,” said Jamcela.

“We spent the first days of the sea voyage returning our food to the sea,” added Adiba. “We are embarrassed about developing another problem now that we are back on dry land.”

“You are never a problem for us,” said Charles.

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“That is true!” added Gregory smiling, “You both have been very brave this whole journey. It has not been easy for anyone, even for old, seasoned travelers like your husbands. We will just have to walk a little more slowly.”

“Fortunately, we only have less than a half-day of walking tomorrow and then you will have time to rest you blistered feet,” said Charles, hugging his wife, Now let’s see if we can get some rest and start early tomorrow morning.”

Late in the morning of the third day, the weary travelers entered the city of Avignon. Nicholas, who had remained silent for most of the journey showed them the way to the rectory of the church that Ludolphus had mentioned. There, they were greeted by the pastor’s assistant, Brother Francis. Francis was a tall, thin, young man who was polite, pleasant and obviously confused by the presence of the two women and the Arab boy who accompanied Nicholas and the two knights. He looked to Nicholas, who he thought might understand, but Nicholas offered no explanations. While curious, Brother Francis asked no questions and simply explained that Father Ludolphus would meet them tomorrow to lead the knights to the Palais des Papes.

Chapter 30

October 1341

Avignon, Kingdom of France

Mid-morning of the following day Father Ludolphus and Steven arrived at the parish rectory where the priest greeted Charles and Gregory. He asked nothing about their overland journey and did not look at or address Adiba, Jamcela, Nicholas, or Khalil. He told the knights that they would be going with him for their audience with the Pope. He also mentioned that they should leave the simitars that they carried there at the rectory. He added that Nicholas should accompany them to the palace, Khalil should remain at the rectory.

As they turned to leave Jamcela asked Ludolphus,
“When will they return?”

Ludolphus gave no answer. Charles stepped in front of the priest. Looking down at him he asked,

“When will we be back here?”

Obviously irritated at the question, Ludolphus forced a smile and responded,

“You will be back by mid-afternoon.”

Turning he walked away followed by Steven, Nicholas and the knights. As they proceeded up the street Ludolphus explained, over his shoulder, that they were going to the fortified Papal Palace in Avignon.

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“The Palais des Papes,” he explained, “overlooks the Rhone River and was begun nearly ninety years ago. It is now being completed by Benedict XII, the current pope. I will introduce you to the Holy Father and you will kneel in front of him, bend over and kiss his feet as a sign of respect and obedience. After this you are to stand and move backward three steps and wait for the pontiff to speak to you. Remember, you are to speak only if asked a question. At the end of the audience, you will back away from the pope and turn around when we reach the doors.”

When he had finished his directions, Ludolphus looked at Charles and Gregory and asked,

“Do you have any questions?”

For a moment neither of them answered. Looking at each other, they wondered if Ludolphus thought that they were unable to process these simple directions, or if he was just excessively nervous about appearing before the pontiff. Finally, Gregory smiled and said,

“I believe we both understand.”

The rest of the walk to the palace was conducted in silence. As the knights approached the gates, they were impressed by the imposing structure before them. The Palais des Papes was a massive stone building that might be better described as a bastion or fortress with small defensive window openings, designed to protect the pontiff and house the church’s business. It had the appearance of a castle with a cathedral-like double door entry way. When the priest and the knights approached the doors, they were stopped by two guards in full armor who carried long pikes. Next to them stood the captain of the gate, who stepped forward and inquired as to the purpose of their visit. Ludolphus explained who they were and that they had an audience with the Pope. The captain instructed Steven and Nicholas to remain on a bench to the right of the door and for the priest and the knights to follow him. Nicholas moved toward the bench. Steven stood for a moment in apparent disbelief and followed Nicholas only when pushed in that direction by one of the guards.

After following the captain through the vestibule and a long hallway, they came to a large set of double doors manned by

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another pair of guards dressed in the same uniform worn by those at the main gate. The guards stood with their pikes crossed in front of the door and drew them upright to their sides as the captain and the men approached.

The captain pushed open the two heavy, ornately carved wooden doors that featured a detailed scene of the crucifixion. While the doors were twice the height of a normal entry, the room beyond had a ceiling that was twice again that height. It was a long, wide, dimly lit room with marble floors. A single narrow carpet led across the room to a raised platform, that could be accessed by means of six wide steps. On the platform was a massive throne flanked by two more guards. There was a tall candelabra to the side of each guard. Each candelabra supported six yellow candles. The hall had no windows and the candles provided the only dim light, making it hard to clearly see the beams that supported the vaulted ceiling.

As their eyes adjusted to the low-light conditions the priest and two knights saw a short, corpulent man in ornate robes sitting on the throne. Even in the dim light, it was apparent that his complexion was very white, almost paste-like. He had small dark eyes. He wore a white cassock under a heavy red robe with ornate gold trim. The robe was secured in the front by metal clasp that had a large red gem stone at its center. On his head the Pope wore a tall silver miter. He did not move and his face was expressionless.

Ludolphus, Charles and Gregory slowly walked forward to the bottom of the staircase where they stopped. No one spoke. No one moved. At length the pontiff extended his hand from the long sleeve and motioned the men forward. All three started toward the lowest step when Ludolphus put out his arms to stopped the two knights. They stepped back and the priest returned to the steps. At the top of the platform, he knelt before the Pope's throne, bent forward and kissed the pontiff's left foot. As he raised his head, the Pope signaled with his hand that the priest should rise. In a high-pitched, almost child-like voice he said,

"Ludolphus of Suchem?"

"Yes, your Holiness, I have brought you two knights of the Temple that I found on the shore of the Dead Sea. I believe that

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they are the sole survivors of the fall of Acre. They have been slaves in the service of a Sultan for all of these years since the loss of that fortress. They have been waiting for the return of their order and a Christian army to retake the Holy Land.”

The pope slowly nodded and finally said,
“Come forward my sons.”

Charles and Gregory climbed the steps as Ludolphus moved to the side. They knelt in front of the pontiff, bent forward and each of them kissed one of the Popes’ feet. They remained kneeling as the pope spoke.

While looking over their heads as if there were someone standing behind them, the Pontiff thanked them for their service to the church and told them that they would be supported and allowed to live in a monastery for the rest of their time on earth. He then gave them both his blessing. There was no reference to the demise of their order. No questions about the decades spent in slavery. Nothing about the fact that they had wives, children and grandchildren. Gregory and Charles assumed that Ludolphus had not mentioned these details to the pope.

When it was apparent that he had finished speaking, Charles and Gregory stood and slowly backed down the steps. There they were joined by Ludolphus. All three backed out of the hall until they reached the main doors. Once outside, Ludolphus turned to the knights and said,

“That went very well. Now you are to return to your lodging place and I will come for you in a few days; as soon as I have determined where you will be living.”

Without another word he turned, indicated that Steven and Nicholas should follow him and walked away heading up the main street. Nicholas looked back at the knights with a question on his face, but said nothing and followed the priest. The knights stood in silence as the three walked away.

Turning to Charles, Gregory smiled and said,
“I could not tell for sure, but apparently that went very well!”

“Do you think the pontiff even knows who we are?” asked Charles.

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“Do you think it matters?”

“Probably not!”

“Let us go tell our wives that we have been blessed by the Pope,” added Gregory, smiling.

When they returned to the parish house the men were greeted at the door by Adiba and Jamcela. They told of their rather strange meeting with the Pope during which he had offered to lodge them in a monastery for the remainder of their lives.

Adiba asked,

“Are women allowed to enter a monastery, much less live there?”

Charles shook his head and responded,

“I do not know. Ludolphus has probably not mentioned to the Pope that we are married. Ludolphus said that he will return in a few days. We will probably learn more about our accommodations at that time.”

“Have you, talked to Father Ludolphus about returning to your home lands?” asked Jamcela.

“There was no mention of that either,” added Gregory.

From the looks on their faces, it was obvious that none of them were comfortable with what had taken place so far.

Khalil, who had been listening to the discussion, was also concerned. There was no mention of him at all. There was not a day that went by that he did not celebrate where he was and who he was with. The thought of being left to fend for himself frightened him greatly.

After eating the first hot meal that the group had enjoyed in weeks, they retired to restlessly dream and worry about what tomorrow might bring.

Chapter 31

October 1341

Parish Rectory, Avignon, Kingdom of France

Late in the evening, near the midnight hour, the sleeping and dreaming was interrupted by loud pounding at the rectory door. Charles, still half asleep, went and opened it cautiously. He found a highly excited Nicholas, clearly out of breath, standing with to an older man who also looked quite agitated.

“Please let us in!” cried Nicholas. “We have come to warn you!”

Charles opened the door further and stepped aside to let them enter.

“Warn us of what?” asked Gregory who was just entering the room followed by Adiba and Jamcela.

“Who is this with you?” added Charles.

“This man is the bishop’s housekeeper. He has asked that we not use his name. He came to warn us of the plans that the bishop and Father Ludolphus have for the two of you.”

“I do not understand?” said Charles. Gregory nodded.

The older man stepped forward. “I overheard a conversation between the bishop and the priest concerning questioning the two of you. I am sorry to be so rude as to not give my name, but if you do not know it, you can not be forced to disclose it under torture.”

“Torture?” said Charles. “What are you talking about?”

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“As I was mopping the floor in an adjoining room, at the bishop’s palace, I overheard the bishop and Father Ludolphus talking about two Templar Knights that Father Ludolphus had brought back from the Holy Land. The bishop said that he was curious as to why the priest had done that. Ludolphus told him that he believed you had helped to load the Templar treasure on a ship that sailed away just before the fall of Acre. He said that he had asked if you knew where the ship was bound and that you told him that you did not. He added that he suspected that, out of loyalty to the order, you might be keeping the location secret, even after all of these years. The bishop indicated that he would summon the Dominicans to his palace to question you regarding this matter. He also indicated that Father Ludolphus would be richly rewarded for his service.”

“They can question us all they like,” said Gregory. “We were not told where the ship was going and after all this time, we still have no idea. We are not even sure what was in the trunks we loaded.

“You don’t understand!” cried the housekeeper. “The Dominicans don’t just ask questions. Even if you appear to be cooperating with them, they will torture you to ensure that you have told the whole truth. Forgive me sirs”, he said with tears welling up in his eyes, “but you are old men and it is very likely that you would not survive that questioning.”

“You know this for certain?” Gregory asked.

“All too well,” he responded. “Many years ago, when the order was first suppressed, my grandfather’s brother was a Knight of the Temple. Like so many others, he was questioned and subjected to ungodly torture at the hands of the Dominicans. Also, like many others, the torture broke him and he died shortly afterward. Even strong, young men were often not able to survive the ordeal. Many of those that did survive were crippled for life, left wishing that they had not lived. Questioning by the Dominican Order is for many a death sentence!”

A gasp was heard from behind the men. The men turned around to see Jamcela and Adiba hugging each other, tears streaming down their cheeks.

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“Do you see now why I brought him to warn you?” asked Nicholas.

“Yes,” said Charles, “but toward what end?”

The housekeeper continued.

“There is still hope. From the very first suppression of your order, friends and families of the Templars came together to create a system that would allow them to escape to countries where they would be safe to live out their lives. The group that I have worked with uses a secret route that will lead you and your family to Tomar, in Portugal. There the Order of Christ has their castle. We call the route the Way of Saint James. It consists of safe places to stay in towns that are all a day’s walk apart. At each stop you will be given the name of, and directions to the next village.”

“Wait a moment,” said Charles, “what is this Order of Christ that you speak of?”

“We have never heard of that order,” added Gregory.

“I understand your confusion, the man replied. As I am sure you know, your order had a strong presence on the Iberian Peninsula. Starting in 1128. One year after the Council of Troyes established your order, Teresa of Portugal gave the Templars the town of Fonte Areada. For years the order flourished there and grew more powerful. In 1307 when Philip IV of France and Pope Clement V betrayed the order and it was abolished in most every other country, the Templar tradition lived on in Portugal under the protection of the King of Portugal and under a new name, The Order of Christ. Since that time, they have welcomed and protected all Templars who have made their way to safety. As you can probably imagine, the numbers of Templars, seeking safety, has decreased over the years, but I know for certain that you will be warmly welcomed at the Convento do Cristo.

“I am speechless,” said Charles.

“What do we do?” added Gregory.

The housekeeper smiled and said, “You will be told the route step by step as you go. That way if you are captured, you will not be able to expose the rest of the route and endanger the people who would help you along the way. Once you cross the border, into the Kingdom of Aragon, you will be safely on your way. The

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bishop's men would not be welcomed if they were caught following you into another kingdom."

As he spoke the man looked at shocked faces. Though their minds were racing none of them spoke. Finally, Charles asked,

"When should we leave?"

"Tonight," the man answered. "As soon as I give you the directions to the first town on the route."

"So soon?" asked Gregory.

"Tomorrow will be too late. Once the bishop's men come for you, it is all over. Your only chance is to be gone as far away as you can by the time they arrive here."

"I cannot believe this!" cried Adiba. "How could this happen? We have been betrayed by one of your own priests."

"Now is not the time for that discussion," said Charles looking sternly at his wife.

Turning to the housekeeper, he said,

"Please, give us the instructions as to what we should do. We are most grateful for your help!"

Nodding his head the man said,

"Your first stop will be west of here, in the village of Saze. Walking all night, you should be there by mid-morning tomorrow. When you arrive go to the Frigolet Abbey; it is a Canonical Augustinian Community. Saze is a small village and you will have no problem finding the Abbey. Once there, enter the chapel, which is called Our Lady of Good Remedy. Your process there will be the same as it will be for every other town on the journey. Please listen carefully.

In each town go immediately to the parish church. Once you are there, explain that you seek the sacrament of confession. When you enter the confessional and the priest greets you in the name of Christ, say the traditional greeting, 'Bless me father, for I have sinned' and then add then words, 'Deus Volt,' your old battle cry, 'God wills it'. Wait for his response. If the priest replies, 'Beau Seant, the other Templar battle cry, you have the right person. If he does not, leave the church immediately. God willing, you will be able repeat this process at every village until you reach Tomar."

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"We understand," said Charles, still looking shocked, "We thank you for your help.

There is no way we could repay you for saving us all."

"I am honored to do so," replied the housekeeper.

He stepped forward and embraced Charles and then Gregory.

"Deus Volt," he whispered, with a smile on his face and quickly slipped out into the moonlit night.

Khalil who had silently listened intently, stepped forward.

"What of me?" he asked. "What am I to do?"

"As always," said Gregory, "you are free to join us on this adventure."

Khalil smiled. As he turned to his right, he saw Nicholas, who had also been listening in silence.

"Are you going back to Father Ludolphus?" Khalil asked, "You have saved our friends lives!"

"Yes, but possibly at the expense of my own," he responded, "If Steven tells the priest that I was out on the street tonight, he may well figure out that it was me, who warned his intended victims. It would hardly be the first time that he took out his wrath on me, but with the help of the Dominicans, it could very well be the last time!"

"What will you do?" asked Khalil.

Turning to face Charles he asked, "May Nicholas come with us?"

"Of course," said Charles as Gregory nodded his head.

"Thank you all," said Nicholas. "I am sure that you know, I have come to love all of you as I did my parents. You have been most kind and generous to me, but I believe that it is time for me to set out on my own and get as far away from Father Ludolphus and Steven as possible. Do you remember the offer that Captain Wolfgang made to me and Khalil as we left his ship?"

The group smiled and nodded.

"Well, I am returning to Genoa and going to sea with the captain, if he will still have me." Turning to Khalil, he asked,

"Would you like to go along?"

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Clearly torn, Khalil looked back and forth from Nicholas to the knights and their wives.

"I do not want to abandon you," he said with tears in his eyes.

Gregory smiled and stepped forward and put his arm on Khalil's shoulder.

"You will not be leaving us helpless, my son. You would make an excellent seaman."

"It is true," said Charles. "After seeing you in action against the pirate crew, brother Gregory and I agreed that if the times were different, we might suggest that you consider the Order of the Temple."

Turning to Nicholas with a smile on his face, Khalil said,

"To Genoa it is! We also must leave tonight so that no-one in Avignon knows where we have gone."

"That settles it," said Charles. "Gather no more that you can carry and we will depart in different directions."

Looking at the young men he said,

"You know our ultimate destination. If you are ever in a port near Tomar, please visit us."

After hugs and best wishes the two groups set off on the same road in opposite directions. There was a nearly full moon that would illuminate the way, toward Saze and Genoa.

Chapter 32

October 1341

Saze, Kingdom of France

Quickly and quietly, the couples navigated the streets of Avignon, watching for anyone that might witness their departure. As they expected, the streets were deserted an hour after midnight. Once they reached the western edge of the city, they were able to relax, though they continued to look over their shoulders. After an hour of walking in silence. Gregory turned to his companions and softly said.

“I think we have made it. There should be no travelers on the road at this hour.”

“It will be at least six or seven hours before Father Ludolphus comes to take us to the Dominicans. We should be most of the way to Saze, by that time, said Charles.

“Still, we should walk as quickly as we can. If possible, I would like to be in Saze by sunrise,” added Gregory.

“I have been thinking about that also,” said Charles, “when the bishop sends men out to chase after us, they will not be on foot. With good horses, they might catch up to us before we arrive in the village.”

Turning to Adiba and Jamcela, Gregory asked, “Do you think we could walk any faster? Would you be alright?”

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“If it would keep you out of the hands of the Dominicans, we would run the whole way,” said Jamcela. Adiba nodded in agreement.

“Running should not be necessary,” said Charles smiling, “with a brisk walk, we should be fine.”

Walking at a faster pace, with the moon lighting their way, they managed to complete the journey just as the morning light began to illuminate the outskirts of the sleepy little village of Saze. They had no trouble recognizing Frigolet Abbey which was the largest building in the village and the only stone structure. They were quickly able to identify the church they sought. Charles thought to himself, ‘Every church in Christendom has basically the same design.’

When the four of them entered the Our Lady of Good Remedy Chapel, the only person they encountered was an elderly priest.

Father Percival was a short, older looking man; bald except for a ring of grey hair around the edges. He wore a full grey beard. The priest was clearly surprised to greet four travelers first thing in the morning. As he walked toward the travelers he asked,

“Good morning, is there something that I could do for you?”

He was even more confused when Gregory responded,

“Good morning father, I would like you to hear my confession.”

Father Percival had been a priest for most of his life and had heard some curious requests, but this was a new one. As he nodded his head and directed Gregory toward the confessional, he wondered to himself ‘what sin could possibly merit such urgency.’

Percival closed the doors to their adjoining booths. The other three travelers remained out in the pews.

He began by quietly saying, “How may I help you, my son?”

When Gregory responded as the bishop’s house-keeper had directed, the shocked priest realized who was before him seeking absolution. His eyes welled with tears. He stepped out of the confessional booth and opened the door to Gregory’s side.

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“It has been so long,” he said, “I thought I would never see a Templar pass through this route again.”

With tears running down his cheeks, he hugged Gregory and then Charles who had walked up to stand near them in front of the confessionals. Turning, the priest nodded to their wives, wondering to himself who they were and why they were in the company of two Templar Knights. His curiosity was overcome by the urgency of their situation.

“I would love to have you stay with us here in Saze for a while, but it is more important that you move on quickly in case you are being followed. You will stay here with me in the rectory today and start on your next part of the journey this evening. Only I will know that you are here and will tell anyone who might follow later, asking about you, that I have seen no one. As much as I would love to visit with you and hear of your adventures, it is more important that you eat and rest, before your journey. You will not be out of danger until you cross the border into the Kingdom of Aragon and even then, you may be followed for some distance in hopes of capturing you and dragging you back into the bishop’s jurisdiction.”

“Thank you, father for your understanding and assistance,” said Charles, “you have no idea how much this means to us.”

“Oh, sadly I know very well and am most happy to be of assistance,” Percival said shaking his head.

Without further discussion, Father Percival led the couples to his rectory. After entering, he immediately shut the door behind them. The travelers were tired and hungry and once they had eaten, Charles, Gregory, Adiba and Jamcela sat down to rest and almost immediately fell asleep.

After sleeping most of the afternoon, Adiba was the first to awaken. As she rubbed the sleep from her eyes; she looked at her still snoring husband. Since the day before, she had been feeling badly about what she had said when they became aware of Father Ludolphus’ betrayal. Charles was always a kind, patient husband and it hurt her to think that she had upset him. When he awoke, she asked if she could talk with him away from the others. Not sure of

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what she wanted to talk about, he led her to the walled garden area behind the church rectory.

“What troubles you, my love?” Charles asked with a smile on his face.

“I need to beg your forgiveness for the things I said, in anger, about the priest. I know that it was not my place to do so and that it angered you.”

Without a word, Charles stepped forward putting his arms around her shoulders, laying her head against his chest.

“My anger was not with you,” he said smiling. “It was for the man who had lied to us from the beginning. While we were still on the ship, Captain Wolfgang tried to warn me and Gregory about this possibility. I doubt if he knew exactly what his old friend had in store for us, but I suspect that he knew what the man was capable of. I still feel angry about being so easily fooled.”

“We had no way of knowing that there was a purpose to his generosity. He is a man of God,” Adiba said.

“Yes,” said Charles. “It was not the first time that I have seen a man of God act in such a way, but it is always so very disappointing. This time it could have been deadly for all of us. Just know that I certainly understand why you spoke that way and am not at all upset with you. Religions are created for the betterment of man, through the teachings of their gods, but are too often administered by men who twist those teachings to serve their own purposes.”

Adiba looked up at Charles and said,

“Every man is different and possibly every man’s god is different also.”

Charles gently wiped the tears from her cheeks, hugged her once again and said,

“Now we must wake to our traveling companions and get ready to depart as evening approaches.”

Father Percival arrived as Gregory and Jamcela were awaking from their afternoon nap. He had brought them two wine skins and two large loafs of bread.

“I am sorry that I cannot do more to make your visit pleasant, but it is important that you get as far from Avignon as you

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can, as soon as you can. Your next destination is Nimes. It is a good day's walk. If you do not stop along the way, you should be there by midmorning tomorrow. Travel safely and may the Lord be with you."

Father Percival gave them his blessing and their journey began. Though no longer full, the moon still provided sufficient light to make walking safe and easier than it would have been in total darkness. Again, the group set a walking pace that was faster than it would have been in less stressful situations. The exertion they put into walking took the edge off of the cool evening air. The roadway was easy to follow and the short grass of the center section between the wagon ruts made a comfortable walking path. Every hour or so they stopped for a few minutes to rest, drink some watered wine and then continued on their way.

Chapter 33

October 1341

Nimes, Kingdom of France

As the first dim light of morning began to replace the illumination of the waning moon, they began to feel more comfortable and talked quietly as they walked. Shortly after the sun broke over the horizon, they began to see vineyards on what would turn out to be the east edge of a town. Row upon row of grape vines stretched across both sides of the road and extended as far south as they could see.

“This must be Nimes,” Adiba said quietly.

“Indeed, it is!” said Gregory. “We made good time getting here. Do you know that this town is named after Nemausus, the genie of a sacred fountain?”

“How do you know that?” asked Charles.

“Father Percival told me before we left,” responded Gregory. “He also told me that in Roman times, Nimes was one of the richest towns in Gaul and that just a hundred years ago, possession of the town passed from the Courts of Toulouse to France.”

“You are an absolute font of information, aren’t you?” said Charles, shaking his head.

Looking up, Jamcela asked, “What is that stone structure over the roadway?” The group stopped and looked up at a series of

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stone arches that extended as far as they could see on either side of the road.

“It looks like an aqueduct,” said Charles. “If it is, that flat section on top of the arch has a channel that carries water from a distant stream or lake to the town. It is most likely left over from Roman times.”

“I have never seen anything like that,” said Adiba.

“Many towns in this part of the world use a system like that,” said Gregory. “If they cannot dig a well to find water, they can bring it in from sources, sometimes quite far away.”

As the group walked under the stone arch, they saw another tall structure constructed of three layers of arches one on top of the other. The whole building appeared to be in the shape of an ellipse.

“What could that be?” asked Adiba. “It is as big as a palace, but in a very different shape. There are no corners, it seems to be round.”

“It has been many things,” said a voice from behind them.

Turning, the group saw a short, stocky man wearing a heavy leather apron that hung from a strap around his neck and was tied with a rope around his waist. In his hands he carried a hammer and a pair of tongs.

“I did not mean to startle you,” he said. “My name is James. I am the village metal rite. Can I help you?”

“Yes,” said Charles, “we are looking for the village church.”

“You are very close,” said James, “It is just behind the walls that you see in front of you.”

“What is this structure?” said Gregory. “It seems somewhat familiar, but I can’t remember where I have seen one like it.”

“Have you been to Rome?” James asked.

“Yes, we both have,” replied Charles, pointing to himself and Gregory.

“Then you have seen one before,” said James, “this is another Roman amphitheater and the structure you just walked under is an aqueduct also built by the Romans. They were both built over a thousand years ago and are as sound as the day they were finished.”

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“What is this building used for?” asked Adiba.

“It was originally used for gladiatorial shows, chariot races and naval spectacles. The whole structure was constructed of stones from a local quarry. All of the stones were set in place without mortar!”

“The Romans were amazing engineers, weren’t they,” said Gregory.

“Indeed, they were. This structure has been in constant use for over a thousand years. After the decline of Rome, the Visigoths used the amphitheater as a fortress and more recently a church and several houses have been constructed within its walls. The church you seek, is right inside the gates you see in front of you.”

“You are both helpful and informative!” said Charles, “we appreciate your assistance!”

“My pleasure, my friends, I hope that you find what you seek inside.”

With a slight bow of his head, James smiled and continued on his way around the outside wall, while the four travelers walked through the open gates. Once inside it was soon clear which building served as the village church.

At first sight it had the look of a Roman or Greek temple, which it very well may have been, at one time, centuries ago. It sat on a rectangular stone platform four meters high, with a large, square stone building situated back from a staircase that led up from the ground level. It was set in from the edges with a row of tall pillars going all around the edge of the base. On top of the pillars sat a pitched roof, covering the building and the open part of the platform.

“This looks like a smaller version of the temples in Rome and those on the Acropolis in Athens,” said Gregory.

“Indeed, it does,” said Charles, “but it would hardly be the first pagan temple converted into a Christian church!”

“Shall we see if they are offering confessions there today?” asked Gregory.

Shaking his head, Charles said, “Yes, let me ask this time.”

While Gregory, Adiba and Jamcela waited at the base of the stairs Charles climbed the steps and entered the tall double doors at

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the front of the building. Having no windows at all, the interior was dark except where candles provided illumination. When his eyes adjusted to the semi-darkness, Charles saw a tall man with sparse grey hair, wearing a black robe, kneeling at the altar railing. As Charles approached him from behind the man continued facing forward, his head bowed. Charles softly cleared his throat and the man turned slowly to look over his shoulder.

“May I help you, my son?” he said.

“Would you hear my confession, father?” replied Charles.

The man looked at Charles, but did not ask the question in his eyes.

“My name is Father Perrette,” he said, “follow me, if you will.”

Once in the confessional, he said,

“How may I help you, my son?”

Charles responded, “Bless me father, it has been very long since my last confession. Deus Volt.” The priest hesitated and finely replied,

“Beau Sant”.

Without another word, he stepped out of the confessional and opened the other door for Charles.

“Saints preserve us, I never thought I would ever see another Templar in my lifetime! Where have you been?” he asked.

“It is a long story,” said Charles. “If you look outside, you will see another Templar standing with both of our wives.”

Father Perrette tilted his head and furrowed his brow.

“Father, we are possibly being followed. It would be best if we answered your questions in a less public setting,” said Charles.

“Of course, let me take you to a safe place immediately! And yes, I do have several questions,” he added with a smile.

At the bottom of the chapel steps, Charles quickly introduced Father Perrette to Gregory, Adiba and Jamcela.

“I don’t mean to be abrupt,” Father Perrette said, “but I want to get you off the street before our little village awakens and more people see that you are here. Have you talked to anyone before you entered to the church?”

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“Yes, we got directions from a man that called himself James,” said Gregory.

“That should be alright, said the priest who looked clearly relieved, “I know him, he works for the man I am taking you to see. If you will please follow me.”

Chapter 34

October 1341

Lavigne Estate, Nimes, Kingdom of France

Father Perrette and the travelers left the amphitheater and quickly walked toward the opposite side of the village. A short ways out of town, they went through the gates of what appeared to be a lavish estate. The road lead up a shallow incline toward a large, stone manner-house with a red, tiled roof. On the left side of the road, there were grape vines in neat rows, as far as the eye could see. To the right was a large grassy pasture with at least twenty horses. When they approached the double doors at the front of the manner house, the priest turned to the travelers and said,

“This is the estate of the Lavigne Family. They have been here in Nimes, for generations and have been making superb wines for over a century. As you will soon learn, they have deep connections with your Order.”

The priest struck the massive wooden door with the large round iron knocker that hung from its center. He then turned and smiled at the travelers. Shortly the door opened and a servant who recognized Father Perrette invited the visitors into the vestibule.

“Could we speak with your master?” the priest asked.

“Certainly Father, I will summon him,” the servant replied, turning to leave the room. They soon heard the sound of footsteps coming down a curved stone stairway. Looking up they saw a tall

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stately gentleman who appeared to be about the same age as the knights.

“Father Perrette,” the man said with a smile on his face, “who do we have here?”

“I bring you two Knights of the Temple,” he replied.

The smile faded from the older man’s face and he stared at Charles and Gregory in silence. His dark brown eyes did not blink as he tried to make sense of what he had just heard.

“Knights of the Temple of Solomon?” he said slowly, with what may have been tears welling up in his eyes. “What brings you here?” he continued.

“Dais Volt,” answered Gregory. For a moment there was silence. At length the man slowly smiled and said,

“I am Abelard Lavigne and yes, God does will it. Welcome to my home!”

Turning to the servant he said,

“Bring us bread, cheese and some of our best wine; we will be in the great room.” Looking to his guests he added,

“Please follow me.” He led the group past the staircase into a spacious room with polished, wooden floors, stone walls and three sets of open double doors that looked out over the vineyards.

“I have much to ask you,” he said as he directed them toward heavy wooden chairs around a long table.

“We have much to tell you.” responded Charles, smiling.

As Father Perrette and Abelard asked the guests questions, Gregory and Charles took turns answering and relating the details of their lives in northern France, their trip to Outremer, the fall of Acre, their years of slavery with the Sultan, their rescue of the Sultan’s daughters and finally how they were found by a priest who later betrayed them.

Adelard and Father Perrette listened intently and when the knights were finished, Adelard nodded and stated that he understood their situation. He added that the four of them were safe at his estate and that he had sufficient men in his employ to protect them if others were to come seeking to return them to Avignon.

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“I am so pleased that you are safe,” said Father Perrette. “If you will excuse me, I have important matters to attend to at the parish house. Smiling at the group, he nodded and left the room.

As the men had been speaking, Adiba and Jamcela ate some of the delicious goat cheese and freshly baked bread, that the servants had brought to the table. They also drank their first glasses of un-watered wine. They were both tired from their long walk and were trying not to yawn, struggling to stay awake. Adelard noticed their situation and smiled.

“I fear you wives are exhausted after their long walk,” he said. “I would suggest that all of you might need some rest. We can continue our conversation over the evening meal.”

“That would be very good,” said Charles. “We are all tired and could use some sleep.”

“Excellent,” said Adelard. “I will have one of the servants show you to your rooms. We will call for you just before the dinner hour. If there is anything that you need before then, please let us know.”

“Is there a place for us to bathe and wash our clothes?” asked Adiba.

“Yes, of course,” said Adelard. “I will send our servants to attend to all of your needs.”

“Thank you so much,” said Gregory. “We most sincerely appreciate your kindness and hospitality.”

One of the household servants led the couples to separate rooms where they, for the first time in memory, were able to sleep on comfortable beds. The servants brought them warm water to bathe in and fresh smocks to wear while their clothes were being laundered. With full stomachs and the help of some excellent wine, the knights and their ladies slept soundly and securely until late in the afternoon when a servant summoned them to the evening meal.

Chapter 35

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Lavigne Estate, Nimes, Kingdom of France

When the travelers began to stir from their afternoon nap, they noticed that the sun was getting low in the sky. As she slowly awoke, Adiba turned to Gregory lying next to her and said,

“That could possibly have been my best sleep ever. My first warm bath in who knows how long, clean clothes, a real bed and the best wine I have ever tasted. If there is indeed a place called haven, I suspect it is very much like this.”

“Oh, I agree,” said Gregory, smiling, “If heaven is like this, it would make living a virtuous life worthwhile even if it only meant not having to sleep on the ground for eternity.”

Giving his wife a hug and a kiss on her forehead, Gregory added,

“Shall we go out to see if Charles and Jamcela are awake?”

When they opened the door and walked into the hallway, they saw Charles and Jamcela talking to the servant that Adelard had sent to escort them to the evening meal.

The servant led the couples back down stairs to the great-room where they saw that the long table had been set for six. There was a beautifully embroidered red table runner that stretched down the center of the table from one end to the other. On both of the long sides, there were two place settings and one setting at each of the

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far ends. A servant directed the guests to the table and seated each couple in the high-back chairs on either side. The chairs at the ends of the table remained empty. Another servant entered the room carrying a carafe of red wine. He half-fill each of the guest's silver goblets. When he had finished, he announced that the master and his wife would be there shortly.

Gregory, Adiba, Charles and Jamcela sat quietly looking around the large, candle-lit room. The scent of the candles mingled with the cool evening breeze that gently blew in from the vineyards. One wall of the great-room housed a massive, stone fireplace that was wide enough for a tall man to lie in without touching either side. The grate in the center contained firewood. It had not yet been lit. On the wall opposite the fireplace hung four large oil portraits of men on horseback. As Gregory studied the paintings, he thought to himself that the horses the men sat astride were large steeds; more similar to the Destriers that knights rode into battle than the smaller horses that most travelers used. His thoughts were interrupted by the sound of foot falls coming from behind him.

"Good evening, my friends. I trust you had a sound rest," said Adelard in his usual soft voice. "May I introduce you to my wife, Gabrielle Lavigne."

Turning toward the door the guests saw a tall, elegantly dressed woman with long, grey hair tied into a single braid. As her husband made the introductions, she smiled warmly at each of them.

"Welcome to our home," she said. "You have no idea how wonderful it is for us to see you."

The travelers looked at each other, but no one spoke. Finally, Charles interrupted the awkward silence and said,

"It is our sincere pleasure to be here also!"

Adelard escorted his wife to the chair at the end of the table closest to the entrance and then took his place at the head of the table near the doors overlooking the vineyard.

"My husband has told me so much about you," said Gabrielle. "I am anxious to hear more."

"And so, we shall," said Adelard. "But let us not allow our meal to grow cold as we talk," he said with a smile. He signaled for

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the servants to begin bringing in the food. The servers brought platters of vegetables, bread and sections of rack of lamb and presented plates of the warm repast to the master, mistress and each of their four guests.

During the meal they talked about the weather, the coming wine harvest and other topics intended to avoid the real issues on every mind. When all had finished eating, and the plates were cleared the wine goblets were refilled. Gabrielle turned to the guests with tears in her eyes and in a voice that sounded more like a cry than a questions, said,

“You know that our family has deep ties to the Templar Order, do you not?”

After a moment, Charles said,

“We did not know that until Father Perrette mention it when we arrived.”

“Both of our families do,” said Adelard, “I have, or had, three younger brothers who took the cross and became members of your Order. Gabrielle also had a brother who did the same.” Everyone sat in silence, avoiding the obvious, but painful next question.

Adelard broke the silence. “When the Order was suppressed, two of my three brothers were taken by the king’s men. My youngest brother, Walkelin, was visiting our home here in Nimes when word came of the arrest of all Templars. We were able to hide him and eventually help him escape to safety.”

“And your brother?” said Gregory, looking at Gabrielle.

“They arrested my brother as well.” She said softly.

“Six months after we heard of arrest of the Templars, we had a visit from a truly unexpected individual,” said Adelard. “A slight built young man arrived at our gate one afternoon asking to speak with us. He was thin, gaunt and badly bruised. He had clearly been recently beaten. He had a wide-eyed look of terror on his face. Our men at the gate brought him to the house where Gabrielle and I met him and asked him why he was here. In a voice that sounded more like croaking than speaking, he told us that he was a Dominican novitiate who had deserted his monastery and had come to us with a message from my brothers. At first, of course, we did

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not understand. We had him come into the house and offered him food and drink. He hesitated, saying that we should first listen to why he was here and what he had to say. He added that after hearing that, we might not want him here at all. Confused, we asked him to go on.

He told us that his name was Brother Anthony and that he had been almost through his time as a novitiate and was soon to take final vows to become a Dominican Frier . He explained that he had entered the Dominican Order almost a year ago with the usual intention of “preaching the Gospel of Jesus Christ for the salvation of souls.” With tears in his eyes, he went on to explain that his encounter with our brothers changed all of that.

“What your brothers asked me to tell you is horrible!” he told us, hesitating. “Are you sure you want me to go on? Are you sure you want to hear this?”

“They are our brothers.” we answered. “We need to know what happened to them.”

He could not make eye contact with us and stared at the wall over our heads as he spoke.

Chapter 36

October 1307

Paris, Kingdom of France

Brother Anthony began.

“In mid-October of 1307, I was assigned to travel to Paris with a team of Dominican Inquisitors to question Templar Knights that had been arrested on the orders of King Philip of France. Starting on the thirteenth of that month, Philip had ordered the arrest of over 15,000 knights. We began the process of questioning one hundred of these knights on October nineteenth.

The king had charged these Templars with a long list of offences including the worship and service of the Devil, believing that Jesus was a false prophet, spitting, trampling and urinating on an image of the cross, having carnal knowledge of other Templars, and worshipping a demon named Baphomet. I was dumbstruck and horrified as I heard the charges being read aloud to the knights. It was clear from the looks on their faces that they were also shocked. One by one they were asked to admit to the charges. Every knight refused to do so. As they denied the offences, they were stripped of their outer garments and tied with their hands behind their backs. Ropes had been thrown over the roof beams and one end of the rope was tied to the knight's hands. The other end was grasped by friars. They proceeded to pull on the rope until the knights were suspended by their arms, behind their backs. I could see that the men were in

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agony. Many tried not to cry out and failed. As their bodies wretched in pain the movement caused their shoulders to dislocate.

While this was being done to some knights, others were stretched on the rack, dislocating both their shoulders and hips. I could hear the noise of the shoulders and hips popping loose and the screams of the men as they suffered. Many of the knights cried aloud, often making unhuman sounding noises until they went horse, lost their voices or became unconscious. I tried, but could not help myself and the first time I witnessed this, I turned my back and vomited on the floor. My fellow friers laughed and ridiculed me for being weak while doing “the Lord’s work!” I remember thinking at the time that I had become a Dominican novitiate to defend the faith. What I witnessed seemed more like serving the Devil.

When the day of questioning was over the broken men were taken to a large cell where they were placed on a cold, stone floor. Those with dislocated hips were dragged, since they could not walk on their own. Those with dislocated shoulders could not even feed themselves the stale bread or rancid water that was left for them in the cells. In the evenings, I snuck down to the dungeon alone and ask the guard to allow me to go into the cell with the knights. There I fed those knights that could eat and provided water for those who could not even hold a cup. Every night after the questioning, at least one of the knights died. I sat with several who cried and moaned and suddenly went mercifully silent as their souls fled their bodies.

During my third night of helping these men, I fed two knights who told me that they were brothers and had family in the town of Nimes. They both thanked me for the help that I gave them and questioned whether I was cut out to be a good Dominican. They seemed to know that they would not survive and asked me to let their family know what had happened to them. I swore an oath to them to do so if at all possible.

It was also during this third night that my activities were discovered by one of the older friers. He reported me to our prior. I was brought to the prior’s cell where he screamed at me, saying that I was not worthy of being a Dominican. He ordered my fellow friers to beat me for my transgressions. They carried out their assignment

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with enthusiasm, leaving me with a swollen eye, a split lip, a chipped front tooth, and a bruised right hand that had been stomped upon.

The following day I was ordered to report to the courtyard where I was told to assist in stacking wood around poles where three knights were to be burned as heretics. Two of them were your brothers. If I had thought that the previous days of witnessing torture were horrendous, it was nothing compared to this day's horrors. The three knights were each tied to a post and had brush and firewood stacked around their feet until it was over their knees. When the wood was in place, one of the priests came forward and asked if any of them would like to confess their sins and avoid eternal damnation. None of them agreed to do so.

When the priest stepped back a friar with a torch came forward and one after another, lit the wood piled around each man. As the smoke rose and each fire began to burn, one knight started saying the Confiteor. The other two joined in "*Confiteor Deo omnipotenti.*" Their voices were loud and strong. Along with the other Dominicans, I watched in silence. As the fires grew, the smoke choked the lungs of the knights. They began to cough. We could see that they were trying not to cry out, but as the fire scorched their skin, they could not help but scream. The smell of their burning flesh filled the courtyard. I looked around to the faces of those who witnessed this with me. Most seemed surprisingly unaffected by what we saw, but some of the others appeared to share my reaction of horror to this vision of Hell. I knew, at that moment, that I must leave the order. Escape at the first opportunity. My goal was to honor my promise to your brothers and come here to Nimes. I later heard that several other Dominicans resigned rather than continue this brutal work. I was also told that the good name of the Dominicans would be forever stained by their participation in these cruel activities. Before long the order became popularly known as *Domini canes*, Latin for God's dogs. I cannot tell you how painful it is to share this information with you. I would understand completely if you wanted to take my life for my part in your brother's fate. Of late I have often thought of ending my own life.

Chapter 37

October 1341

Lavigne Estate, Nimes, Kingdom of France

Adelard looked at Charles, Gregory, Adiba and Jamcela.
“We did not harm him!”

“No, we thanked him for traveling all this way to honor his promise to our brothers,” added Gabrielle. We thanked him, attended to his injuries and sent him safely on his way after he had a chance to regain his strength.”

“It was not his fault that our brothers were tortured, for refusing to admit to the king’s lies,” said Gabrielle in a quivering voice.

The six of them again sat in silence. Finally, Charles said,

“For so many years, we knew nothing of these horrors. It was only when a priest found us on the shore of the Dead Sea that we learned what had happened to our Order. The last brother Templars that we saw were those who we were forced to witness being executed after the fall of Acre.”

“And yet, the more we learn, the more horrific the history of our Order seems to become,” said Gregory.

“I am sorry to go on like this after all of these years,” said Adelard, “But no matter how much time passes, the pain never seems to lessen! We believe that we have been betrayed by our church, our Pope and our King.”

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Gabrielle nodded. "The only salvation for us, is in the number of Templars, that over the years, we have been able to save from our brother's fate. It has been so long since the last knight came through here, we began to think that perhaps it was finally over."

"Yet it seems the ministers of our faith continue to betray and persecute their own," said Adelard, "Gabrielle and I have discussed this and want to help you reach the safety of Tomar. You appear to be very close to our age and thought we are in good health. I doubt that either of us could survive walking the entire Way of St. James. We would like you to make your journey on horseback, accompanied by three of our men. In addition to grapes, we also raise some fine riding horses that can take you safely across the border. Our men will be along, to keep you safe.

We have discussed your situation this afternoon and agree that the best route for you to reach Tomar is to travel from here to Barcelona on the East coast and there board a ship that will sail around the peninsula to the port of Lisbon, on the west coast. From there you can travel north to the town of Tomar, and the Convento do Christo, the headquarters of the Order of Christ. What do you think?"

"We think you are heaven sent," cried Jamcela.

Smiling, Gregory added, "I believe that she speaks for all of us!"

Adiba and Charles smiled and nodded their heads in agreement.

"I have one question," said Gregory. "When we reach Barcelona will there be ships sailing West that would be willing to take us?"

"I assure you that there will be one there for you, my brothers," said Adelard,

"What do you say?" he added.

Looking around at his companions and then Adelard, Charles said, "We most sincerely thank you for your kindness!"

"Then it is settled," said Adelard. "After a few days rest and some horseback riding practice, you will be on your way to safety. One more thing," he added smiling broadly. "I have a present for

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each of you knights.” He nodded to a servant who had been standing by the wall next to the main entry door.

“I would ask that you leave those simitars that you carry, here in Nimes and take these two Templar broad swords with you as my gift, to ensure your safety.”

As these words were spoken the servant placed two gleaming, silver broad swords on the table; one next to Charles and the other next to Gregory.

With a smile on his face, Gregory said, “I never thought that I would ever own a real sword again. We can never thank you enough for all that you are doing for us.”

As their group was preparing to retire for the evening, Adelard came up to Gregory and Charles and asked if they would seek out his brother when they reached Tomar.

“It has been some time since we have had word from Walkelin. I am concerned for his wellbeing.”

“We would be happy to,” replied the knights.

Chapter 38

October 1341

Lavigne Estate, Nimes

It was the Fall of the year, when, when the days were becoming noticeably shorter and the mornings and evenings were cooler. For the weary travelers the next few days were spent relaxing and exploring the grounds and gardens of the Lavigne estate. Adelard Lavigne's land had an aura of tranquility and order about it. The vineyards, gardens and even pastures looked more manicured than simply maintained. There was not a vine out of place nor a weed in sight. The leaves on the vines were beginning to lose their bright green hue as the first colors of Fall appeared. It was time to harvest the grapes. Men were walking up the rows of vines cutting the clumps of grapes free and placing them in large baskets. Others carried the baskets to horse-drawn wagons which, when full, carried the harvest to the large barn-like winery. There they would be crushed and fermented in large vats. The stems and seeds that remained would be distilled to produce the strong clear alcohol that the Italian vintners called Grappa. The workers responsible for this process seemed joyful in their work and clearly took pride in their efforts.

The same was true of those who managed the Lavigne livestock. Adelard's horse stables were impressive. The barns were spacious. Immaculate stone structures with stalls for over thirty

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animals. In the large green pastures, a half a dozen mares grazed with their folds at their sides.

Shortly after the morning meal, the second day, James came to Adiba and Jamcela to ask if they would like to go for a horseback ride. Knowing that the group had a long ride ahead of them in the coming days, Adelard had suggested that James take the ladies out to determine if they could ride and to help in selecting mounts for each of them that suited their riding abilities. After saddling two mares that were known to have gentle temperaments, James accompanied them on his own mild-mannered gelding.

Riding next to the women on the road through the center of the vineyard James turned to the ladies.

"I am impressed, this is clearly not your first time on horseback."

"True, it has been many years since our last ride, but it is all coming back to us quickly," replied Jamcela, smiling.

"Our father was a Sultan in Outremer, and like most men in that land, he loved horses. He allowed us to ride occasionally," added Adiba,

"Our two-week ride, from Al Karak Castle to Jaffa, on the coast, was made on burros" Jamcela exclaimed.

"Was that miserable?" asked James, grinning.

"Indeed, it was, but better than walking," said Jamcela, patting her horses' neck.

While Adiba and Jamcela were out riding, Charles and Gregory had time to walk together through the fields and pastures of the estate and discuss the events that had taken place in Avignon. At first, they walked in silence until they were confident that they could not be overheard.

"Is the shock of our priest's depravity wearing off for you, my brother," asked Gregory with a hint of a smile.

"No, but I am not sure that either of us was shocked as much a disappointed that our worst fears were so accurately founded," responded Charles, "We had both noticed a change in Ludolphus as our journey progressed."

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"I agree," said Gregory, looking off in the distance. "As time went by, he seemed progressively less inclined to overlook some of our life choices."

"If only you were more willing to confess and do penance for your multiple sins, Brother Gregory, things may have worked out so much better," said Charles, trying not to laugh.

"I fear that would not have helped, Brother Charles, I believe that Ludolphus like Marshal Sevry had no intention of ever telling us the truth".

"I agree," continued Charles, "Sevry had no trouble sending us off to die knowing full well that he had no intention of returning to Acre at all, much less with reinforcements. I can only wonder what Ludolphus had planned for us and our wives, assuming that the two of us survived the Dominican's questioning."

"I have thought about that also," added Gregory, "I can not imagine that either Ludolphus or his Bishop would want any survivors that knew of their quest for lost treasure."

As the knights came to the fence-line at the far end of the main vineyard they saw a stone bench. They both sat down. From this spot, they had a panoramic view of the entire estate and the village of Nimes beyond. Both sat quietly. Lost in their own thoughts. It was the first time in days that either of them felt relaxed.

After what seemed like a long time, they saw a man on horseback approaching them at a trot. When he neared them, he slowed his mount to a walk and called out,

"Good morning my friends, how are you this beautiful day?"

"We are fine, James and you?" asked Charles.

"Could not be better," James shouted, "I have just returned from a ride with your wives. We were concerned about their riding abilities and how that might impact the journey we have before us."

"So, what did you discover?" asked Charles.

"We have nothing to worry about," said James nodding his head. "Your wives are very capable riders and seemed to genuinely like the mounts I selected for them. I have more good news. My master, Adlard, has informed me that I am to take two of our

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Basque horse trainers along to ride with you and your ladies to Barcelona.”

“That is good news and it is very kind of you to assist us,” said Gregory.

“Ah, it is my honor to do so and only fitting since part of our route will be along the Way of St. James, which is named after my patron saint.” he exclaimed, beaming with pride.

“I don’t believe that we have met the two men that you mentioned,” said Gregory.

“Probably not,” said James, “they are a quiet pair, almost shy around strangers, but fine horsemen who are also familiar with the use of a good sword.”

“Excellent,” responded Charles, “when do you anticipate leaving?”

“Early tomorrow morning, if that is agreeable with you?” asked James.

Charles looked at Gregory, who nodded his approval.

“That should be fine,” Charles added. “How long will our journey be?”

“The whole trip should take us a little over eleven days, possibly a few more depending on weather and grass for the horses along the way. The first day we will have a long ride from Nimes to Montpellier, where we will stay with friends of the Lavignes. Montpellier to Narbonne is a two-day ride so we will have to sleep under the stars one night. Narbonne to Perpignan and Perpignan to Figueres will both be two-day rides, but by that time we will be well into the County of Roussillon, in the Kingdom of Aragon. If the bishop’s men were to find us there, they would have no authority over us and would likely not be treated kindly by the local people. After Perpignan, we have another four-day ride to Barcelona passing through Girona, and Lloret de Man along the way.

“It sounds like you have the journey well planned,” said Charles.

“I agree, I am looking forward to this,” Gregory added.

Well before daylight, the morning of their departure, the travelers heard a knock on their bedroom doors. It was one of the Lavignes’ serving maids there to announce that breakfast was about

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to be served. The couples quickly dressed and proceeded down stairs to the dining room where they were greeted by Adelard and Gabrielle.

“Good morning my friends,” said Adelard smiling. “I know it is very early, but I believe that it is better that you ride out of town in the dark. The fewer people that know of your where-about, the better. I would like to think that you are now safe from the bishop’s grasp, but one never knows for certain. Greed is a powerful motivator and would prompt some to chase you to the gates of Hell in hopes of gathering information concerning a legendary treasure.”

“I would like to hope that is not the case,” said Gregory, “but at this point nothing would surprise me.”

“We understand,” added Charles nodding, “We have long believed in hoping for the best, but being prepared for the worst.”

As the food was being brought in from the kitchen, Gabrielle looked along the table at each of their guests. Tears were welling up in her eyes.

“It has meant so much for us to meet you. I can’t tell you how much it means to make contact with ones who are so much like the brothers that Adelard and I lost so long ago. It may seem silly but though our time together has been short, I know that I will miss you terribly. We hope, with all of our hearts, that you will find safety and comfort far from the forces of evil.”

“We will miss you also,” said Adiba, “you have been so very kind to us.”

Jamcela quietly nodded, her eyes also welling up.

“When you return to your rooms to gather your things you will find new clothes that we wish to send with you,” said Gabrielle.

Nodding and smiling, Adelard said, “You should eat a hearty meal now to sustain you for the long days ride. James and the men are outside with the horses packed and ready to go.” Looking at Charles and Gregory, he could not help but think of his bothers.

When the travelers came back down stairs after gathering their belongings, it was time for hugs and sincere best wishes. With tears streaming down her cheeks, Gabrielle kissed each of the travelers on the cheek and told them that she was praying that God

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would watch over them on their journey. All four smiled and nodded.

Stepping outside the front door the travelers were greeted by James, who introduced them to the men who would accompany them on their journey.

“I would like you all to meet Abarran and Ganiz,” said James. Pointing toward the taller of the men he said, “This is Abarran, he has a mount for each of you knights.”

Looking toward the other man he added, “And this is his partner, Ganiz, who has the two mares that you ladies rode yesterday. He will help you secure your belongings behind your saddles and adjust your stirrups.”

Charles and Gregory smiled and nodded to the men. They noticed that each man, like James, carried a broad sword in a scabbard across his back.

Charles and Gregory secured their provisions with the straps behind their saddles and mounted the two tall geldings that James had selected for them. With one last look toward their guests, the group turned their mounts down the road and began their journey.

As their guests rode away, Adelard and Gabrielle stood hand in hand watching. They felt a hollow emptiness that was left behind in the early morning mist. While they treasured the opportunity to interact with those so close to their brothers’ spirits, they were saddened by the certainty that they would never see them again.

Chapter 39

October 1341

Montpellier, Kingdom of France

The seven rode quietly through the sleeping town of Nimes and took the road leading south. They did not see a soul on their way. An hour south of Nimes, just as dawn was breaking, James indicated that it was time to stop for a moment.

“Out here in the countryside it is safe for us to talk quietly,” said James. Looking at the knights and their ladies, he asked “Are you mounts satisfactory?”

“Both of us still like them.” said Adiba, smiling.

“Ours are fine also.” added Gregory.

“I know that you are probably more used to riding war horses,” said James, “I hope that these geldings I have selected for you will not prove disappointing.”

“Oh, not at all,” Charles confided. “We never rode Destriers any more than we had to.”

James looked surprised.

Gregory nodded, “Chargers were great horses when the job was to drive a lance into an enemy soldier. They would bite, kick and run over anyone you rode towards, but they were a handful to control.”

Charles agreed. “We used to say that there was never a moments relaxation while sitting on their backs. They were all very

large stallions, over a half ton of pent-up anger. I can't remember ever looking back and missing a minute on one of those beasts."

"Either did I," exclaimed Gregory. "In battle they served their purpose well, but for traveling, I would rather walk than work to control one of them all day."

"That is good to hear," said James. "I think before we go any further, we should also talk about our riding formation. I would like to suggest that three of us lead, with the ladies riding in the middle. The other two can follow behind."

James looked at Charles and Gregory who were both smiling.

"Are you sure you were never a Templar?" asked Gregory, grinning.

James looked puzzled.

"That is the exact travel formation that we always used when traveling with large armies in Outremer," said Charles. "Our order was very often in the vanguard where attacks most frequently occurred. "

"That is good to know," replied James. "The road we are traveling is generally safe. Most robbers would rather not target a party with five armed men. I am more concerned with those that might be following you at the bishop's bidding. I would prefer to be ready for any situation."

"That is always wise," said Gregory.

James suggested that he ride in the front along with one of the knights and one of the Basque horsemen and that the other knight and horsemen follow behind Adiba and Jemcela.

"I would like to stay in the front," said James, "to guide. The others can trade positions when we stop to rest and water the horses."

That first day the party set a brisk walking pace. The Fall weather still featured beautiful warm days, and they stopped only to stretch their legs, water the horses and eat a light lunch of dates, bread and watered wine. They were making good time without exhausting their mounts. As the sun was setting, they approached the town of Montpellier where Adelard had told James of a family

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of his close friends who would be happy to provide them with accommodations for the night.

When they arrived at the manner house of Andre Frelie, Adelard's friend, he was more than happy, to meet them. When James explained to Andre that two of the men with him were members of the Knights Templar, the man seemed ecstatic and commenced to treat the group like honored guests. When the travelers sat down that evening to dinner with Andre, his wife, Yvonne and their five children, the host explained to his family, with great reverence, that they were dining in the presence of two knights of the legendary Templar Order. His children sat in wide-eyed silence looking at Charles and Gregory without saying a word.

James had mentioned to their host the urgency of their travel schedule, so after dinner there was only time for brief conversations before the household servants took the travelers to their rooms for the evening. As they were being led down a long hallway, Gregory turned to Charles and said,

"I am pretty sure those children had no idea what their father was talking about when he introduced us."

Charles smiled and responded, "Yes, but they were still very polite. We need to remember that this man and his wife were probably not born until twenty-five years or so after the fall of Acre. As far as the children are concerned, they might as well have been introduced to Julius Caesar."

"I fear you are right!" said Gregory laughing.

After a very comfortable night's rest, the journey commenced early the next morning. Andre had his servants provide the group with a hearty breakfast and then insisted on riding along with the travelers to the outskirts of Montpellier. There he wished them all a safe journey. The next city on the route was Narbonne, two long days ride from Montpellier.

Chapter 40

October 1341

Avignon, Kingdom of France

While conditions continued to improve for the knights and their ladies, back in Avignon, significant changes had begun to impact those who had been left behind. Six hours after the knight's midnight departure, Father Ludolphus arrived at the rectory in the company of four armed men.

After searching the building and finding it empty, he returned to the bishop's palace and reported that the knights and their wives were not only gone, but no one seemed to have any idea where they went. The bishop's complexion turned from its usual pasty white, to a glowing red. Overhearing the conversation while sweeping the floor in an adjacent room, the bishop's housekeeper spoke up and shared that one of the men delivering bread to the palace early that morning had mentioned overhearing two elderly couples asking for directions to the city of Toulouse. At this point, Father Ludolphus interrupted the housekeeper and added that Toulouse, in the Provence of Languedoc was where the Templar Knight, Gregory was raised. He added that it was very likely that Gregory still had family there.

The housekeeper turned his back and smiled as he resumed sweeping the stone floor. Toulouse is north of Avignon and that was the direction in which the bishop sent his guards in hopes of overtaking the couples.

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Turning to face the Bishop, Father Ludolphus offered to order Nicholas and Steven to assist in the search, only to learn, from a smug-looking Steven, that he had no idea where Nicholas was and had not seen him since the previous afternoon. Steven was rewarded for his honesty with a robust slap across the face. This prompted Steven to immediately implement plans to depart for his parents' home in Suchem.

After a week of searching, the guards returned to Avignon emptyhanded. The bishop reminded the still wide-eyed Father Ludolphus, that if the Templar treasure had been found, he had planned to reward him by making him a Monsignor, in charge of a large, prestigious parish. Instead, the Bishop said that he would convince the Pope to assign the disgraced priest to a different posting. He would soon be the parish priest of a remote village along the Rhone River.

After only two months in his new assignment, Ludolphus went missing, only to be found washed upon on the riverbank by fishermen from a village several leagues downstream. At Ludolphus' posting, the parishioners, who had never warmed up to their new pastor, wondered aloud, but without smiling, why their priest would choose to go swimming while wearing his heavy woolen cassock.

Chapter 41

October 1341

Montpellier to Narbonne, Kingdom Of France

The ride from Montpellier to the next town, Narbonne, took two long days in the saddle. James was quite familiar with the route and mentioned to his fellow travelers that he knew of a wonderful place to camp between the towns. The spot was a little over half the distance to Narbonne and was surrounded by beautiful pine trees and had a stream running through it that had a shallow pool, perfect for bathing. Along the banks of the stream, he said that there was
always green grass for the horses.

The part about bathing in the stream was especially delightful to Adiba and Jamcela, who joked to each other, in private, that they had experienced enough dust and grime covered days of traveling to last them a lifetime. Not wanting to offend their husbands, they had never shared their feelings about the ordeal of traveling for days across the deserts of Outremer, caked with sand and dust. Considering the hot baths they had enjoyed in Nimes and Montpellier, this leg of the journey seemed like a bit of heaven.

The horses that James had selected for Adiba, Jamcela, Gregory and Charles proved to be especially pleasant to ride. They were clearly well trained and their gate was smooth. At a brisk walk they covered much more ground than any person could on foot. Later in the morning as they approached the place that James had

selected to stop for lunch Gregory, who was riding at the rear of the group next to Ganiz, noticed that Adiba's horse had stepped over a snake that was crossing the road. The horse neither stopped nor hesitated. When he pointed at the snake Ganiz noticed it also.

"That is a well-mannered steed," said Gregory. "I've seen many a horse that would start jumping and do everything it could to unload its rider after seeing a snake. Your horses are much better trained than many of the mounts I rode years ago."

"Adelard Lavigne only has well-trained stock, replied Ganiz, "Any that are not or can't be trained to work successfully are soon gone."

When the sun was near its highest point, the road started to climb through a wide, open meadow toward a flat plateau at the top of a saddle. When they reached the summit, they saw a small, clear, winding creek that was almost hidden in the tall grass.

"This is where we will stop to eat," announced James. Turning toward his guests he said,

"Make your selves comfortable, Abarran and Gniz will take the horses for water and stake them out so they can eat some grass."

As James spread out blankets for them to sit on, he explained, "We have some dried meats and freshly baked bread that Andre's cook sent along to go with the wine that Andre provided. You will probably not be surprised to learn that the wine is from the Lavigne Winery."

"That is wonderful," said Adiba, "except if I drink too much of that excellent wine, I might fall asleep in the saddle."

"Oh, don't worry," Gregory replied, "if we see you nodding off, we will tie you on over the horses' back and wake you up when we arrive."

Adiba smiled and slowly shook her head.

After lunch they remounted the horses and continued their ride. They crossed the broad meadow, and began their descent toward a vast, flat, treeless plain. It was a clear sunny day and they could see for miles. James pointed across the plain and asked, "Do you see those trees on the far horizon?"

Everyone looked.

"Just barely," said Charles.

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"That is where we will spend the night," replied James. "It is another half days ride away."

"And it is a beautiful day for a ride," added Gregory.

Jamcela and Adiba nodded in agreement. As they rode along, the two women chatted with each other. They never seemed to run out of things to talk about. Both Charles and Gregory talked with James when they were riding in the lead, with him. They had no luck trying to converse with either of the Basque horse trainers. When Gregory mentioned to Charles his unsuccessful efforts to converse with Abarran and Ganiz, he seemed puzzled.

"Do you think I offended them," he asked.

"No and I don't think I did either," declared Charles earnestly.

"Perhaps we can try again this evening?" Gregory lamented. Charles nodded.

As the sun began to sink toward the horizon early in the afternoon, as it does this time of year, the travelers saw the grove of trees getting larger as they approached.

Turning back in the saddle to address Gregory and Charles, James said,

"When we arrive, Abarran and Ganiz will take the horses down to the river for water. If you would not mind, would you gather brush and branches for our fire."

"That will not be a problem" said Gregory smiling, "We know a little about gathering firewood."

"Yes, I imagine you do," replied James sheepishly, "Adelard told me of your work for the Sultan."

When the group rode into the grove, they saw a small clearing that had a ring of stones with charred sticks and logs in the center.

"I have camped here on many other occasions," James explained as the group dismounted.

"After we unpack our provisions, Abarran and Ganiz will remove the horses' saddles and blankets before they lead them to water. If we place the saddles and blankets around the ring of

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stones, we should be able to sleep comfortably near the warmth of the fire.”

James, Adiba and Jamcela arranged the blankets around the fire ring while Abarran and Ganiz led the horses to the river and Charles and Gregory walked out in search of firewood. Shortly after James and the ladies had the campsite arranged, Charles and Gregory returned with arm-loads of sticks and branches. In short order they had a crackling fire going. Adiba and Jamcela had broken out the loafs of bread and wineskins in anticipation of the evening meal.

Sitting around the fire, James and the knights looked at each other, quietly sensing that it was taking more time than necessary to water the horses. Before they had a chance to voice their concern, they heard the sound of laughter as the two men returned to camp soaking wet, each carrying two fish in each hand.

“We were beginning to think that perhaps you had fallen in.” exclaimed Gregory.

“No,” laughed Ganiz, “we found a shallow pool where these fish were trapped and waded in to catch them so that we could bring them back to camp for dinner.”

“Excellent,” exclaimed Charles. “We can cook them over the fire on green branches and supplement our evening meal of bread and wine.”

“Yes, let us handle that while the two of you get close to the fire and dry out,” added Gregory.

Charles and Gregory had both cooked fish over an open fire in the days of their youth. After gutting the eight fish and cleaning them out they left the heads on so that they could run a green branch through the gills and hang them over a slow cooking fire. The smell of cooking fish made all of the campers hungry. It was not that their standard fare of bread and wine was not appreciated, but the same meal every day did become repetitive.

As Jamcela watched the fish slowly cooking over the open fire, she looked up at the canopy of green tree branches arching overhead around the camp site. She could not help but appreciate the joy of such a beautiful location. Camping along the stark, hot and dry desert roads of Outremer was never like this.

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When the fish were a light, golden brown Gregory gave one to each of his fellow travelers, which they enjoyed with their fresh bread and delicious red wine. For a while, no one spoke as they savored their special meal.

Once they were all finished eating, Adiba and Jamcela asked if it would be alright if they went down to the stream to bathe, before it got dark. Gregory looked at Charles and then told the ladies that it should be fine. He added that if there was a problem, they should call out.

As the women walked away toward the stream, Charles got up and added more wood to the low embers of the fire. Gregory broke the silence. Looking across at Abarran and Ganiz, he said,

“Thank you for that delicious addition to our repast. That was excellent!”

Both men nodded but did not respond. There was a long uncomfortable silence. Gregory continued,

“You seem very quiet. Have we done something to offend you in some way? If we have, we are truly sorry” he continued.

No one responded. Finally, James began,

“Abarran and Ganiz are from the Basque country far to the west. They grew up in Dorostia – San Biarritz on the Bay of Biscay. They consider themselves, Basque, but their grandparents were Cathars originally from Beziers, a city only a few miles to the north and west of where we are right now.

Charles and Gregory looked surprised, but did not respond. James continued,

“Are you familiar with Pope Innocent III and his war to eliminate Catharism in southern France?”

“Yes,” said Gregory, “It was over a century before our time, but we did hear about it. We were told that the Pope labeled the Cathars, Gnostic heretics for their refusing to accept the Incarnation of Christ, participation in the Sacraments and their general disdain of the priesthood. We were told he offered the land and holdings of the Cathars to any French noblemen who agreed to fight against them.”

“Were you also told of the Massacre at Beziers?” asked James nervously, “that is where those nobles you mention, the ones

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who called themselves crusaders, tried to kill every man, woman and child. In Beziers, they killed everyone, Cathars and Catholics alike?”

“Yes, we heard that also,” said Gregory, his words coming out in a low whisper, “We were also told that this atrocity played a role in the creation and development of the Dominican Order and the Inquisition.”

Looking over the fire at Abarran and Ganiz, Charles added, “That was indeed a horrible time for so many, but in terms of us there are two things that I would ask you to consider. The Templar Order purposely played no part in that abomination or any other violence against the Cathars. Also, as you might suspect, Brother Charles and I, along with all Templars, have absolutely no respect for the Dominican Order.”

“That is quite understandable,” said James, nodding, “Adelard told me of your recent experiences with the Dominicans.”

“I believe that we understand,” said Ganiz. “Our grand fathers were among the very few able to escape that slaughter and flee to safety among the Basque people.”

“We often heard tales of those events as we were growing up,” added Abaran, “and it instilled in us a healthy dose of skepticism concerning any organizations connected to the Roman Church.”

“This is not the first time that we have heard such sentiments,” sighed Gregory, “On our long journey from Outremer, we encountered a surprising number of good people, who while loving their God, had serious concerns regarding His church.”

“That sentiment seems to be rapidly growing,” said James as if to himself, while looking into the fire.

There are several things that you should be aware off,” offered Gregory looking across the fire at Abarran and Ganiz,

“As Templars and later as slaves, we lived our lives in the midst of peoples of many religions, including some who consider themselves Christians and yet had ideals and beliefs quite different from those of Rome. It is not widely known, but our order had some beliefs that were strikingly similar to Gnosticism. The other thing that you should consider is that we, as much as anyone, understand

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what it is to be betrayed by those you believed in. In many ways, we are fellow travelers.”

“That is good to know,” Abarran declared earnestly.

“And comforting,” added Ganiz, smiling and nodding.

Gregory stood up and added more wood to the fire, just as Adiba and Jamcela returned from the stream. Abarran and Ganiz moved closer to the fire as their clothes continued to dry. The two Basques remained awake, on watch, as their fellow travelers settled in around the fire to sleep.

Chapter 42

November 1341

Toward the boundary of Aragon

The next leg of their journey was the second day of travel between Montpellier and Narbonne. Charles, who was on watch for the last hours before sunrise, made the rounds to wake his fellow travelers. As he suspected, James was already awake. Charles wondered if James was a light sleeper or possibly had not slept at all.

When the group was awake and moving about, Gregory revived the fire so that they could heat water for tea. James announced that they would be heading for Narbonne this day and would arrive after a long day's ride.

"I have a contact in Narbonne that will provide us with a place to rest unnoticed by the local population. I feel that we will be in less danger the further we get from Avignon, but we will still be in the Kingdom of France for several more days. Being cautious and not attracting attention is still our best defense."

While Adiba, Jamcela, Gregory and Charles ate some bread and drank their tea, Abarran and Ganiz saddled the horses and fed them some of the oats that they had brought along to supplement the grass that they would eat along the way. Next, they took the horses to the stream for water and then returned them to the camp ready for the days ride. When the group had loaded their bed rolls

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and provisions, they mounted up and started their ride in the same formation that they had been using for days.

Leading from the front, James scanned the horizon ahead noting what looked like rain clouds. He was also the first to notice a group of travelers coming toward them. Due to their situation, and the possibility of being followed, James had been vigilantly monitoring the road ahead of and behind them. He was surprised that these were the first travelers that they had encountered thus far, but relieved that they were approaching from the west. As the travelers drew closer, James could see that there were two men riding horses, each of them leading two pack animals. Their cargo was wrapped in heavy cloth and securely tied to pack frames.

When the two groups came together James called out a greeting and asked the lead horseman how the road looked ahead. A bearded, older man on the first horse returned the greeting and said, "The road is fine and there are very few travelers on it today. You are the only people we have encountered since leaving Narbonne."

"I see," replied James. "I thought I saw some rain clouds up ahead in your direction. We may be getting wet a little later on today."

"Perhaps," the older man replied smiling. "One never knows, those clouds may very well blow on by without leaving a drop of rain."

The younger man, that resembled his companion, smiled and nodded.

"Well, may you have a safe and pleasant trip." said James as the two groups passed each other and continued on their way.

"You also," shouted the older man over his shoulder.

Charles, who was riding up front with James, turned and asked him,

"Is it unusual not to see many other travelers along this road?"

"It varies," replied James. "Sometimes we see other people every few miles and other times we have the road all to ourselves. I don't think it is anything to be concerned about."

Charles smiled and nodded.

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The rest of the days ride was quiet and uneventful. The group stopped by a small lake near the road, ate some bread and slices of the delicious cheese that Andre had given them. Before they moved on, they took time to water the horses. By the time the sun was dropping toward the western horizon, they were approaching the outskirts of Narbonne.

Turning to Gregory, who was riding next to him and Ganiz, James grinned and said,

“The man we seek here is the parish priest who has long been a supporter of our endeavors. He and I know each other well. There will be no need for you or Charles to go to confession today.”

Gregory laughed and replied, “That is a relief. At my age I do very little sinning and have been forced to dream up transgressions to meet these occasions.”

“No, you are safe today,” James said, smiling.

When they entered the city, Gregory noticed that they were taking a circuitous route on side-streets. He understood that the fewer people that saw them the better their chances of not being reported to any that may be following them. At length they approached the back entrance to a one-story rectory that was situated just outside of a very large structure that appeared to be a cathedral under construction.

James dismounted and handed his reins to Ganiz. He was gone for a few minutes after entering a small wooden door on the side of the building. When he came back out the door, he was accompanied by a tall young, dark-haired man dressed in the long black cassock of a Benedictine Priest.

Addressing the group, he announced, “This is Father Gabriel.”

Before any of them could respond, the young priest announced, “Dismount your horses, tie them to those rails and come indoors quickly.” The travelers looked at each other and then at James. Without uttering a word, they all did as directed.

Once inside the dimly lit room, the priest turned to them and apologetically announced,

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“I am sorry to appear so rude, but getting you off the streets quickly is wise. The fewer people that know you are here, the better. Please excuse my harsh manner.”

“We are not offended and appreciate your concern,” said James, who proceeded to introduce the rest of the group.

“It is an honor to meet all of you,” replied Gabriel, “you should be safe here this evening and may continue your long journey early tomorrow morning. For now, let us find places for you to rest and sleep. I will bring warm food for your evening meal.”

Turning the priest walked to the door and left the building.

“Father Gabriel seems very nervous,” observed Charles.

“More conscientious than nervous,” replied James, “he is a very serious person, but that is good in these circumstances.”

Abarran and Ganiz went outside to remove the saddles, bring them in with the travelers’ possession and then returned to feed and water the horses. They would take turns outside guarding the animals during the night.

After the members of the group had found places to lay out their sleeping mats, Jamcela turned to James and asked,

“What is that tall building next to our room?”

“That is the Narbonne Cathedral,” replied James.

“Is it still under construction?” asked Gregory.

“No, they are no longer working on it. Construction began almost seventy years ago, but they ran into several problems,” explained James.

“Did they have structural issues?” asked Charles.

“No,” replied James, “First they realized that they would need to take down some of the city walls to use as building materials and to make room for the main structure. Just about that time there was a plague in the area and they decided to leave the walls in place to keep people out who might bring the illness into their city. When the plague subsided, the city found itself in economic decline and construction on what was once intended to be one of the tallest cathedrals in France was never completed. Some of the smaller structures such as the choir, the side chapels,

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the sacristy and the courtyard remain intact and are used as Nabonne's primary place of worship."

"Could we go and take a look at those parts?" asked Adiba.

"Let me go look to see if there are any people in the chapels," said James, "it is late in the day and they should be empty."

James walked out through a side door that connected the main cathedral to the rectory. He was only gone for a few minutes before he returned.

"I think it will be safe if we don't stay too long," James reported.

James and the two couples went through the door and walked into one of the side chapels. What was completed during the early construction was actually quite nice. Probably also due to lack of funding, the rooms' decor did not match the opulence seen in other French cathedrals.

When the group walked through the chapel to the steps of the altar, Adiba looked around in awe.

"I have never been in a Christian church before," she said, "Is that platform on the top of the stairs the altar?"

"Yes, it is," said Charles.

"Indeed," added Gregory, "Did you know that in my youth, I was an altar server?"

Charles smiled and rolled his eyes.

"No, I don't remember you telling us that," said Adiba. "Didn't Nicholas say that he was one also?"

"I think he did," added Jamcela. "What exactly is that anyway?"

"The Alter Servers, who in some parishes are referred to as Alter Boys, represent the congregation during Mass and respond in Latin to the priest who conducts the service in Latin," said Gregory.

"Do all Catholics speak Latin?" asked Jamcela.

"No and neither do the Alter Boys," Gregory stated.

"Then how can they respond to the priest?" Jamcela inquired.

"They memorize the responses to the priests' words," Charles added.

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“But they don’t really know what they are saying?” Adiba, wondered aloud.

“I am afraid so,” added Gregory.

“Do they ever learn what the words mean?” asked Jamcela.

“Those of us who later studied Latin came to understand,” said Gregory. “For many, the meaning of the words, when translated into our native language was disappointing. The aura of mystery that surrounded the Mass, illuminated by candle light, scented with incense and expressed in words that we did not understand, seemed much more impressive.”

“I believe that every religion has its share of mysteries,” said James, looking up at the altar, “Perhaps that is part of the attraction? For now, I think we should retire for the evening. We have a two-day ride ahead of us to reach the next town, Perpignan and four or five more days in the saddle to reach Barcelona.”

They all nodded in agreement and turned to return to the rectory.

The following day, the travelers and their companions mounted their horses and left in the early morning darkness. The next leg of the journey from Narbonne to Perpignan, was a two-day ride with another night spent sleeping under the stars. On this road they also encountered very little traffic with three other groups meeting them while traveling north and one small group ahead of them traveling slowly south. They passed this group and hurried on.

As in Narbonne, their night’s lodging was in a church rectory, this time as guests of the pastor of the Cathedral Saint-Jean Baptiste in Parpignan. The city is located on the plain of Roussillon at the foot of the Pyrenees Mountains. This cathedral was also still under construction, having been started seventeen years before.

Again, they had contact only with the pastor and departed in darkness heading south-west toward the Coll de Banyuls, a mountain pass separating the Kingdom of France from the Kingdom of Aragon. While they were riding up the grade toward the summit, Charles looked to James, smiled and said,

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“I am amazed at the number of people associated with Adelard Lavigne that are willing, even anxious to help us. Is there anyone in this part of the world that he does not know?”

“I don’t think so,” replied James laughing.”

That evening the group made camp at the summit, one thousand, one hundred and seventy-one feet above the sea to their east. It was a clear evening and it seemed as if they could see forever. The quarter moon made the stars seem close and bright. When they finished their simple meal of bread and wine and were sitting around a small fire that Ganiz had started, James look at each of his fellow travelers and said almost reverently,

“We are now at the boundary. Tomorrow as we descend, we will be in the Kingdom of Aragon.”

Chapter 43

November 1341

Barcelona, Kingdom of Aragon

The trek down the southern side of the Coll de Banyuls was done in silence. Each of the riders, including James and the Basques were subtly looking back over their shoulders, relieved to see no one following them. Adiba and Jamcela took comfort in knowing that they were out of the Bishop of Avignon's jurisdiction. The men all knew that it could still mean a fight.

Ahead of them was a full-day's ride to Figures, a two-day journey to Girona a one-day ride to Llalet de Man and the final two-day ride to Barcelona. More than once along the way, Charles and Gregory had both come to realize that this was the only possible way that they could have ever hoped to reach the safety of Tomar. Any other route would have unquestionably been an enormous ordeal, even for much younger travelers. At their age it would have been impossible, especially on foot.

The morning the travelers arrived at the Port of Barcelona, James told the knights and their ladies that he would go ahead to make contact with the captain of the ship that would take them to Lisbon and then provide them with transportation to the headquarters of the Order of Christ in Tomar. James instructed

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Abarran and Ganiz to remain with the knights telling them that he would return as soon as possible.

Several hours after the ringing of the noon bells in the church tower, the knights and their party began to wonder if James had been delayed or possibly encountered difficulties. Abarran offered to go to search for James, but before he could mount his horse to leave, James rode up to the group. He was smiling.

"I have wonderful news," he said. "The cargo vessel that I was expecting to meet has been delayed, but I found an even better ship to serve our purposes!"

"What did you find?" asked Gregory.

"There is a new type of vessel in the harbor that was built in the shipyards of Sao Martinho do Porto. It is here on its maiden voyage, manned by a crew that I believe you will be delighted to meet!"

"I am sure that we do not understand!" said Charles.

"That is alright!" said James. "Mount up and I will take you to where your questions will be answered!"

As the group rode through the narrow streets, they saw a city alive with activity. Many of the smaller cities that they had passed through seemed slower, some even sleepy. In Barcelona it appeared that everyone was in a hurry. People walked more quickly, horse and ox-drawn wagons rumbled over the cobblestone streets. Pedestrians, careful to stay out of their way. And the noise. In Barcelona it seemed that everyone was shouting. Some in anger, many in laughter, all in a variety of languages.

When they rounded a final corner, they were greeted by a panoramic view of the harbor and waterfront. The salty sea breeze providing welcome relief from the inland heat. It was bustling. Every available space along the docks had a ship secured to it with heavy rope lines. Most of the vessels were merchant ships embroiled in a flurry of activity and noise. Shouts, laughter and occasional curses. Some crews unloaded cargo. Others loaded materials that would be taken to faraway ports.

Amongst the large and familiar merchantman galleys sat a smaller ship of a design that none of them had ever before seen. It was less than half as long as the cargo vessels and had a raised bow

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and a noticeably narrower beam. Unlike the merchant galleys, the gunnels of this craft had no ports for oars. It rode low in the water and carried two masts. Also, the sails were different. Galleys carried square sails, mounted on yardarms that were perpendicular to the centerline of the ship. They could be used only in a following wind. This new craft carried triangle-shaped sails that were attached to spars that extended fore-and-aft and were mounted near the top of each mast. The forward tip of the spar on the front mast came close to touching the raised bow of the boat. It extended upward at a sharp angle toward the stern, where it ended above the rear mast. The aft mast was located in the center of a large, elevated deck that took up the aft third of the ship's length. This second mast was shorter than the main and also had a spar that ran from a low point, just short of the main mast to a top end, high above the stern of the boat. Both masts were supported by four rigging lines that ran from a point just short of the top of the masts, down to the deck rails on either side. Above the spar connection point on the front mast sat a flat platform with a short railing to accommodate a sailor on watch. This new craft also sported a rudder that was mounted in the center of the stern instead of the traditional steering oar used by galley helmsmen. While noticeably smaller than the other ships in the harbor, this craft seemed to exude speed and attitude. Its high bow and sleek hull seemed to shout out 'catch me if you can.'

When the travelers reached the place on the dock where the gang-plank rested, they dismounted. James instructed Abarran to hold the reins for the seven horses while he and Ganiz helped Charles, Gregory, Adiba and Jamcela unload their few possessions and place them dockside near the base of the ramp. As the group turned to face the ship, they noticed four armed men who had suddenly stationed themselves across the base of the gangplank. All four held swords in their hands. Without thinking Charles and Gregory drew their broad swords. James and Ganiz did the same.

"That is far enough," said the tallest of the armed men.

"You don't mean to rob us in broad daylight, do you?" asked Gregory.

"No, we are here by the authority of the bishop of Avignon, with orders to return you to his jurisdiction for questioning,"

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“Here in Barcelona, you are far from your jurisdiction,” shouted James. “You have no authority here.”

“Our swords give us all the authority that we need,” snarled the apparent leader.

“And yet it may not be enough,” shouted Gregory holding his gleaming sword with both hands.

“Must I remind you that interfering with or striking a priest or agent of the church is a mortal sin? If you were to die with that sin on your soul, you will go straight to hell.” admonished the leader.

Gregory, stepping forward “If I have anything to say about it, you will arrive there first and will be able to save me a good seat.”

“So, you challenge my authority and that of the bishop?” shouted the leader.

“Yes, and so do I,” said the booming voice of a man standing behind them on the ship’s deck.

“I am Brother Kristopher, Captain of the Spiritus Sanctus.”

Turning to look over his shoulder the leader saw a tall man of stout proportions standing at the deck rail. He had short-cropped hair, that was starting to grey and a long grey beard. His bright eyes and broad white smile gave him a look of disarming charm. The intensity of his voice made it evident that there was a limit to that charm.

Close behind him were twenty men. They also had short-cut hair and long beards. What most impressed all seeing them was their dress. Like the captain, each of them wore a long white surcoat with a bright red cross on the front. Sixteen of them held gleaming silver broadswords exactly like the ones that Charles and Gregory had received from Adelard Lavigne. The other four held cross-bows; one aimed at each of the bishop’s men.

For what seemed like a long time, no one spoke. The silence was broken as the man at the rail continued.

“Listen carefully, for I am not a man prone to repeating himself. You and your men will slowly place your swords on the dock in front of you and step off to the side. You will stand there and not move. If you do not do exactly as I have ordered, the next

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sound you will hear will be your heads bouncing on the dock next to your feet!”

The leader and his companions looked at the captain and then the twenty, knights standing behind him. Without discussion or hesitation, they slowly placed their swords on the dock and stepped to the side of the ramp. Three knights walked down the gangplank. One of them collected the swords. The other two tied each of the men’s hands together and then attached them to one long lead rope.

The knight who held the swords took James off to the side and spoke to him where their conversation could not be overheard. James nodded his head, obviously understanding what he had been told. As he returned to the base of the gangplank the knight turned to Charles, Gregory, Adiba and Jamcela.

“Follow me please,” he said walking up the ramp. As they started to walk, carrying their bundled possessions, the knights and their ladies heard twenty-one men shout in unison,

“Beau Sant, welcome home our brothers!” Gregory and Charles turned to look at each other. They felt amazed, shocked and delighted all at the same time. Once aboard, both of them were embraced by each of the sailors and the captain, who then turned, smiled and nodded to their wives. Coming up the ramp after the knights, James announced,

“This, Captain Kristopher, is Brother Charles and Brother Gregory the only Templar survivors of the fall of Acre. These ladies are their wives, Adiba and Jamcila.”

“It is truly a pleasure for all of us to meet you,” said the captain.

“Our ship and my crew are at your service. I am sorry for this distraction and I assure you that by the end of this day, those men will never be able to trouble you again.”

Turning to James he added,

“We are most grateful to you and your men and your master, Adelard Lavigne, for helping to bring our long-lost brothers home safely.”

“It is our honor,” said James, nodding to the knights and turning to acknowledge Abarran who continued to hold the reins of

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the horses and Ganiz, who held his sword to the throat of the leader of the bishop's men.

"We will take care of one additional chore and then begin our return to Nimes this afternoon. There we will report that all is well and that our guests are on their way to Tomar. May your voyage be swift and safe!"

"You need not worry about that!" Captain Kristopher responded, smiling

"I was named after the patron saint of travelers. He will be watching over us the whole way!"

The crew standing behind him smiled. James turned and walked down the ramp to join his companions. The three of them waved good-bye and rode off leading four, riderless horses and four securely bound men on foot.

On the dock, the crowd that had gathered to watch the commotion, turned back to their work seeing that the entertainment was over.

Turning to his crew, Captain Kristopher shouted,

"Stow the ramp and prepare to make sail." As the crew jumped to their assignments, Kristopher turned to his passengers.

"My crewmen will show you to the aft quarterdeck. There, you will be out of the flurry of activity and have a much better view of the scenery. I want to take advantage of this offshore breeze. In a busy harbor it is more difficult to get out to sea in a ship without oars. Once we are in open waters the advantages of this type of ship will be obvious. If you will excuse me, I have matters to supervise." Smiling, the captain turned and started to walk toward the bow. Hesitating for a moment, he looked to the crewman standing next to the knights and said,

"Get our brothers new surcoats to replace those rags that they are wearing." Winking at Charles and Gregory he smiled and added,

"These two have been out of uniform for long enough!"

Charles, Gregory, Adiba and Jamcela followed the seaman who did not speak but gestured, directing them toward one of the two staircases that led to the upper deck. Once on the quarterdeck they saw the ships wheel near the front railing and the aft mast

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halfway back, coming up through the center of the deck. Beyond the stern railing, there was a davit used to lower the ships small boat. In the starboard, aft corner of the quarterdeck was a tall piece of equipment covered by a large tarp, secured with ropes.

There were long benches near the railing at either side of the ship. Charles, Gregory, Adiba and Jamcela walked over to a bench and sat down. The sailor that was acting as their guide, excused himself and indicated that he would return shortly. Once he had left, Jamcela turned to her companions and whispered,

“These men are all tall and stout like you are!”

“You don’t have to whisper,” said Gregory, smiling.

“They all know that they are tall!”

“You should not laugh at me!” said Jamcela. “That is mean!”

“I am sure that he did not intend to hurt your feelings,” said Charles, “The order has always selected large men to be warriors and feeds them well to keep up their strength.”

“In addition to training and fighting there was always enough hard labor to keep us fit.” added Gregory. “This is an interesting ship, is it not?”

“Yes, I am anxious to see how they handle it,” said Charles.

As they watched, as the crew cast off the bow and stern lines and using poles pushed the bow away from the wharf. As this was being done, other crewmen hoisted the front lateen sail with its large red cross in the center. It immediately caught the breeze and slowly began to move the ship toward the harbor entrance and open waters. Once they were well clear of the harbor, the helmsman turned the bow to starboard, the ship faced south and Captain Kristopher gave the order “make sail”. The crew set the fore-sail as well as the aft lateen rig, which also featured a large red-cross on its center. With the lines secured and the sails filled, the ship listed slightly to port and moved out more quickly than any other ship that the knights had ever been aboard. While the passengers were marveling at the speed, the seaman returned to the aft deck with two surcoats. Without hesitation Charles and Gregory removed their tattered cotton tunics and donned the once familiar Templar garb.

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“You both look so handsome!” said Adiba. Charles and Gregory looked at each other and then their wives and smiled.

“She is correct!” the captain said as he came up behind them on the quarterdeck.

“You both look much better.” Turning to Adiba and Jamcela he added,

“I have sent a man below decks to look for some sergeant’s surcoats that will be much warmer than what you are wearing. As you can probably imagine our selection of women’s clothing is quite limited.” Clearing his throat, Captain Kristopher added, “A beautiful day to be at sea, is it not?”

“Indeed, it is!” said Charles.

“We are impressed by the speed of your ship, sailing into the wind, in this mild breeze,” exclaimed Gregory.

“Yes,” said Captain Christopher smiling, “This is a Caravel christened the Spiritus Sanctus. It is a new design that makes sailing a traditional galley seem like going to sea in a wash tub! Our lateen rigging allows us to sail into the wind and eliminates the need for oars and all of the seamen required to man them. The shallow-draft hull allows us to navigate shallow waters where a galley could never venture.”

“The design reminds me of the smaller boats used by Arab fishermen in the sea and along the Nile in Egypt,” said Gregory. “I believe that I heard them referred to as crab-claw sails.”

“Yes,” said Captain Kristopher. “There are several variations of this design used in many parts of the world. It is yet another innovation that we have borrowed from our long-time Arab adversaries.”

Charles nodded his head and sighed.

“I sometimes wonder if the Franks and the Arabs had spent as much time, sharing good ideas they spent trying to kill each other, how much better our world would be.”

“I fear we might never know the answer to that question,” said Gregory.

“For now, my brothers, our mission is to get all of you safely to Tomar,” said Kristopher. “We will be sailing south to Valencia and then on to the port of Cartagena. We will sail several miles off

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shore, but will always remain in sight of land. From Cartagena we will take a wider birth around the coast of the Emirate of Granada, which is the last Arab stronghold on the Iberian Peninsula.”

“How long have Arabs lived in this land?” Adiba asked.

The group turned to look at her.

“Your Latin is excellent!” said Kristopher, smiling. “Where did you learn the language?”

“At home,” she answered, smiling and looking at Gregory. “I had most excellent teachers.”

“Indeed, you must have,” Kristopher responded.

“To answer your question, the Arabs, or Moors, as they are called here, have been in Iberia for over six centuries. After the fall of Rome, the Visigoths took over the peninsula and declared this land, they called ‘Hispania’, officially Catholic. It remained that way until the year of our Lord seven hundred-eleven, when Jebel al-Tariq crossed at Gibraltar and defeated the Visigoths. Christian kings have been fighting for centuries to reclaim the land for Christendom and the Emirate of Granada is the last Moorish holdout.”

“Does sailing through their waters present a danger?” asked Gregory.

“Not usually,” answered Kristopher. “Occasionally, a ship of Moorish pirates will come out from the coast seeking opportunity, but once they get close enough to see the red cross on our sails, they usually change their minds.”

“And if they don’t?” asked Gregory.

“If they don’t steer clear of the Spiritus Sanctus” said Christopher “they are greeted by twenty of God’s warriors and the little surprise that we have waiting under the tarp behind us.”

“We noticed that,” said Jamcela, “what is that under the tarp?”

“That is a smaller version of the same catapults that our armies used to assault Arab fortresses in Outremer,” said Kristopher.

“I thought perhaps it was,” said Gregory.

“Some of the galleys in the fleet that brought us to the Levant, so many years ago, carried catapults used to throw Greek

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fire onto enemy ships. There was no occasion to use them on our voyage, but they seemed like an impressive weapon.”

“Indeed, they can be,” said Christopher. “We have yet to use ours, but when we do I plan to throw large stones. Dealing with Greek Fire on a wooden ship is something that I would prefer to avoid.”

“So where do we sail after passing the emirate territory?” asked Charles.

“Once we pass the Costa del Sol and sail through the Pillars of Hercules, we will enter the great ocean and sail north, to the Port of Lisbon. From here you will be taken to the Convento do Cristo.”

“When we arrive in Tomar, will we have an opportunity to meet with the Grand Master of the Order?” asked Charles.

“Yes, of course,” said Kristopher. “I am certain that our Grand Master, Alfonso IV, would be most anxious to greet you. We will have ample opportunities to talk and discuss your meeting, but now I must attend to my other duties.”

Smiling, Kristopher turned and started to walk toward the stairs leading to the main deck. Before reaching the railing, he turned and said,

“Oh, I almost forgot. Beneath this aft-deck, there are two very small cabins. I have had them arranged for you and your wives. If there is anything you need, just let me know.”

As he turned to continue his departure, Charles said, “No, Captain, we cannot ask you to give up your quarters...”

Before he could continue, Captain Kristopher raised his hand with his palm facing them and said,

“I will not hear of it. You are my honored guests! It will be no inconvenience for me. Like many captains, I never sleep! Just ask my crew!”

Without another word and with a smile on his face, he descended the stairs to the main deck.

Turning to face her companions, Jamcela said, “He is so kind!”

Gregory nodded his head and said, “He is our brother!”

Chapter 44

November 1341

Sailing the Mediterranean Sea South of Iberian Peninsula

The first thing about the voyage that caught the attention of both Charles and Gregory was the speed of the Spiritus Sanctus. Even in a slight breeze the caravel seemed to fly before the wind. It not only moved down-wind at two, possibly three times the speed of the fastest galley, it could sail at an impressive pace tacking into prevailing winds. Once the sails were trimmed and the ship was securely underway, Captain Christopher came up to Charles and Gregory who were standing by the deck railing.

“We are well underway! If this wind holds, we will be in Tomar in record time.”

“I can’t believe how fast this ship is,” said Charles.

“Yes, the caravel is a big improvement over the ships that we were used to.”

“Where will we be stopping along the way?” asked Gregory.

“Unless there is some sort of emergency, we may not be stopping at all. From Barcelona we will sail past Valencia, Alicante, Cartagena, Almeria, Malaga, and Tarifa. At Costa de Luz, we will pass through the Cape of Gibraltar and head north, toward Lisbon.”

“How can we stay at sea for so long when other ships have to make frequent stops at ports all along the way?” asked Gregory.

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“It’s all a matter of design,” said Kristopher. “One of the main reasons for the development of the caravel was to build a ship capable of sailing in all conditions and be able to travel long distances without stopping to resupply. The ability to carry adequate food and wine for an extended voyage is critical for a vessel being used to investigate new regions and passages to unknown lands. Our hope is to have a ship that will enable us to explore the lands across the ocean to the west and hopefully discover a route to the eastern spice islands by sailing around the great continent to our south.”

“How has it been working out so far?” asked Charles.

“It’s been very encouraging. As you may have noticed, we sail much farther off from shore than we would in a galley and are able to make long tacks into head winds. The distance also makes us less attractive targets for pirates. By the time a pirate galley sees us and rows miles off shore, we are long gone. Even in a following breeze, there is not an empty galley, under full sail, that can match the speed of a caravel.”

“I imagine that you would want to give the Kingdom of Granada a wide berth in any ship.” said Gregory.

“Yes, Granada is the last of the Moorish kingdoms on the peninsula, and we still try to avoid coming too close to their holdings. We are certain that we would not be welcome visitors in any of their ports,” Kristopher said laughing.

“I can’t help wondering what you would do if you were becalmed and attacked by a galley of Moors or pirates,” asked Charles. “You would have no way of escaping at that point.”

“Yes, we considered that and carry the catapult you saw on the stern deck for exactly that reason.”

“Has that proved effective?” asked Gregory.

“To date we have never had an opportunity to test it in battle, but we did have a chance to try it out on an old galley that was scheduled for dismantling. The large rocks, that we sent it from a distance, tore out the rigging, went straight through the upper decking and cracked the hull beams below decks. Even one well-placed stone can do a surprising amount of damage to a wooden ship.”

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As Gregory and Charles were talking with the captain on the aft deck, Adiba and Jamcela walked toward the bow on the main deck where they saw Brother Giovanni, who served as the ships' doctor, sitting with another knight. Brother Giovanni was a tall man with blue eyes and sandy blond hair. He had a calm, almost serene disposition as he examined the other man's hand. It was swollen and red. The younger knight, Brother Luke, was clearly in pain and had a look of worry and concern.

"That does not look good," said Jamcela.

Looking up, Brother Giovanni turned to the women and said, "I agree, this small cut on Brother Luke's hand has become infected."

"Are you going to lance the swelling to let it drain?" Adiba asked.

"Yes, that is exactly what I was considering."

"Will you soak the hand in hot salted water before you make the incision?"

"Yes, I planned to do that also," said Brother Giovanni smiling up at them. "You are most interesting ladies. You not only speak Arabic, Latin and French fluently, you apparently have had some medical training."

"Oh, no," said Jamcela, looking embarrassed. "We were raised in a sultan's harem. Our mother was one of the sultan's many wives. Only eunuchs were allowed in the harem compound and none of them were doctors, so we had to learn medical skills to take care of as many of our needs as best we could."

"I see," said Brother Giovanni. "And what would you recommend I do after soaking the hand and lancing the infection?"

"Pour wine in the incision and then rub in some honey," suggested Adiba.

"Very good!" said Giovanni, smiling, "I will pour some unwatered wine in the incision, apply the honey, as you suggest and wrap the wound with clean strips of cloth."

Turning to look at his patient, he said, "Relax Brother Luke, you are in good hands. The three of us will have you back in action

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in short order.” Brother Luke smiled and nodded at the two women who smiled, turned and continued their walk on deck.

Later that day after treating Brother Luke’s injury, Brother Giovanni came up to Charles and Gregory who were standing by the port railing.

“Good afternoon, brothers! I had a chance to visit with your wives while working on Brother Luke’s swollen hand.”

“How did that work out?” asked Gregory.

“Very well! Your wives had some suggestions for me.”

“We hope you were not offended,” said Charles.

“No, not at all. I am most impressed with their knowledge of medicine. Actually, I am very impressed with many of their qualities. They not only knew how to best treat the brother’s swollen hand, they were also able to share their knowledge in Arabic, Latin or French. It is truly rare to meet such well-educated women.”

“Yes, during their years with us they quickly picked up Latin and French by listening to us. In turn, they helped us to understand and appreciate the culture and traditions of the Levant in ways that we would have never experienced, had we not met them,” said Charles.

“Yes,” said Gregory, smiling “I fear that they turned us into Poulains.”

“Is that not a disparaging term for Franks that were either born in Outremer or stayed to live there after taking the cross?” asked Giovanni.

“Yes, it is used that way,” replied Gregory, “especially among the English and French, however among the Levant’s long-term residents it is seen as a positive distinction,” said Gregory.

“Many of the Franks who came to Outremer, thought of those whom had been born there or remained there, as questionable Christians, possibly not worthy of defending the Holy City of Jerusalem,” added Charles.

“What led them to that observation?” asked Giovanni.

“They were horrified that these people had adopted some of the ways of the local Saracens; dressing like them, enjoying their

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traditional foods and consulting Arab doctors. New arrivals from the homelands regularly referred to the native peoples of the Levant as “the Devil’s spawn.”

Looking at Brother Giovanni, who seemed rather surprised, Gregory continued, “Poulains were mocked as men who had been seduced by the sinful habits of the locals, like regular bathing. To many, that made them seem weak and effeminate.”

“Personally, I could never understand how not bathing and smelling like the south end of a north-bound horse could be thought of as either manly or pious,” added Charles. “I remember a bishop chastising a knight who suggested that our army, made up of men wearing heavy padding and chain mail, sitting on horseback in scorching heat, should try to attack their enemy down-wind so that our foul odor would help to overcome our enemies. I found his comment to be quite amusing. The bishop did not!”

“Poulains were also criticized for going to Arab doctors even though they were widely considered to be more knowledgeable than their Frankish counterparts,” said Gregory.

“Yes,” said Giovanni, “most of us who practice medicine are, sometimes grudgingly, forced to agree. I do believe however, that you will find that many of the beliefs and attitudes that were prevalent in your youth, have shifted during your long absence.”

As he looked out to sea, Charles thought to himself, of the seemingly endless number of things that had changed during the years that they had been gone. Their order, their church perhaps even their god seemed different from what he remembered believing so many years ago. Some things seemed better, some concerning, but definitely several were in a process of evolving. Perhaps, he thought it could be simply the different perspective one would expect being fifty years older. But then again it seemed that there were many who had questions, even doubts, like the Lavigne’s, Brother Paul and the priests who had helped them along the way from Nimes to Barcelona. Could it be that even greater changes were in the wind?

Chapter 45

November 1341

Aboard the Caravel Spiritus Sanctus

Early morning on a clear, crisp day found the Spiritus Sanctus tacking to starboard into a moderate breeze when the watch, high in the mast, shouted out, “Ship dead ahead.”

“Heading?” came the question from Captain Kristopher.

“Looks dead in the water,” came the answer from the lookout.

“Can you make her out?” came the reply.

“Looks to be a merchant galley, Captain, oars out, no sails set.

“Men to arms,” Kristopher shouted. “Swords and crossbows, full armor. Women to the aft cabins.”

The men hurried to help each other don their padded, gambeson undercoats and chainmail. Armor was not typically worn at sea unless needed.

“Ready the catapult, captain?” came the question from the crewman on the aft deck.

“No, not yet,” came the reply. “Reef the sails and come up on their port side within range. Keep a sharp eye out.”

As the Spiritus Sanctus slowly approached the galley, the light wind went calm with only enough breeze to cause a slight ripple on the otherwise still water. Charles and Gregory returned

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from escorting Adiba and Jamcela to the safety of the aft cabin. They helped each other make the final adjustments to their chainmail and surcoats, which never seemed to go on easily without assistance. They then moved to stand at the rail with the other knights and sergeants.

When the Spiritus Sanctus came around to the port side, the crew could see that several of the galley's oars were broken and there appeared to be a section of crushed planking a mid-ship.

The watch shouted out, "Captain, there are no sails in the rigging. They have been cut free and removed ." Captain Kristopher called out to the ship asking if there was anyone on board. There was no response.

"Lower the long boat," called Kristopher. "Four men row, four men at arms. Look lively and stay alert and watch your step lads. You won't float any better than Barbarossa did in full armor," he warned as the small boat was lowered to the water and the eight men climbed down to get on board.

Charles and Gregory walked up to stand next to Captain Kristopher.

"On our way to Outremer, we heard that same warning about Fredrick Barbarossa and how he fell off his horse and drowned in the Saleph river wearing full armor," said Charles smiling.

"Yes, said Kristopher, nodding his head, "but it is a warning worth repeating."

"Could this be a trap?" asked Gregory.

"Wouldn't be the first time," answered the captain, his eyes continuing to scan the deck of the galley. "If it is a trap, they are very good at staying out of sight."

The men with crossbows, standing on the fore and aft decks of the Spiritus Sanctus, kept watch along with the man high in the rigging. The long boat slowly approached the galley, rowing all the way around the ship before pulling up near the stern behind the last oar. Two men stayed with the launch while the other six climbed over the galley's railing and proceeded to search the ship, looking into the cabins on the main deck and going down the staircase into

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the hold. Coming back out from below decks, they walked to the rail and shouted to their captain.

“Two bloated bodies floating, face down, in the water below deck. Look to be dead for a couple of days. Ships taking on water where the planks are cracked. It’s a slow leak so it could stay afloat for another day or two. Looks like someone set a fire in the cargo hold. It’s still smoldering, but the rising water level has almost put it out. No sign of any cargo left or any of the sails. There’s part of a broken scimitar blade stuck in the railing on the starboard side. Large pools of blood and smears where something was dragged across deck to the rail. There’s another pool of blood on the near aft side with four fingers laying in it.”

“Have you checked the captain’s cabin?” shouted Kristopher. “We have,” came the response.

“Captain’s cabin is empty, no maps, charts or logs, only torn rags and two smashed wooden barrels that smell of wine.”

“Alright, lads, row on back,” Christopher shouted. “There’s nothing more we can do.”

“Pirates, probably Moors,” said Kristopher turning to Charles and Gregory. “Took the cargo and probably fed the crew to the fishes. They must have rammed the ship when boarding her, breaking those oars and cracking the side planking. If the galley was still sound, they would have taken it to use or sell.”

“I suspected that things did not go well with that crew,” said Gregory. “I can detect the sickening, sweet smell of sunbaked blood all the way over here.”

“So can I,” said Kristopher, “but we had to check for survivors.”

“Piracy seems to be a problem everywhere in the *Mediterranean*,” said Charles.

“It’s endless,” said Kristopher smiling. “No matter how many of them we kill, there always seems to be a limitless supply of replacements. I had actually hoped to have an opportunity to try out our catapult on some of them, but that will have to wait for another day. If you will excuse me, I have a few things to check before we get back underway.”

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As he started to walk away, Kristopher turned back and said, "Oh, also don't forget to tell your wives that it is safe to come back out on deck.

"We will," said Gregory turning to walk back toward the cabin under the aft deck.

"Are we safe?" Adiba asked as they met Gregory at the cabin door.

"Yes, no pirates this time. Actually no one at all, this time. The ship was deserted, no captain, no crew and no cargo."

"Only ghosts?" said Jamcela.

"Yes," said Gregory, "Only unholy ghosts."

"How could that be?" asked Adiba. What happened to all the people onboard?"

"There's no way of knowing for sure," said Charles. "It was most likely pirates. Events like this are not common, but, as you know, they do happen. I have heard tales of ships being found with everything intact; the cargo, the equipment still in place and not a soul onboard."

"Yet another mystery of the sea," said Gregory smiling.

As they talked, they could see that the crew of the launch had returned to the Spiritus Sanctus, where they hoisted the boat back onto its cradle on the aft deck and went below to remove their armor. Gregory and Charles did the same. Out at sea, with a good lookout in the rigging, there was sufficient time to redon battle armor and all would agree that life aboard ship was far more comfortable without it.

Seemingly on cue, the breeze picked up and the sails popped as they filled with air. The light caravel seemed to jump forward like a destrier anxious to charge.

Chapter 46

November 1341

Through the Pillars of Hercules

During the following days the waters were calm, the winds steady. The seas devoid of menacing pirates. As they sailed West, there were opportunities for Charles and Gregory to visit with the crew members. The sailors had, what seemed like, a never-ending series of questions about the original Templar Order and their adventures in the Holy Land. Captain Kristopher spoke often with Charles, Gregory, Adiba and Jamcela, but the crew, early in the voyage seemed to purposely avoid talking with the ladies, unless they were directly asked a question. In that case they were pleasant and polite but clearly nervous, even uncomfortable. Adiba and Jamcela found their behavior confusing. Charles and Gregory found it amusing. They explained to their wives that for many of the Order's crewmen the last women that they had engaged in conversation were their sisters or mothers.

As time went on, the crew became more comfortable around the women. Several crewmen mentioned how impressed they were with the ladies' language skills. Others reported enjoying hearing the ladies describe their childhood in Outremer. When Adiba mentioned to Gregory, the profound change of behavior that she observed among the crewmen, Gregory replied that the men undoubtedly were much more relaxed around them once they

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realized that the women did not bite. This led Adiba to silently wonder why she even bothered to ask such questions to her husband.

At first light one morning, during the second week of sailing, Captain Kristopher came up to his guests, who were standing at the aft rail watching the first slivers of light from the rising sun.

“Are you ready to experience the Pillars of Hercules?” he said in his booming voice. Turning to look at him, Adiba asked,

“Are there monsters there like in the Straits of Messina?”

“There are occasionally some strong currents, but no whirlpools.” said Christopher with a smile.

“As to monsters, the ancients said that the land came together at this point to keep the sea monsters, of the great ocean, from entering our sea.”

“Have you ever seen any monsters?” asked Jamcela.

“No, but I may have just been fortunate!” he said winking at Charles and Gregory.

“In ancient times, sailors were very hesitant to venture into the open ocean in their cumbersome galleys. They described these straits as *Non plus ultra*, meaning ‘nothing further beyond’. The more superstitious among them feared that the edge of the world lay close at hand just beyond the straits.”

Looking at Adiba and Jamcela, he added,

“As we pass through the straits and turn starboard to sail north, keep a weather eye out on the port side for any sign of the edge of the world. If you spot it, be sure to let me know!”

Adiba and Jamcela just smiled and shook their heads. By this time, they knew that the captain, like their husbands, would never grow tired of teasing them.

During the voyage beyond the straits, to the Port of Lisbon, Captain Kristopher had an opportunity to talk with Charles and Gregory about the Order of Christ and King Afonso IV of Portugal who served as its Grand Master. Kristopher told them that Afonso was the seventh King of Portugal and the only legitimate son of his father King Denis and his mother, Elizabeth of Aragon.

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“King Denis is the man responsible for saving our order, allowing us to carry on the good works that have always been our purpose.” said Kristopher.

“That is fortunate,” said Charles, “The priest that found us in the Levant told us of the treachery of the French king and how he convinced Pope Clement V to order all of the Christian rulers to seize the assets of our order and arrest all of its members.”

“We were also told of Templars finding safety in the country of Portugal,” added Gregory, “but we were never told how that came to pass.”

“Strange as it may sound, it was rather simple,” said Kristopher. “King Denis, King Afonso’s father, refused to obey the pope’s order. Instead of handing all of the Templar’s assets over the church, he kept them and used his royal power to protect the order. He reshaped it so that it could survive. With the protection of the King of Portugal and a slightly different red cross on our surcoats, sails and shields, we became the Order of Christ!”

“What an extraordinary act of kindness,” said Gregory.

“Yes, but a very wise act of kindness,” said Kristopher. “The Templar Order had a long and significant history in the Kingdom of Portugal. A full century and a half before this, the Templars had come to the aide of the first kings of Portugal by helping them to wrest control of the cities of Lisbon and Santarem from the Muslims. This allowed them to forge a new Christian nation. King Denis, like all of the kings of Portugal, was grateful to the order and eventually was able to convince Pope Clément’s successor, Pope John XXII, to recognize the new order, arguing that his kingdom still faced a significant threat from the Moslem armies to the south. After the Pope agreed to this request, the Order of Christ was moved to the headquarters that the Templars had built and used, the Castle at Tomar. To this day Afonso works closely with our order and serves as our Grand Master!”

“We know that as King and Grand Master, Afonso must be very busy, but we hope to be able to meet him some day,” said Charles.

“I am sure that you will have that opportunity!” said the captain.

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The rest of the voyage was uneventful. The sea remained calm, the winds favorable and no sea monsters were sighted. Sailing north, they passed the peninsula known as Caba Espichel and turned eastward into the narrow opening at Belem. This led to the large bay at the estuary of the Tejo River. The city of Lisbon is located on the north shore of the bay.

There the Spiritus Sanctus was docked at Terreiro do Paco, known as the gateway to Lisbon. Upon their arrival, the travelers were able to see the impressive shipyards where three Caravels, similar to the Spiritos Sanctos, were sitting in dry docks in various stages of completion.

As they left the ship at the port, Charles and Gregory thanked Captain Kristopher and his crew for all that they had done.

"There are no words that can adequately express our gratitude," said Charles.

"We will be eternally in your debt," added Gregory.

"It was our pleasure," responded the smiling captain. From the twenty men standing behind him on the deck came the loud response, as if in one voice,

"Dais Volt". The travelers all smiled and nodded acknowledging the complement.

Captain Kristopher continued,

"From here you will be taken to the fortress that you see on the hill to our north, the Castelo De Sao Jorge. There you will be able to rest and regain your land legs. I will make arrangements for a smaller skiff to take you on a river voyage to The Convento do Cristo. I look forward to seeing all of you the next time I am in Tomar.

Chapter 47

December 1341

Castle of St. George, Lisbon

Waiting on the road that ran along the Lisbon waterfront was a mounted knight wearing the traditional white surcoat with the red cross on the chest. The sergeant that was with him wore a black surcoat with a red cross. They led four saddled horses. The knight who introduced himself as brother Anthony, did all of the talking. His companion remained silent. Anthony announced that they were there to escort the travelers on their ride through the narrow winding streets of Lisbon up the hill to the Castle of St. George, known locally as the Castelo de Sao Jorge. After weeks at sea, Charles, Gregory, Adiba and Jamcela had little time to get over their unsteady sea legs, but the excitement of nearing their destination overshadowed any thoughts of discomfort.

Anthony explained that the fortress on the hilltop was at one time the location of settlements dating back to the seventh century B. C. He explained that this castle, like the fortress in Sintra, fifteen miles northwest of Lisbon, had been built by the Moors, during the eleventh century. Both were defensive positions that enabled the Moors to maintain their holdings in this part of the Peninsula. He went on to say that both the Castle of Saint George and the fortress at Sintra, known as the Moorish Castle, were captured one hundred

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and ninety-four years ago by Christian forces under the leadership of Alfonso Henriques, Portugal's first king,

Charles, Gregory, Adiba and Jamcela enjoyed their guide's horseback history tour. As they approached the outer ramparts, Jamcela asked Brother Anthony about the construction of the castle walls.

"These walls are different from many of the others that we have seen on our travels."

"What do you mean?" responded Anthony.

"These walls are made of much smaller stones and a great deal of mortar," she added. "The walls are also not strait up and down. The bottom of the walls are further out than the tops."

"You are very observant," said Anthony. "Moorish constriction did rely heavily on the use of mortar, thus the smaller stones. The base of the walls are placed further away than the tops to keep siege towers from being used when attacking them. They could not get close enough to the top of the walls to lower a draw-bridge and let the attackers into the castle."

"It seems as though walls made of small stones would not be as strong as the large stone blocks that many castles are made of," offered Adiba.

"It isn't," answered Gregory.

"The Moorish builders came from places that did not have nearly as much stone as we have here. As you probably remember many of the buildings in the Levant were made of dried mud bricks, which worked very well in a land with very little rain," added Charles.

"Even when they did have enough stone for building the Arab builders were never as good at stone masonry as our order," said Gregory smiling.

"I agree," said Anthony. "You will notice that many of the critical wall sections have been redone using large, square-cut stones. That is the work of Templars and later members of the Order of Christ."

When the group crossed the bridge over the dry moat and entered the castle, Brother Anthony informed them that he would lead them to rooms along the inside of the main walls where they

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could rest. He told them that the boat that would take them to Tomar would arrive the next day and their voyage would continue.

As they dismounted Adiba noticed that her horse was holding its left front hoof off the ground. When she pointed this out to Brother Anthony, he lifted the hoof to check for a stone lodged in its quick. There was no stone but there appeared to be a thorn or piece of wood stuck in the soft tissue in the center of the hoof.

"We should have the blacksmith look at this," he said taking the reins to lead the horse to the blacksmith shop on the far side of the castle's bailey. Adiba, who felt badly about the animal being injured, went with him. Jamcela followed along. When they reached the shop and Anthony asked for the blacksmith, an assistant told him that he was not there; he was in the chapel praying for his wife who was in the midst of a difficult childbirth. He added that they had called for a local midwife to come and assist, but she was busy with another problem delivery on the other side of Lisbon.

"I am sorry to hear this," said Anthony. "Tell the smith that I will include him and his wife in my prayers."

"Perhaps my sister and I could help," offered Adiba.

Anthony and the assistant turned to look at the two women.

"We have had some training and experience in these matters," she explained. "We were raised in a harem. Our father, the Sultan, had many wives and childbirth was a common occurrence there. We watched the process often, when we were young and helped when we were older."

"I am sure they would appreciate that," said the assistant. "Let me take you to the birthing chamber."

Adiba and Jamcela quickly went back to where Charles, and Gregory were standing and told them of the situation.

"We should hurry," said Jamcela.

Nodding, the blacksmith's assistant told them to follow him. He started across the castle bailey. The sisters were close behind.

As they walked Jamcela and Adiba thought of the number of times that they had successfully assisted women in labor, including their own daughters. Though they did not consider themselves to be midwives, they knew that the experience that they

had gained as young women in the harem made them well equipped to assist in this potentially dangerous process. They were also well aware that when given the choice of being assisted by a competent midwife or a male doctor; even an Arab doctor, most women would choose the services of someone with a midwife's skills.

When they arrived at the birthing chamber, they were met by the blacksmith, who was waiting outside with one of his wife's sisters. The assistant introduced him to Adiba and Jamcela and explained that they were there to help if they could. Looking at his assistant and sister-in-law the blacksmith exclaimed, "But they are Moors!"

"Does that matter?" cried the sister, "if we don't do something, both your wife and the child will likely die."

"But they are Moors," the blacksmith repeated.

"So were the people who built this great castle," the sister cried. "Move aside and let these women help."

The blacksmith continued to look dazed and did not respond. His sister-in-law took Adiba's hand and led her and Jamcela past the blacksmith and into the room where the pregnant woman lay. She closed the door behind them leaving the smith and his assistant standing outside.

Adiba and Jamcela examined the mother to be and realized that the baby was inverted in the womb and would need to be repositioned to make a live birth possible. They had seen this situation several times before. After moving the mother and then the baby into a better position, they were able to assist in a birth that was announced by the blessed sound of a crying infant.

The news of the arrival of the blacksmith's child and how it was aided by the arrival of two Templar knights and their Arab wives, quickly spread throughout the castle. The twin sisters were greeted with smiles and offers of welcome and congratulation. When Adiba and Jamcela washed up and rejoined Charles and Gregory, it was obvious from the smiles on the men's faces that they were quite proud of their wife's abilities and willingness to assist the new mother. For Adiba and Jamcela, the approval and love of their husbands was always gratifying.

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After a hearty evening meal and a sound night's sleep the travelers were ready to continue their journey. Early the next morning, Brother Anthony and his sergeant led them back to the dock on the Lisbon Bay waterfront where a different watercraft was waiting. The boat used for this last leg of the journey to Tomar was a shallow-draft, open skiff with a single mast rigged for a lateen sail. It had two sets of oars. In many ways it looked like a much smaller version of the Spiritus Sanctus, without the raised fore and aft decks. Captain Kristopher had assigned five sergeants to crew the boat. Four took turns working the oars and trimming the sail, while the fifth managed the tiller.

For many miles heading north from Lisbon, the Tejo delta forms a wide and slow-moving bay that serves as a well-protected natural harbor. The bay has sufficient room for boats to either run with a following breeze or tack into a head wind. When there was no wind, the men at the oars rowed the craft up stream in the slow-moving waters.

The boat carrying Charles, Gregory, Adiba and Jamcela started the voyage from the Belem dock in Lisbon and sailed through the wide bay where the Tejo River entered. They sailed north-east past three small islands to Vila Franca where the Tejo narrowed where it entered the bay. It was still wide enough for easy navigation through the flat countryside. When there was no wind, the sergeants worked the oars and moved the boat along at a good pace through the flat, slow-moving waters. Charles and Gregory offered to take a turn at the oars, but the sergeants refused, insisting that the knights and their ladies were honored guests. Later in the morning the boat passed the village of Satil that sits back from the river and then on toward Santarem on the banks of the Tejo.

Shortly after noon, the travelers reached the town of Santarem where they stopped to stretch their legs and enjoy a lunch meal of bread, cheese and watered wine. Charles, Gregory, Adiba and Jamcela were surprised by how quiet the five sergeants were thus far in the journey. Jamcela asked Charles and Gregory why the knights were so outgoing and the sergeants seemed so reserved, even shy. Gregory responded that he had no idea, adding that they should not take it personally, some people are just naturally quiet.

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Charles offered that it was only some people that were quiet and reserved, smiling and looking toward Gregory. When the group had finished their lunch they climbed back in the boat, shoved off from shore and continued their voyage toward their next stop, Almourol Castle.

Chapter 48

December 1341

Almourol Castle on the Tejo River

The Tejo River near Almourol Castle was wide and slow-moving. The deciduous trees that lined both sides came all the way down to the water, the green branches shading the shore-line. The skies were a deep blue and the following breeze that seemed to be constant, in this flat terrain, moved the skiff along up stream at a steady pace.

Gregory looked over to Adiba, who was sitting on a bench next to Jamcela and noticed that she was shifting herself back and forth with a worried look on her face. He moved across the boat and sat next to her.

“Are you doing alright?” he quietly whispered to her.

“Yes,” she said looking somewhat self-conscious. “My bottom is going numb after sitting on these hard wooden benches all day.”

Gregory smiled.

“Don’t say a word,” she quietly hissed. “This is not something that I want announced to the whole crew.”

Though he loved teasing his wife, Gregory was a man who also knew when to quit.

“I’ll ask how far it is to Almourol and see if it would be alright if we stopped there for the day,” he whispered.

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As Gregory was clearing his throat to ask his question, the boat came around a shallow bend in the river and revealed a tall castle on a steep rocky island sitting near the right bank. The Tejo was almost one hundred yards wide at this point and the island less than ten yards from the right shoreline. Even for life-long warriors who had visited countless castles, Almourol was an impressive sight. The fortification sits on a mountain of rock upon which the Moors built the original structure they called Almorolan, meaning “high peak.” The impressive castle walls brought the total height from the river level to twice the elevation of the rock island.

With the river on all sides, the height of the stone mountain and the tall stone walls give first impression of a fortress that looks impregnable.

“Almourol Castle,” announced the helmsman. “We will spend the night here before continuing on tomorrow.”

Adiba smiled.

Charles asked, “Will we continue upriver tomorrow?”

“We could,” responded the helmsman, “but it is much faster to cross the river in the morning and proceed on horseback. As the crow flies, we are only a day’s ride from Tomar. If we were to stay on the river we would wind along the countryside for much longer.”

“Sooner would be better,” added Gregory, smiling. Adiba smiled and nodded.

As the boat came alongside the island, the four crewmen released the sail and manned the oars. Pulling up to a wooden dock on the river side of the island. After securing the boat, they helped their passengers ashore.

“Thank you for the pleasant boat ride,” said Charles. “Will you be going with us on horseback tomorrow?”

“No, we will be returning back down stream tomorrow morning after we take you across the river, where armed guards will be waiting for you. We will go to Lisbon and report to Captain Kristopher that we safely delivered you to Almourol.”

“I couldn’t help but notice that you and your men were very quiet and seemed rather nervous on this trip,” said Gregory, “I hope that we did nothing to offend you.”

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“No, nothing at all,” the sergeant responded, “we are trained to be most vigilant at all times. Though it was many decades ago, the events of 1307 taught us that betrayal is always possible and danger is never far away. If a pope that we lived to serve could allow us to be destroyed, there is no safety that can be absolutely assumed.”

“We understand,” said Charles, “we appreciate your taking your duties seriously.”

While the passengers were gathering their possessions on the dock, and the crew of the skiff was securing the boat for the night, a sergeant from the castle came down to the river to lead them to the fortress. Charles, Gregory, Adiba and Jamcela followed the sergeant up the roadway to the gates. They could not help but marvel at the structure before them. The stone walls on the river side of the castle were impressively tall and once they entered the castle bailey, they could see that the walls on the shore side of the structure were even higher.

Turning to the travelers, the sergeant said, “Brother Samuel, the castle commander, will meet you on the ramparts facing the river. If you follow me, I will show you the way.” After climbing up a long, steep staircase against the interior side of the castle wall, they reached the rampart where Brother Samuel awaited.

A tall, stocky, nearly bald man with a long gray beard strode over to the knights, extended his arms and hugged each of them. Turning to Adiba and Jamcela, he smiled, nodded and said, “A warm welcome to you also!”

Looking back to the knights, he added, “It is an honor to have you visit our castle. We have heard so much about you.

“Believe us, it is a pleasure to be here,” answered Gregory.

“The view from up here is spectacular,” said Adiba, “you can see forever in all directions.”

“That is by design,” said Samuel smiling, “we hate surprises and always want to know who may be coming to visit us.”

“Yes, it is wise to be vigilant,” said Charles.

“That is true” said Samuel, nodding his head, “I would like to invite all of you to dine with us this evening. I know that you are endlessly asked to tell of your experiences in Outremer, but if you

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would, we are all anxious to hear of your time there. Part of our training was to learn about the battles against the Saracens, but it would be fantastic to hear the accounts from knights who were actually there.”

“We understand,” said Gregory, “while it seems like it happened so long ago, we remember it well, perhaps too well.”

Charles nodded.

Brother Samuel excused himself and said that he had matters to attend to. He assigned another sergeant to show his guests to their quarters. After a couple of hours' rest, Charles, Gregory, Adiba and Jamcela were summoned to dinner where they were repeatedly toasted by the assembled knights and sergeants and asked endless questions about their experiences in the Levant. As Charles answered one of the knight's questions about the final days of Acre, Gregory, sitting next to him, had a moment of reflection. ‘Had any of this really happened?’ He knew that it had, but felt that if he were one of the younger knights listening this evening, he might have difficulty believing much of what he heard.. Had he not been there it might seem highly improbable. Could it all have been just one long dream?

When the dinner was over the guests retired to their cells for a much-needed rest. Early the next morning they were awakened to prepare for the last leg of their journey.

Chapter 49

December 1341

Tomar, Kingdom of Portugal

Shortly after first light, the skiff that had brought them to Almourol Castle took Charles, Gregory, Adiba and Jamcela to the far bank of the Tejo River. There they saw three mounted knights and four saddled horses waiting under the overhanging trees. The knights wore white tunics with the red cross over their chain mail coats. Each carried a white shield with the Order of Christ cross in the center. All four carried broadswords.

After again thanking the four sergeants that had brought them from Lisbon, the couples introduced themselves to their new companions, mounted their horses and started the journey to Tomar. The older looking of the three knights, who had introduced himself as Brother William, rode with Charles, on one side and Gregory on the other, followed by Adiba and Jamcela, who rode side by side. Behind them, the other two knights followed.

“I see that some things never change,” said Gregory looking at their riding order. “This is the same formation we used in Outremer and on our ride to Barcelona.”

Turning to look back at him, William smiled and responded, “Some good ideas never get old.”

“Do you typically have problems on a ride like this?” Charles asked.

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"Very seldom," responded William, "but it would be the one time that we got careless that could be dangerous. As long as there are Moors on this side of the sea, it is good to be vigilant."

"I noticed that you still carry broadswords," said William.

"Yes, they were a gift from the man who helped to make our journey possible," said Gregory smiling, "If there comes a need, we still remember how to use them."

"I am sure that you do," said William smiling.

It was a beautiful early, Spring Day for a ride across the flat country-side. The riders could see for miles and noticed a low mountain range that lay ahead of them. The sun was shining, there was a soft cool breeze and they proceeded along at a slow walking pace. After four hours of riding, William suggested that they stop for lunch and water the horses. At a small creek, they let the horses drink and then climbed to a flat area on the top of a nearby hill. There they dismounted in the shade of some large, broad-leaved trees and partook of the bread, cheese and watered wine that the knights had brought with them. During the noon meal, Jamcela asked William how much further they had to go.

"We are about halfway there," he responded. "If you keep an eye on those low mountains ahead to the north, you will eventually see our destination. Are you getting tired?"

"Oh no," she said, "only anxious to see where we will arrive after all of this travel."

"I suspect that you will be impressed, once we get there," he said smiling.

When they had finished eating, they mounted up and continued their ride. Though they did not speak, each of the four travelers wondered about the place that they had come so far to see. Charles wondered if they would seem like strangers among the order that they had not seen for so many years. Gregory thought about meeting their new Grand Master and explaining how he and Charles came to be married and have grandchildren. Adiba wondered what it would be like living in a castle with possibly hundreds of warrior monks. Would the leaders of the order even allow them to live there or must she and Jamcela go live in a convent with nuns. Jamcela had the same concerns. Would they be

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the only women in a totally male society? Would they find the answers to these questions when they arrived?

After the noon meal the travelers rode for another three and a half hours. When they emerged from a particularly dense forest of deciduous trees, they were confronted with the view of a large castle that seemed to be hanging in the air, rising above the forest canopy. Directly in front of them, they saw a narrow, slow-moving river of dark green murky water. Across the water was a small village of white-washed buildings with red tiled roofs.

"Welcome to Tomar and the Nabo River," said Brother William. "There is a place to our right where we can cross the river without getting our horse's knees wet."

As they began to wade the shallow water, William noticed the four travelers looking skyward.

"That," he said, "is the Convento do Cristo, home of the Order of Christ."

No one responded. They continued to look around in amazement as they entered the thick forest on the other side of the river. A narrow, cobblestone road, made of the same small square white stones that seemed to be used for all of the local road surfaces, climbed the hillside and wound its way toward the Convent. In the lower sections of the road the small stones were laid flat, but when the road began to climb the mountain, the stones were placed on edge with their sharp side exposed.

Seeing the puzzled look on Adiba's face, Brother William answered her question before she had a chance to ask it.

"During some times of the year it rains quite often here. When these small stones get wet, they have a tendency to become slippery, causing horses and oxen to lose their footing. This is dangerous for those on horse-back as well as those driving teams pulling heavy wagons. The stones on edge give the animals traction and keep them from slipping and falling."

"I see," said Adiba.

While they continued their ascent, the roadway curved back and forth, with sections of relatively flat road and sharp corners where the elevation changed. After the last switchback, they emerged at a road that ran next to the exterior wall of the castle.

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Ahead, it became wider and led to massive double gates in the tall stone walls. As they approached, the gates slowly swung inward, exposing a large castle bailey. Unlike the roadway the bailey surface was covered with a tan colored gravel made of grape-sized coarse stones.

When they dismounted, three sergeants came forward to take their horses and assist with their luggage. A fourth tall, stout man, wearing the white tunic of the order, walked up to Charles and Gregory and embraced each of them saying,

“Welcome home my brothers, I am, Brother Regnery, Marshal of the Order,” turning toward Adiba and Jamcela he smiled and said, “your wives are welcome as well.”

Jamcela and Adiba looked at each other and smiled, both silently sharing the same thought, ‘That answers our one important question and poses another, ‘yes, we are welcome here’ and ‘is there anything that these people do not already know?’

“The two sergeants will take care of your mounts and the third will show you to your quarters where you may rest and wash off the dust from the road. I would like you to join me for the evening meal. If that is agreeable, I will send a sergeant to summon you later this evening.”

“That would be wonderful,” said Gregory, knowing that he spoke for the others as well.

That evening Charles, Gregory, Adiba and Jamcela joined Brother Regnery at a table in the main dining hall for a meal of fresh fish, recently brought to Tomar from the coast near Nazare. It was served with vegetables grown in the Convento’s own gardens. After leading the recitation of grace before meals, Brother Regnery proposed a toast to the new arrivals, which was loudly seconded by the eighty-two knights and sergeants in attendance. Also present for the evening meal were several nuns and fifteen women, some of whom, the Marshall explained, were the wives of men, who had joined the order later in life. Others were women who worked in the convent as gardeners, cooks, maids and launderesses.

Seeing the surprised looks on his guests' faces, the Marshal went on to explain that there had been many changes in the order’s

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structure since the time when Charles and Gregory took their vows. As he spoke both Charles and Gregory thought to themselves that there were indeed many changes within the church as well and possibly several more to come given the attitudes of many of the faithful.

For Adiba and Jamcela the Marshal's words were a great relief. Not only would they not be the only women at the Convento, they would also be two of several wives in residence. They were also hopeful about the possibility of helping with the work on Convento's gardens. Growing vegetables and flowers was something that they had both always wanted to do. What they heard at dinner that first evening answered many of their questions and relieved the anxiety that all of them had about what their lives would be like in this new setting. All four came away with that haunting sensation that people sometimes experience in a new setting; when they feel that they have known these new people and this new place all their lives. It was comforting, like coming home.

Chapter 50

December 1341

Convento de Cristo, Tomar

In the days following their arrival, the couples had time to settle into their sleeping cells and explore their new environment. After months of travel and anxiety about their situation, being in a safe place, surrounded by friends, was a great relief. They knew that they were getting used to their new home when they woke up in the morning and no longer wondered where they were for the first few minutes. All four were truly touched by the warm and friendly reception they received from the castle's residents.

"It seems like everyone that we have met so far has offered to give us a tour of the castle and convent," Adiba exclaimed.

"I believe we are all impressed," said Gregory, "During our travels, I was both surprised and delighted by the reception we got from Captain Wolfgang, his crew, the Lavignes and their workers and Captain Kristopher and the men on the Spiritus Sanctus."

"Yes," Charles added, "not to mention the priests and all of the good people who supported and protected us along the way."

"I think that perhaps we have finally found a safe place that we can call home," said Jamcela.

"I believe that we have," declared Gregory, "would anyone else like to join me on the walkway along the top of the castle walls? I think we would get a nice view of Tomar and the surrounding

countryside from that height.” They all agreed and followed Gregory down the hallway from their living quarters to a spiral staircase that led to the castle wall. At the top, they walked out to the wall-walk along the inside of the outer wall. From there they had an unobstructed view of the rest of the castle, the village of Tomar and the surrounding countryside.

It was a beautiful Fall day, somewhat chilly but clear and sunny. It had rained lightly during the night, just enough to rinse the dust off the grass and tree leaves and make the greenery seem to glow. The mountain where the Convento sat and the village below were covered with several varieties of trees. There were Maritime Pines, Indian Laurels, cypress, oaks, fig and olive trees. From the village it had appeared that the castle was rising out of a dense forest. From the top of the castle wall, the village below seemed hidden in a forest.

Turning around to look back from the wall, Adiba exclaimed,

“This castle looked big from down in the village, but from up here it seems even larger.”

“It has grown to cover the entire top of this mountain,” came a voice from behind them.

Turning they saw the smiling face of Marshal Regnery coming toward them.

“I was told that I could find you here,” he said. “If you have some time, there are a few things I would like to show you.”

“That would be wonderful,” said Gregory.

“I have a question,” Charles added, “I have never seen a fortification surrounded by a thick forest like this. Doesn’t that make it hard to see attacking forces?”

“It does,” replied Regnery, “But it also makes it very difficult to bring ladders up to the walls and impossible to get anywhere near the castle with siege towers or throwing machines.”

“Has this castle ever been attacked?” asked Gregory.

“Only once,” replied Regnery, “Seventy-two years after it was constructed, it was encircled by the armies of Caliph Abu Yusuf al-Mansur who had been successful in taking several

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strongholds to the south. He was unable to capture this one. Since that time no one has even attempted to attack this fortress.”

Charles and Gregory found everything about this former Templar stronghold to be impressive both in terms of its size and beauty. Perhaps the thing that made this fortress unique in their view was the level of artistry. While most castles were designed and built to be safe, functional and secure structures, the Convento do Cristo looked more like a showcase of elaborate carving and master stone masonry. Every entry-way, every roofline, every spire and archway was covered in intricate sculpture. Gargoyles and statues of saints and biblical scenes covered the walls and rooflines.

Turning to Charles, Gregory exclaimed,

“During our years as Templars, we were no strangers to stone work and castle construction, but I do not remember ever seeing anything this ornate.”

“I agree,” marveled Charles, “what we helped to build was strictly functional. This is truly beautiful.”

“And it is never ending,” added Regnery, “the addition of new buildings and the decoration of existing structures is a constant process here. Let me show you the round Romanesque church that is currently being decorated.”

Following Regnery, the group walked down a stair case and through a doorway into a large open room. There they saw a short stairway and a wide ramp, both leading to a circular room.

“This is the round church we call the rotunda,” said Regnery, “On the outside it is a sixteen-side polygon. The octagonal structure you see, in the center, is connected by arches, to the surrounding gallery area.”

“We have seen round churches before,” said Gregory.

“I am sure you have,” replied Regnery, “I have been told that the general shape of this church is modelled after similar structures in Jerusalem, namely the Mosque of Omar and the Church of the Holy Sepulcher.”

“We have heard that also,” said Charles, “but we would have to take your word for it. By the time we arrived in Outremer the Moslems were back in control of Jerusalem and while some

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pilgrims were allowed to visit, Templars were not among those who were welcome.”

“I can imagine,” replied Regnery, smiling.

Looking to his left, Gregory asked, “Is that ramp next to the stairs for carts carrying building materials?”

Regnery smiled and shook his head. “No that is for horses. Some horses climb stairs easily, but for most, the ramp is more comfortable.”

Charles and Gregory looked shocked.

“You bring your horses to church?” Gregory asked.

“Not all of the time,” replied Regnery, “just when the knight and his Destrier are blessed before they leave for battle.”

“We remember spending the night, with our armor, stacked at the foot of the alter in our parish church the night before we took our vows,” said Charles.

“In our cases, we left our chargers outside,” added Gregory, smiling.

“Sometimes we wish we had also,” said Regnery, laughing.

As they started to walk away from the chapel, Charles turned to face Regnery.

“One of the many people who helped us flee from Avignon was a man named Adelard Lavigne. He lives in Nimes where he raises splendid horses and grows grapes for excellent wine.

“Yes, I have never met him, but I am aware of his good works,” said Regnery.

“He is the one who gave us the fine broad swords we carry,” continued Charles, “Adelard had a brother named Walkelin who was a Templar that escaped during the first suppression and fled here to Tomar. Adelard and his wife Gabrielle, have not heard from Walkelin for a while and asked us to check on him if we made it here successfully.”

“Ah yes,” said Regnery, looking somber, “Brother Walkelin became ill about six months ago and passed away. He was quite old.”

Gregory nodded and said, “Yes, we understand, we are quite old ourselves. Can we get word to his family?”

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“Yes, of course,” Regnery replied, “we will mention this when we send word to the Lavignes of your safe arrival. Now if you will excuse me, I have administrative duties that I must attend to.”

As the Marshall turned to walk away, Gregory looked at the group and asked, “Shall we continue exploring our new home?” “Smiling, they continued their walk around the castle hallways and grounds.

For the new arrivals, life in the Convento do Cristo quickly became both comfortable and interesting. The two old Templars enjoyed being reunited with older members of the original order, as well as meeting the younger monks who knew it only as the Order of Christ. The few remaining Templars their age, shared tales of their escapes from the various countries that had betrayed their Order. They all had tales of the journeys that had led them to safety in Tomar. Charles and Gregory remembered having learned, upon entering the order, that Portugal was the first country where the Templars had established a base in 1160. It seemed fitting, if not a little ironic, that it would also be the last place where Templars were safe.

Adiba and Jamcela also quickly assimilated into their new life in the Convento. Both women enjoyed the new-found freedom of living in a social setting that did not require them to cover their heads, when out in public. People could now see their long hair that over the years had turned from jet black to a beautiful shade of silver.

They also took pleasure in their interaction with the other women living in the castle. There was a tranquil sense of community among the women of Tomar that was warmer than what they had experienced in the Levant and immeasurably more pleasant than the cut-throat environment of a Sultan’s harem.

The castle grounds had several areas dedicated to growing vegetables. The temperate climate of the Tomar region was conducive to gardening during most of the year and the ladies were able to grow a variety of spices, fruits and vegetables. The pastures

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for the small number of sheep, cattle and horses that were raised on the castle grounds provided an adequate supply of fertilizer for all of the agricultural endeavors.

While Adiba and Jamcela were happy to participate in the planting and nurturing of crops for the dinner table and enjoy the interaction they had with the other women in the community, it was the opportunity to grow flowers that gave them the greatest joy. In many of the courtyards throughout the castle and convent there was a fountain in the center and beds for flowers and small trees around the perimeter. It was Adiba and Jamcela's self-appointed duty to beautify the courtyards with colorful and fragrant flowers and beautiful blossoming fruit trees.

As Captain Kristopher had told them, Charles and Gregory were eventually able to report to the Grand Master of the Order. In addition to being Grand Master, Afonso IV was the seventh king of Portugal. He was in his seventeenth year on the throne when he met with the two old Templars. In the weeks before their meeting Charles and Gregory had heard many colorful descriptions of their new leader. It was obvious that he was well thought of by the knights of the order and was referred to, by many, as Afonso the Brave. They came to learn that this moniker did not refer to Afonso's prowess in battle, but referred to what was euphemistically used to described his "marital exploits!" This revelation was always accompanied by the caveat that Afonso, who had four legitimate sons and three legitimate daughters, was unlike any of the previous Kings of Portugal. He had fathered no children out of wedlock! Charles and Gregory anxiously looked forward to what would turn out to be the first of many opportunities to meet with their new Grand Master.

When a brother came to them to tell them that Afonso wished to meet with them, they expected to hear a long list of procedures for the meeting, similar to what they were given by Ludolphus, before meeting the Pope. Though they had met several other Templar Grand Masters, they had never before met a king.

When the time came and they were brought to a courtyard in the center of the castle. Standing before Afonso, they bowed their

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heads and then knelt down on one knee. Afonso told them to stand, saying,

“That is not necessary, here we are all brothers.”

The king invited them to sit with him on one of the large stone benches at the edge of the courtyard. During this first meeting, Charles and Gregory were impressed by the fact that Afonso had taken the time to become familiar with their colorful pasts. He mentioned that he understood that service in the holy order was, for many second sons, preferable to a life of tedium in their home kingdoms. Afonso shared that although he was first born and his father’s only legitimate son, he was not his father’s favorite. He went on to describe the history of the civil wars that he had fought with his illegitimate sibling and the final resolutions of those conflicts.

Both Charles and Gregory were surprised at how willing the king was to share personal information with knights that he had just met. The source of his knowledge of their journey from Jaffa to Marseille became apparent when he mentioned his long-time friendship with Captain Wolfgang. Afonso indicated that the captain made regular voyages to Porto delivering cargo from Outremer.

Noting the surprised looks on their faces, Afonso told Charles and Gregory,

“There is very little that happens that our order is not aware of.”

Smiling at the two men Afonso added,

“Captain Wolfgang spoke highly of both of you, but he did mention that if I needed someone to shoot a crossbow, I should count on Brother Gregory.”

Charles did not know what to say and then began to laugh along with Gregory and the king.

“If I live to be a hundred, shooting the sand in front of my feet will probably be the one thing that I am most remembered for.”

As this first meeting drew to a close, Afonso turned to Gregory and asked if he would be willing to assist in the weapons training of young knights. Gregory said that he would be happy to help and asked if they had a short heavy stick that he could use as

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a teaching tool. The Grand Master smiled and said that although he was much too young to have ever met Brother Benignus, he had, on many occasions, heard stories of the legendary knight. Charles apologized for Gregory's sense of humor offering that Brother Gregory may have been hit over the head with that stick too many times, or possibly not enough times.

When their meeting was concluded and the knights were walking back to their cells, Gregory turned to Charles and said,

"What a difference it is to meet a king after meeting the Pope."

"I noticed that also," said Charles. "He seemed more like a Grand Master who happened to be a king, than a king who also served as a Grand Master. I am not sure what I expected to see in a king, but it was certainly not humility."

"Yes, he was so pleasant, even charming and we didn't even have to kiss his feet," said Gregory smiling.

Charles and Gregory had many other long discussions with, King Alfonso in his capacity as Grand Master. From the beginning, Alfonso made it clear that he was delighted to have them and their wives living with the Order of Christ in the safety of the Convent do Christo. He indicated that while it was somewhat unusual for knights of the order to be married, given their circumstances Charles, Gregory and their wives would be welcome at the Convento for the rest of their days

Over time, Alfonso shared with them the most closely guarded aspects of the order's operations. He assured them that not only had the treasury from Acre made it safely to Templar hands, but that almost the entire Templar fleet had been warned shortly before the Friday, October 13th, 1307 attacks and that eighteen ships had been able to escape with other Templar treasuries. He told them of the extensive network of Templar supporters that were secretly active in every country on the continent and that the supporters that they had met along their journey on the Way of St. James represented only a fraction of the shadow-organization that shared and supported the Templar ideals.

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In one conversation, Charles mentioned that he and Gregory were concerned that their interaction with the bishop's men at the Barcelona dock might have indicated that the network had been compromised and that the people who had been so kind to them might have been put in danger. They feared that when the bishop's men returned to Avignon and reported their failure, the bishop would turn his wrath on those poor souls. Afonso calmly assured them that the four men from the dock never reported their findings to the bishop or anyone else. They did not live to see the sunset that afternoon. The Grand Master did not elaborate, but simply went on to state that the Order had learned many hard lessons, staring that October day in 1307 and had vowed to never be suppressed again. No further explanation was necessary.

In strict confidence, the King told them of planned voyages of exploration and discovery to new worlds far to the west, previously known only to few, other than the seagoing Northmen. One purpose of these expeditions, he said, was to establish secure hiding places for the order's treasures so that they might never again be put in jeopardy. In addition, other voyages were being planned that would sail south along the west coast of the African continent, in hopes of discovering a faster route to the very profitable eastern spice trade.

During their years in Tomar, Charles and Gregory had ample opportunity to be together with their wives in the tranquil atmosphere of the Convento do Cristo. The grounds, gardens and surrounding orchards provided a peaceful setting for contemplation and reflection. As so often happens with men and women who find themselves at a stage of life, closer to death than to birth, the couples shared many conversations reflecting on their long and adventuresome lives together.

In one of these discussions, Gregory spoke of the long travels that they had experienced. He shared that during the voyage home and especially during the passage through the perilous straits, he had thought of Ulysses and the ten years that it took him to return from the Trojan War. He commented that according to Homer's

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text, Ulysses was the only member of his crew to make it all the way back.

Charles responded that he had entertained similar thoughts. He said that he often wondered if any young men who leave for war, ever manage to come all the way home. He speculated that no matter what they experienced, physically wounded or not, a little part of them died, never to return. Their optimism, their innocence and sometimes even their faith was left behind on the battlefield.

Gregory agreed and added that despite this tragedy, kings and princes continue to send young men to war. They both felt resigned that perhaps that would never change. Adiba and Jamcela smiled at their husbands and shared that they were most grateful that their husbands had survived their wartime experiences to be there with them now. They added that both of them felt more at home there at the Convento than they had at any other place, before.

Chapter 51

July 1343

Convent do Cristo

One day, almost two years after their arrival in Tomar, a sergeant came to tell Charles and Gregory that there were two visitors at the gate asking for them. Curious, they followed the sergeant to the main gate, where they found two tall, stout, bearded and darkly tanned young men smiling at them. It took both of them a moment to recognize them before Gregory laughed and shouted,

“Nicholas, Khalil!”

“Yes, you still remember us!” answered Nicholas.

“We hoped you had not forgotten us!” added Khalil.

“We could never forget you,” said Charles, “but we said goodbye to two young boys that evening in Avignon, and now we greet two handsome young men!”

“Come with us,” said Gregory. “Adiba and Jamcela will be so happy to see you and you can tell all of us how you came to be here in Tomar.

The four of them walked back to the monastery courtyard, where they found Adiba and Jamcela weeding one of their many flower beds. The two women looked up from their task, immediately set down their trowels and rushed to hug the two young men they had thought they would never see again.

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Amid tears of joy, the six of them sat at a table in the courtyard with goblets of watered wine and listened to the lad's tales of adventure sailing with Wolfgang, the captain who had brought them all from Outremer. Nicholas and Khalil told of the many new ports that they had visited, ships of pirates that they had encountered and tales of a fabled Templar fleet that some of the older sailors remembered seeing off the shores of the great ocean, west of the Pillars of Hercules.

They had decided, after hearing of Templar ships, that if they ever sailed to a port on the coast near the city of Tomar, they would try to find the people who had saved both of their lives.

During their conversations Nicholas asked, "Do you think that there any way that the two of us could sail as crew members on a Templar ship?"

Charles thought for a moment and said. "Crews on our ships are made up of Templar Sergeants and Templar Knights."

"But we could never be knights, could we?" asked Khalil.

"No," said Gregory. "Knights still have to come from noble families."

"But the ranks of the sergeants were filled by Christians in good standings, not of noble background," added Charles.

"As you know, I am not a Christian." lamented Khalil.

"Yes, but you have mentioned several times that you are more comfortable around Christians that you ever were living among your parents and bothers," stated Nicholas.

Hearing this, Gregory and Charles looked at each other.

"We could speak to the Grand Master on your behalf," offered Gregory.

Nodding Charles added, "We could vouch for your good character and inquire as to the possibility of baptism and initiation into the Order of Christ."

"I would be so happy if you would do this," cried Khalil.

"We both would," said Nicholas.

And so it came to pass that Khalil met with the priests, who determined that he was sincere in his wishes to convert. They agreed to baptize him, after religious instruction and admit him to

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the order's training program. As a part of his conversion process, Khalil was required to select a new name from the list of Christian Saints. Smiles were on the faces of the knights and their ladies as they attended the baptism of Khalil, who had chosen the Christian name, Wolfgang.

Chapter 52

August 1343

Convento do Cristo

Nicholas and the new Wolfgang's preparation for service with The Order of Christ took place at the Convento do Cristo. Their combat training was under the watchful eye of the orders' new armory instructor, Brother Gregory. In their class of fifteen novitiates, Wolfgang and Nicholas were the only ones aware of the relationship that they had with their instructor. Wolfgang was the only student of color. Arab converts to Christianity were not unheard of in the ranks of the Order of Christ, but they were still rare.

Gregory treated Wolfgang and Nicholas with the same kind, but serious demeanor that he presented to all of his students. As was the case in all of the training classes, their group was impressed by the fact that they were being taught by a legendary, battle-tested knight, one of the original Templars.

One day toward the end of their training period, Gregory had his students report to the large courtyard in full armor for realistic, but controlled combat sparing. As was quite often the case, Charles was in attendance watching as his longtime associate molded what Gregory humorously referred to as, "the next generation of holy warriors." Among the parings for these exercises was a match between Wolfgang and a candidate, Emiliano Del

Campo from the kingdom of Castile. Emiliano came from a rich and powerful family, which had imbued him with a sense of privilege and superiority, not unusual among the members of the nobility.

Contrary to Gregory's instructions Emiliano was employing tactics inappropriate for training drills that, if not used with restraint, could result in serious bodily harm. Broadwords, even when left purposely dull, for sparring drills, could inflict serious injury. Stepping between the students, Gregory ordered them to stop and led Emiliano off to the side, where he quietly reminded him of the importance of following his directions. Rather than taking Gregory's admonition gracefully, as it was intended, Emiliano choose to respond. loudly enough for all to hear,

"Why do you waste your time on that Moslem fool? He has no business being here in the first place!"

The courtyard went silent as all in attendance, including Charles awaited Gregory's reply. Gregory responded slowly.

"To begin with, I do not waste my time with any students. Secondly, this classmate you identify as a fool, saved my life many years ago in Outremer."

"The way he handles his sword, I do not see how he could even save himself," sneered Emiliano.

"He saved both Brother Charles and myself, by telling the truth at great risk to his personal safety," Gregory calmly replied.

"Did that make up for his being a Moorish dog?" asked Emiliano smiling as he looked around for support from his classmates. The look he saw on his classmates' faces was predominantly one of shock.

"It earned our respect," growled Gregory.

Emiliano looked around at his classmates. His fellow novitiates remained silent. Turning back to address Gregory he suggested,

"Perhaps you are just too old and soft to be a knight these days?"

Not a sound could be heard in the courtyard.

"Perhaps, I could show you some pointers with a sword, old man," continued Emiliano.

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Charles, his eyebrows raised, looked to Gregory.

Gregory slowly scanned the faces of his other students and then turned to face Emiliano. Looking the young man in the eyes, he slowly said,

“Please, tutor me if you will. Helmets on, shields and broad swords, center of the courtyard.”

Emiliano smiled at his classmates as he walked to the center to meet Gregory who was coming back after borrowing a sword and shield from Wolfgang. The two men stood and faced each other, donning their helmets, then taking several steps backward.

With the exuberance of youth, Emiliano immediately rushed Gregory raining down blows with his sword that Gregory deflected with his shield and sword. The old arms instructor continued to back up giving ground to the student while employing only defensive tactics.

Emiliano stopped his attack as Gregory stepped back again. Removing his helmet and catching his breath, he turned to Gregory and asked,

“Have you had enough old man?”

Walking toward Charles, Gregory softly said,

“I have had enough of that!”

Handing his helmet and shield to Charles, Gregory turned to face Emiliano, smiled and said,

“I believe that it is now time for the lesson.”

Walking up to the confused student he ordered,

“Put on your helmet.”

He had no sooner done so than Gregory swung his sword and hit Emiliano’s shield with a blow that rocked the student several steps backward. Giving him several seconds to recover he approached Emiliano who swung his sword at Gregory’s uncovered head. Gregory ducked and the blade hissed harmlessly past him. While Emiliano’s sword was extended across his body, Gregory delivered a blow to his opponents’ right hip with the flat side of his broad sword blade. The force of the blow staggered Emiliano and a collective gasp was heard from his classmates. All were aware that if the blow had been delivered with the cutting edge of even a dulled blade, the injury could have been lethal. Stepping forward as the

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student staggered backward, Gregory took advantage of the opening left by a lowered shield and delivered another flat-side blow, this time to the side of Emiliano's helmet. The student's legs buckled and he fell first to his knees and then flat on his face in the dirt and sand.

Turning to face the rest of his class, Gregory saw the entire group on their feet smiling at him, pounding their swords against their shields in salute.

When they stopped, one of their number spoke for the rest when he smiled and said,

"Brother Gregory, that was a master class in swordsmanship, but we noticed that you were not wearing your helmet."

Gregory smiled.

"That is true and I apologize for presenting a bad example, but that was not just a lesson in swordsmanship. What I hope you take away from that demonstration is to never underestimate your adversary. A smaller, older or slower man can, under the right circumstances, remove your head quickly enough to settle a contest."

Charles came walking across the courtyard toward Gregory just as two of the students were helping Emiliano to his feet. He was clearly dazed and when he removed his helmet and arming cap it was evident that he was developing a rather large swelling on the side of his head. As he looked slowly around the courtyard his classmates continued to help him remain standing.

Turning to address him Gregory said,

"Emiliano Del Campo, you could learn something from that 'Moslem fool', mainly how to respect your elders."

"And also, your betters," added Charles, chuckling.

As Charles and Gregory turned to walk away, Gregory looked at Charles and said,

"The armorer should be able to quickly pound out that dent in his helmet. The bump on his head will take little longer."

"True," said Charles smiling, "but the dent in his pride is something that his colleagues will never let him forget."

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It turned out that the humiliation that Emiliano experienced that day was indeed too much for his noble pride to handle and he quietly left Tomar and the order without completing his training.

Brother Nicholas and his Moslem brother, Wolfgang, went on to serve as Sergeants on an Order of Christ caravel that took them to places that they had never heard of, in parts of the world they never knew existed. The lessons they learned from Charles and Gregory traveled with them always.

Chapter 53

May 1348

Convento do Cristo

Seven years after the knights and their wives arrived in Tomar, the sickness known as the Black Death had worked its way across the continent from Venice to the castle in Tomar. It started in Tomar when a party of knights returned to the Convento in the Spring of 1348. Of the five men in the group, two had not been feeling well for a couple of days. Three days after their arrival it became apparent that they were suffering from a serious illness. Their traveling companions had also started to show signs of illness; fever, headaches, vomiting, dark discoloring of the skin and swollen lymph nodes. Within the week all five had perished.

Adiba and Jamcela were among the first to assist the doctors in the care of the plague's victims and among the first of the residents to become ill. Though the castle doctors warned them that it would be best to stay away from anyone infected, Charles and Gregory were with their wives, day and night doing what little they could to reduce their suffering. Like the other victims, Adiba and Jamcela developed swollen lymph nodes, ran fevers and eventually began vomiting blood. They succumbed to the disease within a matter of days. Charles and Gregory were devastated.

Since Adiba and Jamcela were not Christians, they could not be buried in the churchyard's 'consecrated ground. 'Gregory

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and Charles found a place at the edge of one of the castles beautiful orchards to bury their wives; laying them on their left sides, facing East. To their fellow brothers, it was obvious that the loss that Gregory and Charles had suffered had taken the light from their eyes.

As the unpredictable plague spread through their community, killing so much of the population, the two knights did what they could to attend to and comfort others who were sick and dying. During that time, they expected to become ill and follow their wives and the others who had perished. After most of their efforts failed, Gregory and Charles helped to bury the dead. As was sometimes the case with this mysterious and devastating disease, neither Charles nor Gregory ever became ill.

As the height of the epidemic passed, Charles and Gregory had time to reflect on their lives before, during and after their time with Adiba and Jamcela. On a sunny, spring day they sat on a stone bench in the castle courtyard when the conversation turned nostalgic.

"There are times that I cannot believe the number of changes that we have seen from the days of our youth," Gregory offered. "Perhaps everyone feels this way as they age."

"Not everyone," responded Charles. "I think of my grandfather and my father who knew only the town where they lived. In those days most people never ventured more than a days' travel from the place of their birth."

"Unlike our ancestors, we have seen half the world, we saw Jerusalem," said Gregory.

"Yes, together we saw all of the Holy Land and lived to tell about it," said Charles, laughing.

"Indeed, if you had not met me, just think of what you would have missed!" offered Gregory.

They sat for a moment, letting those thoughts sink in.

Gregory broke the silence. "In the days of my youth I anticipated living a life of quiet inconsequence. Like all younger sons from noble families, I was basically a supernumerary, on standby in the event of the demise of my older brothers. I was a

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replacement. I thought that one day I would marry, but after taking the cross, marriage no longer seemed likely.”

“I agree,” said Charles. “After a few years of serving the Order, I never seriously thought of doing anything else. I assumed that life was lived in a pattern of consistency with little or nothing significant changing; the same as it had been from generation to generation. Yes, kings died and were replaced, wars were fought and won or lost, but the basic social structure and the church that mandated its order, remained consistent.”

“The number of changes that we have personally experienced and the earth-shattering changes that we have learned of, give me pause to wonder,” added Gregory.

“I can not help but feel that the world has passed us by,” said Charles, looking out into the empty distance.

As it turned out, their observations were valid beyond their wildest imaginings. The Templar ideals that had been central to their lives, outlived all of the order’s critics and its enemies. The Templars, in the form of the Order of Christ even outlived the unified version of the church that had sought to destroy it.

It would be just over a century and a half before a German monk would nail his ideas to a church door and bring action to the long-standing concerns of multitudes that had come to believe that their church had lost its way. Some went as far as to view their pope as the Antichrist. It was a concept that had undoubtedly occurred to many Templars in the depths of the Dominican torture chambers.

Chapter 54

May 1349

Convento do Cristo

Two days less than a year after the death of their wives, Charles went to Gregory's cell in the morning to awaken him. Gregory did not respond. When Charles shook his shoulder, he found Gregory cold to the touch. He had passed in his sleep. Like Charles, he was in his seventy-eighth year. Charles sat at the foot of Gregory's bed and tried to speak to his life-long friend. Gregory appeared as tranquil and peaceful in death as he had in life. Charles could find no words. After a long while, he went to look for one of the monastery priests.

Charles assisted the priest as he administered the rites of Extreme Unction and then helped with the preparation of his friend's body for burial. Charles and forty-nine other knights dressed in full battle armor, took Gregory, on an open cart, to the ornate Church of Santa Maria do Olivél, on the east side of the Nabo river. The church grounds there had served for decades as the burial place for Knights of the Temple and later the Order of Christ. The long funeral procession included a sergeant leading a riderless destrier, also in full armor.

During the funeral Mass, the Abbot delivered a glowing testament to Brother Gregory and his exemplary service to his church, his God and his Order. Charles was asked to say a few

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words about his brother Templar. Charles stood in front of his fellow knights and struggled with the request. What could be said about a man that he had known for over a half century?

At length it came to him and he elected to relate a story from their days in the Holy Land that he felt well-illustrated the essence of this special man. He told of being on patrol along the coastal road with Gregory and eighteen other knights.

“We were all in full armor, mounted on our chargers. As we crested a hill and began our way across an open plateau, we encountered a company of mounted Arab and Mameluke warriors. It was immediately clear that we were greatly outnumbered.

In single combat a lightly-armored Arab soldier on a small Arabian horse was no match for a heavily-armored Frankish knight on a destrier. This was different. Their numerical superiority made the outcome uncertain.

As we moved into battle formation, it was apparent that several of the younger knights were anxious and uncertain as to the wisdom of engaging this numerically superior force. The line was formed with Gregory and I in the center. The other knights were on either side of us, their lances held upright in their right hands and their shields on their left arms. Looking across the flat terrain at the enemy, one of the young knights commented that there were so many more of them.

Above the noise of the anxious horses snorting and pawing the ground eager to charge the enemy, Gregory could be heard laughing out loud. “Look, there are only forty of them and they rode here to fight us this day mounted on sheep,” he shouted. “Hopefully today they won’t ride off into the desert and make us chase them.”

“Nervous laughter could be heard along the entire line. Gregory gave the order to charge and led us through them like a warm knife through butter.”

“That was Brother Gregory,” said Charles, “a kind and compassionate soul, in the body of a fierce warrior who added his calming humor to even the most dire of circumstances. In all of my life, I have never seen another like him. May the Lord grant him peace!” In unison, the knights in the chapel responded,

“Deus Volt.”

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As was the Templar tradition, Gregory was placed in the ground wrapped in a simple shroud; his arms crossed over his chest, his legs crossed and his head facing East, the direction of Jerusalem. When the dirt had covered Gregory, Charles was the last to leave the grave-site. He stood in long silence over the ground that held his lifelong companion. He had no tears left to shed.

When he returned to the castle on the hill, he walked to the orchard where he and Gregory had laid Adiba and Jamcela. Looking down, he quietly told them of Gregory's passing.

A week and a day later, Charles, once again, had the dream of the tower's collapse on that final day in Acre. He was in the tower standing with one foot on either side of his fallen companion, swinging his broad sword from side to side, when the floor suddenly fell from beneath them. In slow motion, he and Gregory tumbled toward the Outremer sand. This time he did not awaken.

About the Author

John C. Lundt was in education for thirty-six years; nine as a classroom teacher, five as a high school principal and twenty-two as a professor of Leadership and Future Studies on the Graduate Faculty at The University of Montana. He is the co-author of *Leaving School; Finding Education*, 2004. *Odyssey From Outremer* is his first historical novel. John resides in Missoula, Montana with his wife Pamela. He divides his time between travel, writing and fly fishing.